

Swarm Failover

A drone swarm that keeps flying its mission when the leader fails - simulation, tests, results, how to run everything and what is left, in one file.

Generated 29 September 2026 from the repository at `/home/saad-rafique/Documents/drone_swarm`.
Everything described here was built and tested in simulation; no real drone has flown this code.
Source documents: README.md, docs/*.md, reports/*.md. Regenerate with `scripts/make_handover_pdf.py`.

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Overview

README.MD

Swarm Failover

A drone swarm that keeps flying its mission when its leader fails, built and verified entirely in simulation. Ten PX4 quadrotors fly a V formation from home to a goal. When the leader crashes, loses its radio or runs low on battery, the next drone takes over in about two seconds and the mission continues. Every drone runs the same agent code and there is no central controller, so a drone can later move to real Pixhawk 6C hardware by changing only its connection URL.



Scope and safety. Simulation only. No code in this repository opens a serial port, connects to a real flight controller or flashes firmware, and no real drone has flown it. Payloads, targeting and anything that engages objects are out of scope.

Highlights

All numbers come from logged simulation runs; each row names the report that holds the evidence.

Area	Result	Evidence
Leader failover (fast simulator, 10 drones, 20 runs per fault type)	new leader agreed 1.64 s after the leader crashes or loses its radio (worst 1.75 s); planned low-battery handover in 0.17 s; goal reached in 100 of 100 runs	docs/RESULTS.md
Leader election under random faults	exactly one leader after convergence in 1,000 of 1,000 randomized runs with crashes, radio loss, delays and network splits; median convergence 0.145 s	reports/PHASE_2.md
PX4 formation flight	10 PX4 SIH drones with MAVROS fly a 1 km V mission in 6 of 6 runs; formation error at most 1.66 m (limit 2 m); closest pair at least 7.80 m (limit 5 m)	reports/PHASE_3.md
PX4 failover (Phase 4, passed: 55 trials)	new leader 1.4–1.7 s after the leader is killed or loses its radio (limits: 3 s median, 4 s worst); planned handover within 0.01 s (limit 1 s); formation back within 6.6 s (13.4 s after a radio split heals); closest pair at least 6.03 m; goal reached 55/55	reports/PHASE_4.md
Swarm size	1 to 100 drones in the fast simulator; after the leader is killed, a new leader is agreed in 1.60–1.75 s (median) at every size from 2 to 100; heartbeat of 45 bytes for 10 drones and 56 bytes for 100	reports/SCALING.md

Area	Result	Evidence
Obstacle avoidance	on 90 unseen courses the learned policy (10.5 h of GPU training) with a brake completes 30/30 sparse, 23/30 medium and 18/30 dense courses, against 15/30, 7/30 and 3/30 for the tuned classical controller	docs/RESUL TS.md
Real city map	3.2 km across Islamabad among 932 OpenStreetMap buildings: no drone hit anything in 10 of 10 runs, including 5 in which the leader is killed halfway	docs/RESUL TS.md
Long routes	12 km Islamabad to Rawalpindi with 2 charging stops: all 10 drones landed, no hits. Islamabad to Lahore (272.55 km, 65 stops): flown to the end, all 10 drones landed, no hits	docs/RESUL TS.md
Radio realism (Phase 5, passed: fast simulator and PX4)	no false leader change in 180 fast-simulator and 9 PX4 missions with up to 300 ms delay and 30 % loss; on PX4 a new leader took over in 1.6–2.5 s in all 9 conditions; the Phase 4 limits hold in 8 of 9 conditions in the fast simulator	reports/PH ASE_5.md
Telemetry-radio stand-in (Phase 6, passed: 22 PX4 trials)	with drone 1 behind a simulated 64 kbit/s telemetry radio, a new leader took over in 1.39–1.60 s after it was killed or its radio was cut; formation back within 6.74 s; closest pair 7.65 m; goal reached 22/22; nothing dropped for lack of room on the radio	reports/PH ASE_6.md

Project status (29 September 2026)

The software phase is complete: Phases 0 to 6 of [docs/SPECIFICATION.md](#) passed, the last on 29 September 2026. Real-drone work needs the owner's review of [docs/FLIGHT_TEST_PLAN.md](#), hardware and legal permission to fly.

Work package	Status	Report
Phase 0: environment audit, one PX4 drone	Passed	reports/PHASE_0.md
Phase 1: 10 PX4 drones on one laptop	Passed	reports/PHASE_1.md
Phase 2: agent logic, unit tests, 1,000 randomized fault runs	Passed	reports/PHASE_2.md
Phase 3: 10-drone PX4 formation flights	Passed	reports/PHASE_3.md
Scaling to 100 drones (fast simulator)	Passed	reports/SCALIN G.md
Obstacle avoidance: learned policy against a classical controller	Ahead at every density	docs/RESULTS.md
City-to-city routes with charging stops	Working; 12 km route completed end to end	docs/RESULTS.md
Islamabad to Lahore run (272.55 km, 65 charging stops)	Completed on 28 September 2026: 10/10 drones landed, 0 hits	docs/RESULTS.md
Ground-control app: 2-D map, 3-D view, fault injection, results, documents	Working	docs/RUNBOOK.md
Phase 4: fault trials on PX4	Passed: 50 trials and a clean-shell cross-check round, every limit met in every trial	reports/PHASE_4.md
Phase 5: radio realism sweep	Passed: fast simulator (540 runs) and PX4 (18 missions)	reports/PHASE_5.md
Phase 6: mixed-reality readiness and flight test plan	Passed: drone profiles, telemetry-radio stand-in, flight test plan; with drone 1 behind the radio stand-in, 22 of 22 PX4 trials met every F1 and F2 limit	reports/PHASE_6.md
Formation shapes: line abreast, column, echelon	Added and compared; experimental, because only the V stays 5 m apart after faults	docs/RESULTS.md
Long RL training on a Kaggle GPU	Done: two 10.5-hour runs; the better policy (seed 2) is in use	docs/RESULTS.md
Real drones	Never flown	—

The full history is in [CHANGELOG.md](#).

How it works

heartbeats, 5 per second, 45 bytes, between every pair of drones (in simulation through the link emulator: delay, loss, radio cut, network split)			
<-----+----->			
+-----+-----+-----+-----+	+-----+-----+-----+-----+	+-----+-----+-----+-----+	+-----+-----+-----+-----+
swarm agent 1	swarm agent 2	...	swarm agent N
election	same code on		
mission, V slot	every drone		
avoidance			
safety layer			
+-----+-----+-----+-----+	+-----+-----+-----+-----+	+-----+-----+-----+-----+	+-----+-----+-----+-----+
velocity setpoints 20 Hz; position, velocity, battery back			
+-----+-----+-----+-----+	+-----+-----+-----+-----+	+-----+-----+-----+-----+	+-----+-----+-----+-----+
MAVROS	MAVROS		MAVROS
+-----+-----+-----+-----+	+-----+-----+-----+-----+	+-----+-----+-----+-----+	+-----+-----+-----+-----+
MAVLink: UDP in simulation, serial on a real drone			
+-----+-----+-----+-----+	+-----+-----+-----+-----+	+-----+-----+-----+-----+	+-----+-----+-----+-----+
PX4 autopilot	PX4 autopilot		PX4 autopilot
(SIH simulator)	(SIH simulator)		(SIH simulator)
+-----+-----+-----+-----+	+-----+-----+-----+-----+	+-----+-----+-----+-----+	+-----+-----+-----+-----+

- **No central controller.** Every drone runs the same agent and decides its own role from the heartbeats it hears. The lowest-numbered healthy drone leads; a term counter settles conflicts, so after a network split heals there is exactly one leader again.
- **Failover.** If nobody hears the leader for 1.5 s, the next eligible drone takes over. At 30 % battery the leader hands over on purpose, leaves the formation and flies home.
- **Formation.** A V with 10 m between neighbours. Each follower copies the leader's velocity and corrects toward its slot; when a drone is lost, the drones behind it on the same arm move up. Line abreast, column and echelon are available as experimental options.
- **Safety layer.** A hard 5 m minimum distance between drones (repulsion starts at 7.5 m), a geofence around home, and an emergency landing on GPS loss or at 10 % battery.
- **One shared frame.** Each drone converts its GPS position to one East-North-Up frame; the MAVROS local frames, which start wherever each drone powered on, are never compared.
- **Obstacles.** The leader plans its route around buildings (A* search over OpenStreetMap footprints); the followers avoid obstacles with a learned policy (PPO, a 47-128-128-2 network run with numpy only) or a classical potential field, with a stopping-distance brake on top.

Details: [docs/ARCHITECTURE.md](#). The reasons behind each design choice: [docs/DECISIONS.md](#).

Getting started

Requirements: Ubuntu 24.04 with Python 3.12. The PX4 flights also need ROS 2 Jazzy, MAVROS and PX4 v1.18.0-rc1; the full installation is in [docs/RUNBOOK.md](#), section 1.

```
git clone https://github.com/saad-rafeque/drone-swarm-failover.git
cd drone-swarm-failover
sudo apt install python3-numpy python3-scipy python3-matplotlib python3-yaml python3-psutil python3-pytest python3-pytest-cov
python3 -m pytest          # the unit and integration tests; tests that need ROS 2 or PyTorch are skipped
python3 scripts/gcs.py     # the ground-control app; then open http://localhost:8080
```

The ground-control app has five pages: **Mission** (2-D map, mission setup, fault buttons), **3D view** (3-D drones over terrain and buildings, chase, orbit and top cameras), **Results**, **PX4 flights** (replay of the logged PX4 runs) and **Docs**. Satellite imagery and the 3-D view need your own Mapbox and Cesium ion tokens: copy `config/map_keys.example.yaml` to `config/map_keys.local.yaml` and paste them there. That file is ignored by git, so the keys never leave your computer.

One-click start on the development laptop: run `bash scripts/install_launcher.sh` once, then double-click **Swarm Control** in the project folder or on the desktop (or run `./start_swarm_control.sh`). Stop the app with `scripts/stop_swarm.sh`.

PX4 flights, fault trials, RL training and every other experiment: [docs/RUNBOOK.md](#).

Repository layout

```
drone-swarm-failover/
├── src/
│   ├── swarm_agent/      onboard agent: election, formation, safety, geometry, heartbeat,
│   │                   obstacles, route planner, avoiders, ROS 2 node
│   └── swarm_tools/      simulation and test tooling: PX4/MAVROS launcher, link emulator,
│                           logger, fast simulators, OpenStreetMap loader, ground-control app
├── config/               swarm.yaml (every tunable), MAVROS plugin list, map-key template
├── launch/               ROS 2 launch file: link emulator, logger, one agent per drone
├── scripts/              entry points: flights, fault trials, evaluations, training, plots, documents
├── tests/                pytest suite
├── models/              trained obstacle-avoidance policy (numpy weights)
├── data/                 cached OpenStreetMap map data (ODbL)
├── kaggle/               notebook for long RL training on a Kaggle GPU
├── docs/                 specification, architecture, runbook, results, decisions, known issues, guides, PDFs
├── reports/              phase reports, figures and the raw evidence logs
├── start_swarm_control.sh one-click start of the ground-control app
└── CHANGELOG.md          project history by milestone
```

Every folder has its own README describing its contents.

Documentation

Document	What it covers
docs/SPECIFICATION.md	The original project specification: goals, hard rules, phases and acceptance criteria
docs/ARCHITECTURE.md	How the system works, from one drone outwards
docs/RUNBOOK.md	Installation from scratch and the command for every test, experiment and document
docs/RESULTS.md	Every result with its numbers and the evidence file behind it
docs/DECISIONS.md	The design decisions and the reasons for them
docs/KNOWN_ISSUES.md	Limitations, open work and the road to real drones
docs/FUTURE_WORK.md	Future work and recommendations: one-click setup, going public, next RL run, real drones (also as docs/FUTURE_WORK.pdf)
docs/FLIGHT_TEST_PLAN.md	The plan for a first test with one real drone: roles, PX4 safety settings, go/no-go checklist, abort rules, kill switch
docs/KAGGLE_GUIDE.md	Long RL training on a Kaggle GPU, step by step (also as docs/KAGGLE_GUIDE.pdf)
docs/HANDOVER.pdf	All documents, the key figures and every phase report in one PDF
reports/README.md	Phase reports, figures and the raw logs they were computed from
CHANGELOG.md	What was done, and when

Technology

Ubuntu 24.04.5, ROS 2 Jazzy, PX4 v1.18.0-rc1 (fca3df865a , target px4_sitl_sih), MAVROS 2.15.1, Python 3.12.3, numpy 1.26.4, scipy 1.11.4. Reinforcement learning: PyTorch 2.14.0 (CPU), Stable-Baselines3 2.9.0, Gymnasium 1.3.0. Ground-control app: Python standard-library HTTP server, Leaflet and CesiumJS 1.145 in the browser. Development machine: Intel i3-1115G4 (2 cores, 4 threads), 8 GB RAM, no GPU.

Roadmap

1. Keep drones apart when they cannot hear each other; give followers a way out of dead ends at buildings; slot-change rules that make the line, column and echelon as safe as the V.
2. Dense clutter: a changed RL training set-up (learning-rate decay, more dense courses, real-map training areas, the brake inside training); more hours with the current settings no longer help.
3. Real drones: a companion computer on every Pixhawk 6C, a radio bridge for the heartbeats, a stable PX4 release, bench tests, then the first flight by [docs/FLIGHT_TEST_PLAN.md](#), after legal permission.

The complete list with evidence and effort estimates: [docs/KNOWN_ISSUES.md](#). Recommendations, including a one-click setup for people who copy the repository: [docs/FUTURE_WORK.md](#).

Credits and licence

PX4 Autopilot, MAVROS and ROS 2 are used as published by their projects and are not part of this repository. Map data © OpenStreetMap contributors (ODbL). Satellite imagery © Mapbox, © Maxar, or Esri World Imagery. 3-D terrain, buildings and photorealistic tiles through Cesium ion. Every result comes from logged runs in [reports/](#).

This is a private repository. No licence has been chosen yet, so all rights are reserved by the owner.

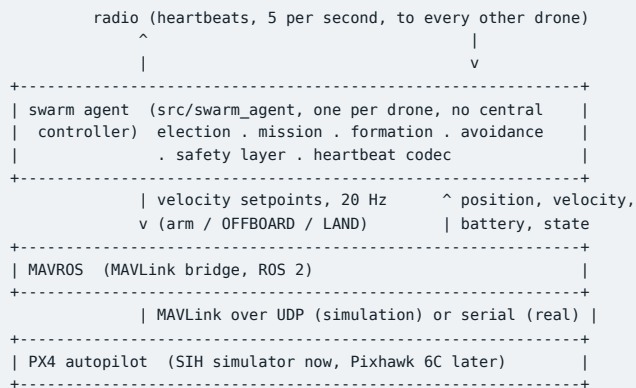
Architecture

DOCS/ARCHITECTURE.MD

Architecture

This document explains the system from the drone outwards. File names point at the code; every tunable number lives in `config/swarm.yaml`.

1. One drone



- The agent logic is plain Python (`agent_core.py` and the modules it uses). The same class runs inside the ROS 2 node (`ros_node.py`, one per drone in namespace `/uavN`) and inside the fast simulator (`swarm_tools/puresim.py`).
- MAVROS runs with a lean plugin list (`config/mavros_pluginlists.yaml`: `sys_status`, `sys_time`, `command`, `local_position`, `global_position`, `setpoint_velocity`) and per-namespace remaps of `/tf`, `/tf_static` and `/parameter_events`; the default plugin set made CPU grow with the square of the drone count (Phase 1).
- Moving a drone to real hardware changes its MAVROS connection URL (UDP -> serial) and replaces the radio emulator by a real radio link. The agent code stays the same.

2. Positions: one shared frame

Every drone converts its own latitude/longitude/altitude to one shared East-North-Up frame anchored at `config.origin` (WGS-84 -> ECEF -> ENU, `geometry.EnuFrame`). Drones never compare their MAVROS local frames, which each start at their own power-on point. On long routes the ground falls below the tangent plane (about 5.7 km at 270 km), so positions are converted back with `EnuFrame.surface_point`, which puts them on the ground (without it they would be ~240 m off).

3. Heartbeat

Each drone broadcasts a heartbeat 5 times a second (`heartbeat.py`, codec version 2): id, role, term, mission phase, leader id, handover target, flags (MASTER_OK, READY, ELIGIBLE, ORPHAN, AIRBORNE), battery, position, velocity, formation heading, time stamp, and - from the leader - the list of members it hears as a bit mask. A fixed 43-byte header plus only as many mask bytes as the highest ID needs: 45 bytes for 10 drones, 56 for 100, up to ID 250 (PX4's `MAV_SYS_ID` limit). In simulation the heartbeats go through `link_emulator.py`, which can add delay, jitter, loss, cut a drone's transmitter or split the swarm into groups.

4. Choosing the leader (`election.py`)

- The lowest-numbered alive and eligible drone leads. Eligible: position valid, battery above the handover level (30 %), not retired.
- Every leader claim increases a `term` number. A leader that hears another leader with a higher term (or the same term and a lower ID) steps down, so after a radio split heals there is exactly one leader again.
- If nobody hears the leader for 1.5 s, the next eligible drone claims - but only if no other drone still hears a leader (MASTER_OK flag) and no lower eligible ID is alive. No pre-emption: a recovered lower ID does not take the job back.
- At startup drones listen first and the first election waits until the whole fleet is heard (or a timeout), so the intended leader is not beaten by a drone that booted earlier.
- A leader at 30 % battery names a successor (planned handover), leaves the formation and flies home.
- While no leader is known, drones hover.

5. Mission (`agent_core.py`)

The leader runs the mission and every follower copies its phase from the heartbeat: IDLE -> TAKEOFF (whole fleet ready) -> CRUISE -> HOLD (10 s at the goal) -> LAND. On long routes: at each charging stop LAND -> CHARGE (on the ground until every battery is ~95 %) -> TAKEOFF (vertically where each drone stands) -> CRUISE again. In open sky the leader flies a straight leg to the goal (fixed heading plus a cross-track correction) with a speed ramp; with obstacles it follows the planned route (pure pursuit), turning the formation heading at most 20 degrees per second.

6. Formation (`formation.py`)

- Shape set by `formation.shape`: the V (the default, and the only shape used in Phases 0-5), or the experimental line abreast, column and echelon (section 12).

- V formation, 10 m between neighbours, 45 degree arms. Even IDs fly the left arm, odd IDs the right, in ID order ("parity arms"), so losing a drone only slides the drones behind it on the same arm.
- Follower command = leader velocity (feed-forward) + P-control toward its slot, saturated at 3 m/s.
- The leader's heartbeat lists its members; a drone the leader cannot hear is an "orphan" and flies 8 m higher behind its arm. Moves longer than 12 m happen 6 m below the formation ("transit layer") so crossing paths are vertically separated.

7. Safety layer (every command, every drone)

- Repulsion from any drone closer than 7.5 m (1.5 x the 5 m minimum), including drones that just went silent ("ghosts", extrapolated for 3 s).
- Geofence: no motion outward beyond radius - margin, capped altitude.
- Emergencies: GPS lost or battery at 10 % -> hand over, drop below the formation while keeping its speed (so the drones behind pass over it), land where it is. On long routes a low battery also lands in place (home may be far behind).

8. Obstacles and avoidance

- `obstacles.py`: 2-D obstacle map at flight height: building footprints (polygons) and trees (circles) with a grid index; 24-ray range "sensor", nearest obstacle point, clearance, occupancy.
- `planner.py`: the leader's route by A* on an inflated grid (8 m clearance) with line-of-sight shortcuts; long routes chunk by chunk; charging stops in open spots about every half battery.
- `avoidance.py`: followers add a horizontal correction from an avoider, then the safety layer:
- none;
- classical: potential field (repulsion from the nearest obstacle point, sliding, a tangential push) plus a stopping-distance brake, tuned on training scenarios;
- learned: a small neural network (2 x 128, tanh) trained with PPO, run with numpy only;
- learned + brake: the network's command passed through the same brake. All avoiders see the same input: desired velocity, own velocity, slot error, 24 range readings, the nearest obstacle point, the three nearest drones. The avoider runs at 10 Hz.
- Map data: `swarm_tools/osm.py` downloads buildings, woods and trees from OpenStreetMap (Overpass API) and caches them in `data/osm/`. Flight height decides what is an obstacle: low (16 m) - every building and wood; normal (30 m) - only structures of 25 m or more (OSM height or storeys).

9. Simulators

Simulator	What it runs	Used for
PX4 SIH + MAVROS (<code>swarm_tools/sim_launch.py</code>)	the real autopilot firmware, simple physics	Phases 0-3: real flights of up to 10 drones
Fast simulator (<code>swarm_tools/puresim.py</code>)	the real agent code, point-mass physics, simulated radio	1,000-run tests, scaling, the ground-control app
Obstacle simulator (<code>swarm_tools/obstacle_sim.py</code>)	numpy formation-through-obstacles	RL training (CPU) and the fair comparison
Batched simulator (<code>swarm_tools/torch_sim.py</code>)	the obstacle simulator on a GPU, 1024 missions at once	long RL training on Kaggle

The obstacle simulator re-implements the follower law and repulsion in numpy; tests check it against the agent code (`tests/test_avoidance.py`), and the batched version is checked step by step against the numpy one (`tests/test_torch_sim.py`).

10. Ground-control app (`swarm_tools/gcs/`)

`fastsim_backend.py` runs the fast simulator in a background thread (1x to Max) and turns its state into latitude/longitude; `server.py` (standard library HTTP server on 127.0.0.1) streams a snapshot every 100 ms (Server-Sent Events) and accepts commands (start, pause, speed, faults, radio split). Pages in `static/`: Mission (Leaflet map), 3D view (CesiumJS), Results, Docs. Slow preparation (map downloads, long-route planning) runs in a background thread with progress on the page.

- **3D view** (`static/3d.html`, `static/view3d.js`): every drone is a small 3-D quadcopter (`static/drone.glb`, generated by `scripts/make_drone_model.py` - no outside model files) whose white body is tinted by role. Snapshots arrive every 100 ms; each drone glides from where it is drawn to its newest position over one snapshot interval, so the motion is smooth (about 0.1 s behind the simulation). The simulators have flat ground, so each drone is drawn at its simulated height above the terrain under it; a drone appears only once that terrain height is known. V lines join the leader to the followers behind it on each side. In the Chase, Orbit and Top modes the camera is placed every frame around the leader and the followers in its formation, and lifts itself when it would go below the terrain.
- **Takeover timing**: when a fault hits the leader (a fault button, a crash, an empty battery), the backend remembers when; the next "became master" event says how many seconds later the new leader took over (for example 1.5 s after a crash, 0.1 s after a planned handover).
- **Without the browser**: `scripts/run_route.py` drives the same backend step by step and writes a JSON record (events, progress, formation error and closest pair while cruising); the long-route evidence in `reports/logs/long_route/` comes from it.
- **One-click start**: `scripts/start_swarm.sh` starts `scripts/gcs.py` in the background if it is not already running and opens the browser. The **Swarm Control** program in the project folder (`scripts/launcher.c`), `start_swarm_control.sh` and the desktop icon all call it.

11. Where to change things

To change	Edit
spacing, speeds, gains, timeouts, battery levels, geofence	<code>config/swarm.yaml</code>
election rules	<code>src/swarm_agent/election.py</code> (+ <code>tests/test_election.py</code>)
formation shape	<code>config/swarm.yaml</code> <code>formation.shape</code> (V; line, column and echelon are experimental); geometry in <code>src/swarm_agent/formation.py</code>
which drones are simulated, behind the radio stand-in, or real	<code>config/profiles/*.yaml</code> (check with <code>scripts/check_profile.py</code>)
what counts as an obstacle, flight heights	<code>src/swarm_tools/osm.py</code> , <code>gcs/fastsim_backend.py</code>

To change	Edit
the avoider used by the app	<code>models/avoid_policy.npz</code> (RL) or <code>PotentialField</code> parameters
the 3-D view (drone look, cameras, colours)	<code>src/swarm_tools/gcs/static/view3d.js</code> , <code>3d.html</code> ; the model: <code>scripts/make_drone_model.py</code>
reward / training	<code>src/swarm_tools/obstacle_sim.py</code> , <code>scripts/rl_train.py</code> , <code>scripts/rl_train_gpu.py</code>

12. Formation shapes, profiles and the radio stand-in (28 September 2026)

- **Shapes.** All shapes use the same slot model (two arms by ID parity, a row per arm). Line abreast puts the arms side by side with the leader in the middle; column and echelon interleave the two arms into one line (left row r is place $2r-1$, right row r is place $2r$), straight behind the leader or on a diagonal to its right. The rules for moving to new slots after a loss are the V's, and they are not safe for the other shapes after the leader is lost or a radio split heals (`docs/RESULTS.md`, formation shapes).
- **Profiles** (`src/swarm_tools/profiles.py`, `config/profiles/`). For every drone: `sim` (PX4 SIH, MAVROS over UDP), `standin` (the same behind the radio stand-in) or `real` (a MAVROS serial URL, checked as text only). `SimLauncher` starts a profile's stand-in relays and refuses any profile with a real drone, so the simulation tools can never reach hardware.
- **Radio stand-in** (`src/swarm_tools/radio_proxy.py`). PX4 instance i sends to $14540+i$, where the relay listens instead of MAVROS; MAVROS binds $15540+i$ and sends to the relay at $15580+i$; the relay forwards to PX4 at $14580+i$. Every packet shares one channel at the usable SiK rate (64 kbit/s air rate, halved by error correction), waits up to 131 ms for its transmit turn when the channel is idle, is lost with 1 % probability, and is dropped when it would wait more than 1 s. Link statistics go to `proc_logs/radio_standin_<id>.json` in the run folder.

Results

DOCS/RESULTS.MD

Results

Everything here is simulation. Each number points at the file it came from.

PX4 autopilot in simulation (SIH + MAVROS, this laptop)

What	Result	Evidence
One drone: arm, climb to 10 m, hover 20 s, land	passed twice; 135 MB RAM for PX4 + MAVROS	reports/PHASE_0.md
10 drones: all arm, climb to 10 m, hover 30 s, land	passed (also from a clean shell); 1,074 MB RAM (107 MB per drone), 76.5 % CPU during hover	reports/PHASE_1.md
10 drones fly a 1 km V mission and land (6 runs)	formation RMS max 1.24-1.66 m (limit 2), mean 0.54-0.62 m; closest pair 7.80-8.65 m (limit 5); leader lands 1.1-1.7 m from the goal	reports/PHASE_3.md, reports/phase3_mission.png

Agent logic (fast simulator, real agent code)

What	Result	Evidence
Unit tests	131 pass, 4 skipped without ROS / PyTorch (with PyTorch: 134 pass, 2 skipped)	python3 -m pytest
1,000 random runs with crashes, radio loss, delays and splits	exactly one leader after convergence in 1,000 of 1,000; median convergence 0.145 s after the last fault (p95 2.12 s, max 2.72 s)	reports/PHASE_2.md
Known weak spot	143 of those 1,000 runs had two drones closer than 5 m; every one contained a random radio split or random link drops (drones that cannot hear each other cannot be pushed apart)	reports/PHASE_2.md

Fault types, 10 drones, 20 runs each (fast simulator). On PX4, Phase 4 passed on 28 September 2026 (reports/PHASE_4.md). All 55 trials (10 per fault plus a clean-shell cross-check round) met every limit: - new leader in 1.4–1.7 s; - planned handover within 0.01 s; - formation back within 6.6 s (13.4 s after a healed split); - closest pair 6.03 m or more; - goal reached 55 of 55.

The fast-simulator results:

Fault	New leader agreed (median / worst)	Formation back under 2 m	Closest pair	Goal reached
F1 leader killed	1.64 / 1.75 s	4.55 / 4.68 s	9.35 m	20/20
F2 leader's radio lost	1.64 / 1.75 s	4.55 / 4.68 s	8.23 m	20/20
F3 leader low battery (planned handover)	0.17 / 0.20 s	3.14 / 3.23 s	9.35 m	20/20
F4 follower killed	no leader change	1.12 / 1.15 s	7.46 m	20/20
F5 radio split, then healed	0.18 / 0.25 s after the heal	9.93 / 13.75 s	6.23 m	20/20

Swarm size (fast simulator, leader killed at 90 s, 3 runs per size)

Drones	New leader	Formation back	Closest pair	All landed	Simulator speed	Heartbeat
2	1.60 s	-	10.0 m	3/3	1,506x real time	44 B
10	1.70 s	4.50 s	9.49 m	3/3	162x	45 B
50	1.75 s	4.95 s	9.49 m	3/3	11x	50 B
100	1.75 s	8.75 s	9.49 m	3/3	2.9x	56 B

With 10 % message loss, 150 ms delay and wind-like drift, 100 drones: new leader in 2.75 s median (worst 2.95 s), never two leaders at once, closest pair 8.14 m, all landed. Evidence: reports/SCALING.md, reports/logs/scaling/.

Radio sweep (Phase 5, fast simulator)

Heartbeat delay 50 / 150 / 300 ms x loss 0 / 10 / 30 % (no jitter), 10 drones; per condition 20 missions without a fault, 20 with the leader killed (F1) and 20 with its radio cut (F2): 540 runs.

- **No false leader change** in any of the 180 missions without a fault, even at 30 % loss.
- **The Phase 4 limits hold in 8 of 9 conditions**, the worst being 300 ms with 10 % loss (new leader median 2.65 s, worst 3.09 s) and 150 ms with 30 % loss (2.59 s / 3.27 s). At 300 ms with 30 % loss the median time to a new leader is 3.06 s against the 3.0 s limit (worst 3.80 s, within 4.0 s).
- Formation back under 2 m within 9.47 s in every run (limit 15 s); closest pair 6.44 m or more; every mission reached the goal.
- **On PX4** (18 missions with 10 drones, one without a fault and one with the leader killed per condition):
 - no false leader change;
 - a new leader in 1.59–2.48 s in all nine conditions, including 300 ms with 30 % loss (2.30 s);
 - formation back within 6.84 s, closest pair 6.89 m or more, every goal reached.

Evidence: reports/PHASE_5.md, reports/logs/phase_5_fastsim/ (summary.md, summary.json, radio_sweep.jsonl), reports/logs/phase_5/ (PX4 runs, phase5_px4_table.md), reports/phase5_radio_sweep.png.

Formation shapes (fast simulator)

Four shapes with the same agent code, 10 drones, clean radio, 10 runs each of: no fault, F1 (leader killed), F4 (follower killed), F5 (radio split, then healed).

Shape	Formation back after F1, median (s)	After F5, worst (s)	Fault runs closer than 5 m	Closest pair (m)	Goal
V	4.47	12.20	0 of 30	6.17	40/40
Line abreast	4.71	12.45	8 of 30	0.57	40/40
Column	25.62	20.95	20 of 30	4.59	40/40
Echelon (right)	11.27	19.90	20 of 30	4.60	40/40

In normal flight every shape holds its slots equally well (formation error 0.02 m mean), and losing a follower (F4) is handled the same way. After the leader is lost or a radio split heals, only the V keeps every pair at 5 m or more: the rules that move drones to their new slots were designed for the V. In a line abreast, drones slide sideways past each other at the same height (8 of 10 F5 runs under 5 m, worst 0.57 m); in a column or echelon, moves along the line come to about 4.6 m and take up to 21 s. **The V stays the default**; the other shapes are available (`formation.shape`, and the Formation menu of the app) but marked experimental. Evidence: `reports/logs/formations/ (summary.md, runs.jsonl)`, `reports/formation_shapes.png`.

Obstacle avoidance: learned policy vs classical

Fair comparison: 90 courses never used in training or model selection (30 per density), 10 drones, every method on the same courses with the same wind-like drift. Success = no drone hits anything and the whole V re-forms at the target. Classical = potential field + stopping-distance brake, tuned on training courses. RL = the policy in use (`models/avoid_policy.npz`): PPO on a Kaggle T4 GPU, seed 2, 5.84 billion steps in 10.5 hours, best checkpoint on the validation courses.

Method	Few obstacles	Medium	Dense	Crashes per mission (medium)	Drones left behind (medium)
No avoidance	3/30	0/30	0/30	6.30	0.00
Brake only	8/30	3/30	0/30	2.63	0.80
Classical	15/30	7/30	3/30	0.57	1.20
RL	28/30	19/30	11/30	0.67	0.00
RL + brake	30/30	23/30	18/30	0.23	0.10

Paired on the same courses, RL + brake against classical: few obstacles 14 courses only RL + brake completed vs 1 only classical (exact McNemar $p = 0.001$); medium 13 vs 1 ($p = 0.002$); dense 9 vs 1 ($p = 0.021$). RL + brake is now clearly better at every density, dense clutter included. The classical controller let drones come as close as 0.88-2.04 m to each other; RL + brake 2.88 m (dense) to 4.47 m. Evidence: the laptop re-test `reports/logs/rl/eval_kaggle_check/ (summary.md, summary.json, episodes.jsonl, comparison.png)`, tuning `reports/logs/rl/apf_tuning.jsonl`, training `reports/logs/rl/kaggle_seed2/`, `reports/rl_training_kaggle_seed2.png`.

Training runs compared (the same 90 courses)

Policy	Training	RL + brake: few / medium / dense	RL alone: few / medium / dense
Laptop (<code>models/avoid_policy_run1.npz</code>)	6 million steps, 38 min on the laptop CPU	26 / 18 / 5	13 / 7 / 1
Kaggle seed 1	5.50 billion steps, 10.5 h on a T4 GPU	27 / 18 / 14	26 / 15 / 4
Kaggle seed 2 (in use)	5.84 billion steps, 10.5 h on a T4 GPU	30 / 23 / 18	28 / 19 / 11

- The two seeds are independent runs with the same settings; seed 2 is better on every count.
- The laptop re-test gave exactly Kaggle's RL numbers for seed 2. Kaggle's own classical row is not usable: its upload lacked the tuning file, so it ran untuned (`eval_kaggle_seed*/`, "APF {}").
- **More hours alone will not help.** The validation score of both runs rose for about 2.5 hours and then only went up and down (seed 1 best 51 of 90 at 2.5 h; seed 2 best 63 of 90 at 6.5 h, 62 already at 2.5 h). A next run needs a changed set-up, for example learning-rate decay or more dense courses.
- Rules for choosing (`docs/KAGGLE_GUIDE.md`, section 8): seed 2 has at least as many successes at every density, fewer crashes, and 0 hits on the real map. Seed 1 failed the last rule (1 hit).

What it means: the long GPU training made the policy much better, most of all in dense clutter (5 to 18 of 30 with the brake, 1 to 11 without). Dense clutter is still the hardest case: 12 of 30 dense missions still fail.

On the real map, with the full agent code

F-9 Park to Faisal Mosque, Islamabad (3.2 km; 932 buildings and 26 woods from OpenStreetMap, low flight height so all of them are obstacles), 10 drones, 5 runs with drift; in the second set the leader is killed halfway. Drones that hit something over 5 runs / runs with no hit:

Method	Leader alive	Leader killed halfway
No avoidance	45 / 0 of 5	40 / 0 of 5
Classical (tuned)	10 / 1 of 5	8 / 0 of 5
Classical (default settings)	3 / 2 of 5, but many drones left far behind (formation error ~240 m)	3 / 3 of 5, same caveat
RL	13 / 0 of 5	12 / 0 of 5
RL + brake	0 / 5 of 5	0 / 5 of 5

Every mission completed; after the leader was killed a new leader was agreed in 1.50-1.65 s. The avoider runs 10 times a second, the rate the policy was trained at. Evidence: `reports/logs/rl/route_eval_kaggle_check/`. Compared with the laptop policy (`reports/logs/rl/route_eval_10hz/`): RL alone hit much less (13 and 12 against 20 and 18), and RL + brake had 0 hits in both. **One caveat**: with the new policy two drones came to 4.77 m of each other once on this route (laptop policy: 5.07 m). It is below the 5 m limit, so check it before this policy flies near real drones. The first run of 26 September (avoider every 0.05 s, laptop policy) is kept in `reports/logs/rl/route_eval/`.

Long routes

Route	Setup	Result
Islamabad F-9 Park -> Rawalpindi Saddar (33.5973, 73.0479), 12.01 km	normal height (30 m; the 266 OSM buildings and woods are all below 25 m), RL + brake, 2 charging stops	10/10 drones landed at the target after 2,795 simulated seconds, no hits, both stops used; formation error while cruising max 1.42 m (mean 0.93 m); closest pair 8.53 m
same route	low height (16 m; all 253 buildings and 13 woods are obstacles), RL + brake, 3 stops	leader route 13.51 km around them; mission completed after 3,131 s; drones 7, 9 and 10 hit buildings (7 of 10 landed); closest pair 5.67 m
Islamabad -> Lahore, 272.55 km	normal height, 38 buildings of 25 m or more from OSM, RL + brake, 65 charging stops	flown to the end on 28 September 2026: all 10 drones landed in Lahore after 64,988 simulated seconds (18 h 03 min), all 65 stops used, no hits; formation error while cruising mean 1.40 m, with one episode up to 201 m (drone 9 held at a tall building for about 2 minutes, below); closest pair 5.49 m

Both 12 km runs were repeated on 27 September 2026 with the current code (`scripts/run_route.py`) and gave the same outcome as the first runs of 26 September (2,794.6 s and 10 landed; 3 hits by the same three drones). At 16 m the three drones that crashed had first got stuck about 1.5 m from a wall, crawling at 0.5-3 m/s and falling 100-1,250 m behind the formation, before they hit that building; this is why the formation error while cruising was above 50 m for 446 of 2,704 s (mean 47 m, max 534 m) although the rest of the V held. Evidence: `reports/logs/long_route/rawalpindi_12km_auto.json`, `rawalpindi_12km_low.json`.

Islamabad -> Lahore, flown to the end (28 September 2026)

Set-up: 10 drones from F-9 Park, Islamabad (33.7036, 73.0231) to Lahore (31.5204, 74.3587), seed 1, 5 m/s, battery endurance 25 min, flight height "auto" (normal, 30 m on a route this long), avoidance RL + brake. Map data: OpenStreetMap buildings of 25 m or more along the route, downloaded in 14 boxes of 20 km with the light "tall buildings only" query: 38 buildings are in the way, 680 lower ones are flown over. Leader route 272.58 km around them; 65 charging stops about every 4.1 km (half a battery per leg, 3-minute battery swap).

Simulated time	Stops used	Drones landed in Lahore	Obstacle hits	Formation error while cruising	Closest pair
64,987.6 s (18 h 03 min)	65 of 65	10 of 10	0	mean 1.40 m; above 2 m for 295 s in total; max 201.3 m	5.49 m

Drone 1 led the whole way. The run took 24 minutes on the laptop (45x real time, with other jobs running; the first run the same morning took 19 minutes at 57x and gave the same outcome and the same events, as the fast simulator is repeatable).

The 201 m episode, explained. About 90 s after the swarm left charging stop 5 ($t = 5,036$ s), a tall building beside the route pushed drone 9 more than 12 m from its slot, so it dropped to the 24 m crossing layer - still below the top of the building - and was held 1.4-1.7 m from the wall, almost stopped, for about 115 s while the V flew on. At the worst moment ($t = 5,150$ s) it was 599 m from its slot. It then got free, caught up at 10 m/s and was back in its slot at $t = 5,271$ s, without a hit. This is the dead-end weakness of the followers' avoider (`docs/KNOWN_ISSUES.md`), seen until now only when flying low. A second, shorter episode on the last leg ($t = 64,690$ - $64,731$ s, max 43 m) was not analysed. Evidence: `reports/logs/long_route/lahore_full.json` (whole run: events, progress every 1,000 s, the episodes above 10 m), `lahore_full_stop5_detail.json` (every follower every 5 s from 5,000 to 5,300 s, recorded by replaying the mission with `scripts/route_window.py`).

The earlier run in the app on 26 September 2026 was stopped on purpose after 76.0 km (18 of 65 stops, 10/10 flying, 0 hits); its record is `reports/logs/long_route/lahore_stopped_2026-09-26.json`.

Hardware readiness (Phase 6, software only)

- **Drone profiles** (`config/profiles/`): `sim.yaml`, `standin.yaml` (drone 1 behind the radio stand-in) and `mixed.yaml` (drone 1 real, through a serial URL placeholder). `scripts/check_profile.py` checks them; a real drone is checked as text only, and the simulation tools refuse to start a profile that has one (`tests/test_profiles.py`, 12 tests).
- **Telemetry-radio stand-in** (`src/swarm_tools/radio_proxy.py`): a relay between one drone's PX4 and MAVROS with SiK defaults - 64 kbit/s air rate halved by error correction to 32 kbit/s shared by both directions, transmit turns of up to 131 ms, 1 % loss, a 1 s buffer. Its tests (`tests/test_radio_proxy.py`, 6 tests) measure the rate (2,000 bytes delivered in 0.45-0.75 s), the shared channel, the turn wait, loss and the full buffer with local sockets.
- **The PX4 stand-in test** (F1 and F2 with drone 1 behind the stand-in): the first four runs failed because the simulated autopilot flooded the radio, 1.7-3.9 times its capacity.
- The radio drone is now set up like a real telemetry port: PX4 Minimal mode at 1,200 B/s, the agent asking for position at 5 Hz, and 1 s allowed without autopilot data.
- The 22 acceptance trials then passed, 29 September 2026 (`reports/PHASE_6.md`):
 - New leader: F1 median 1.51 s, worst 1.60 s; F2 median 1.46 s, worst 1.52 s (limits 3 / 4 s).
 - Formation below 2 m within 6.74 s (limit 15 s); closest pair 7.65 m; goal reached 22 of 22.
 - Radio: 180,937 packets, none dropped for lack of room, 1.15 % lost, mean delay 68-84 ms.
- **Flight test plan:** `docs/FLIGHT_TEST_PLAN.md` (one real drone with simulated ones; PX4 safety parameters checked in the PX4 source; go/no-go checklist; abort criteria; kill-switch procedure).

Ground-control app

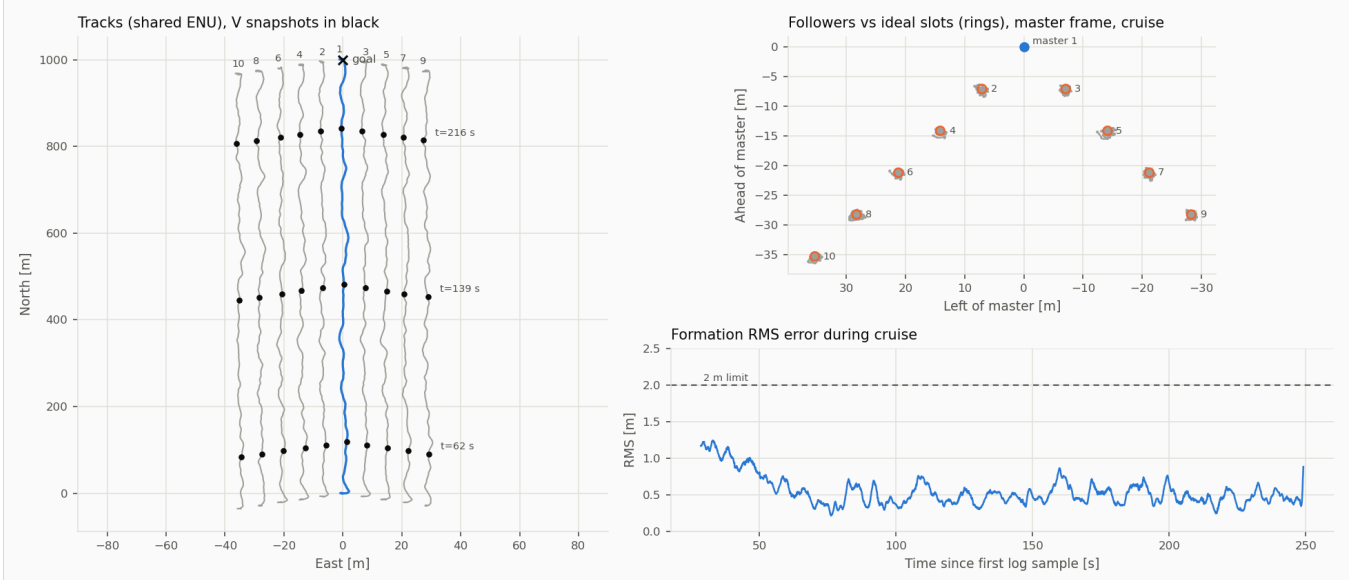
Live 2-D map (Mapbox or Esri satellite, OSM streets), 3-D view (Cesium terrain, OpenStreetMap 3-D buildings or Google photorealistic tiles, 3-D drone models with smooth motion, V-formation lines, trails, chase / orbit / top / free cameras, fault buttons and event banners), real GPS home and target, 1-100 drones, 8 fault types per drone, radio split, speed 1x-Max, obstacle maps and charging stops on the map, results and documents inside the app. When a new leader takes over, the event log says how long after the fault it happened (for example "Drone 2 became master (term 2, election), 1.5 s after the fault on drone 1"; checked by `tests/test_gcs_backend.py`).

Key figures



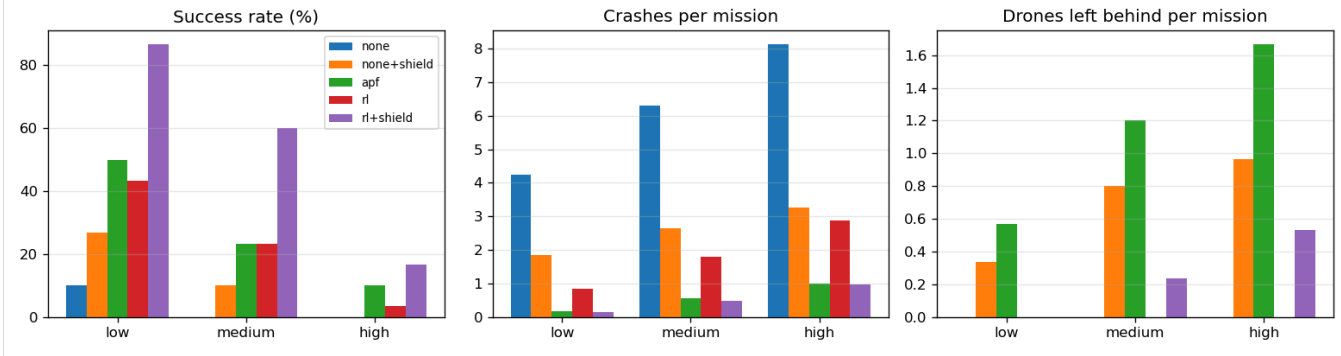
The 3D view of the ground-control app: ten drones in V formation over F-9 Park, Islamabad (Chase camera, 27 September 2026). Leader 1 has the blue ring; V lines, height lines and short trails; red = OpenStreetMap buildings that are obstacles at 16 m, green = woods, yellow = the leader's planned route to Faisal Mosque.

10 PX4 drones, 1 km V mission (cross-check run 2)



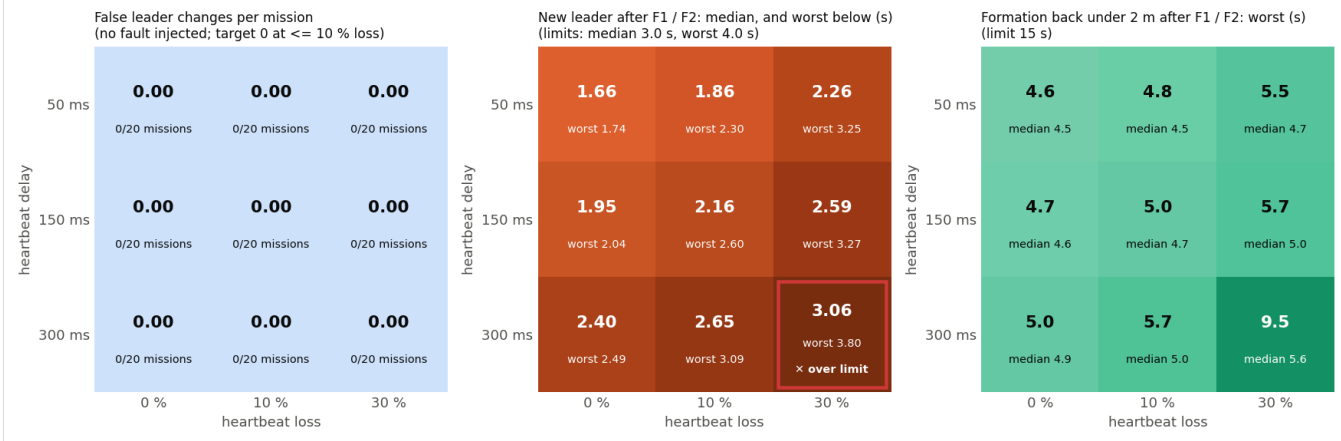
Ten PX4 drones fly a 1 km V mission: tracks with V snapshots, every follower against its ideal slot, formation error over time (Phase 3, cross-check run 2).

Obstacle avoidance in formation, 10 drones, 30 held-out routes per level



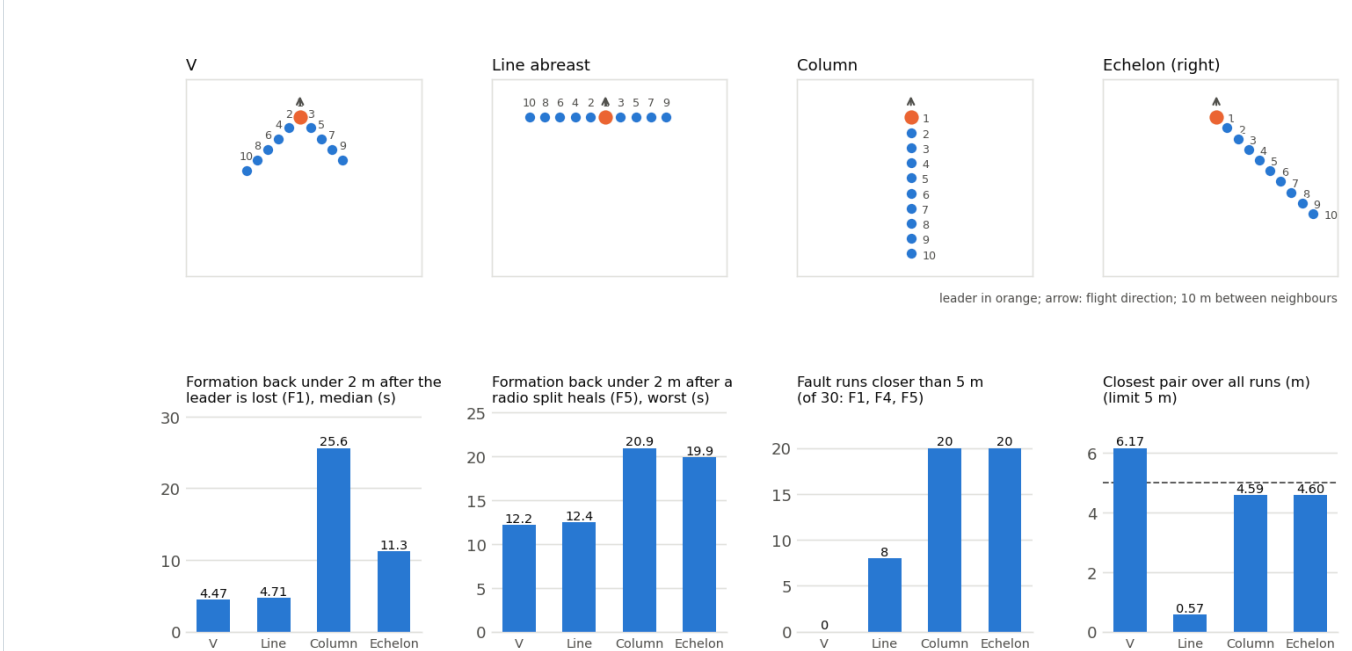
Obstacle avoidance on 90 unseen courses: success rate, crashes and drones left behind for five methods at three obstacle densities.

Radio sweep in the fast simulator (10 drones). Colour runs from 0 to each limit; numbers are the measured values

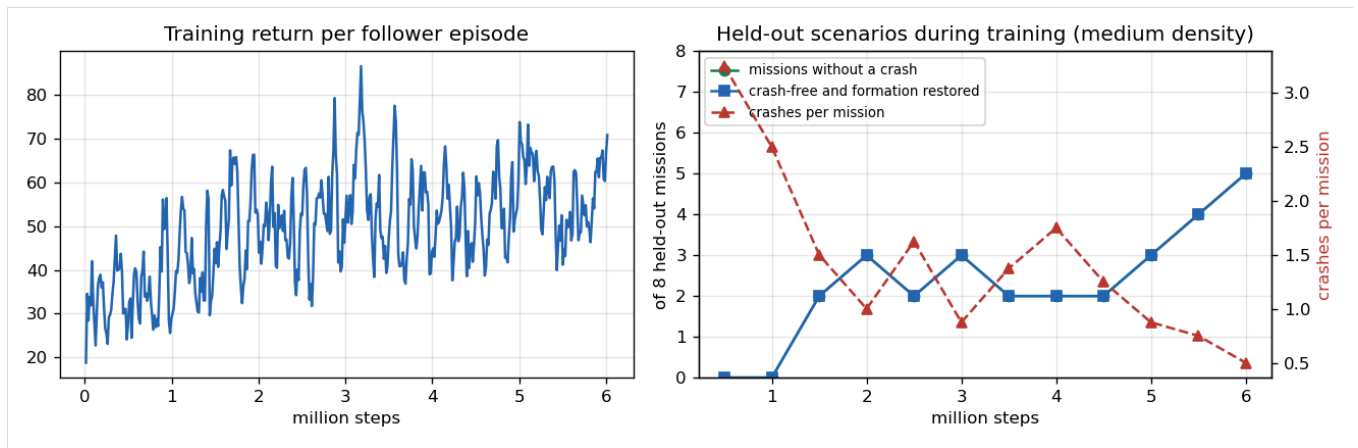


Phase 5 in the fast simulator: false leader changes, time to a new leader and formation recovery for heartbeat delay 50-300 ms and loss 0-30 % (540 runs).

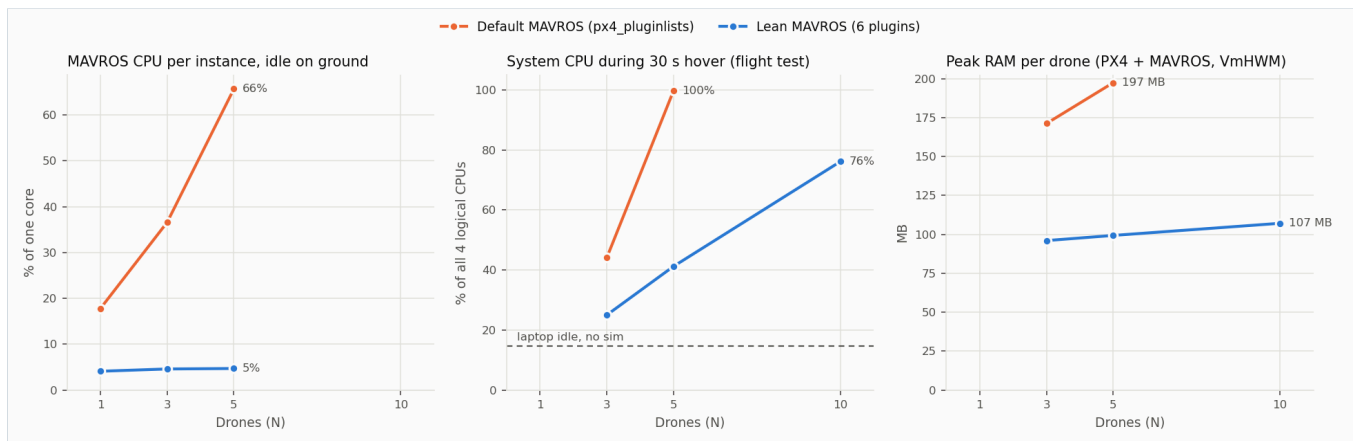
Formation shapes in the fast simulator (10 drones, same agent code)



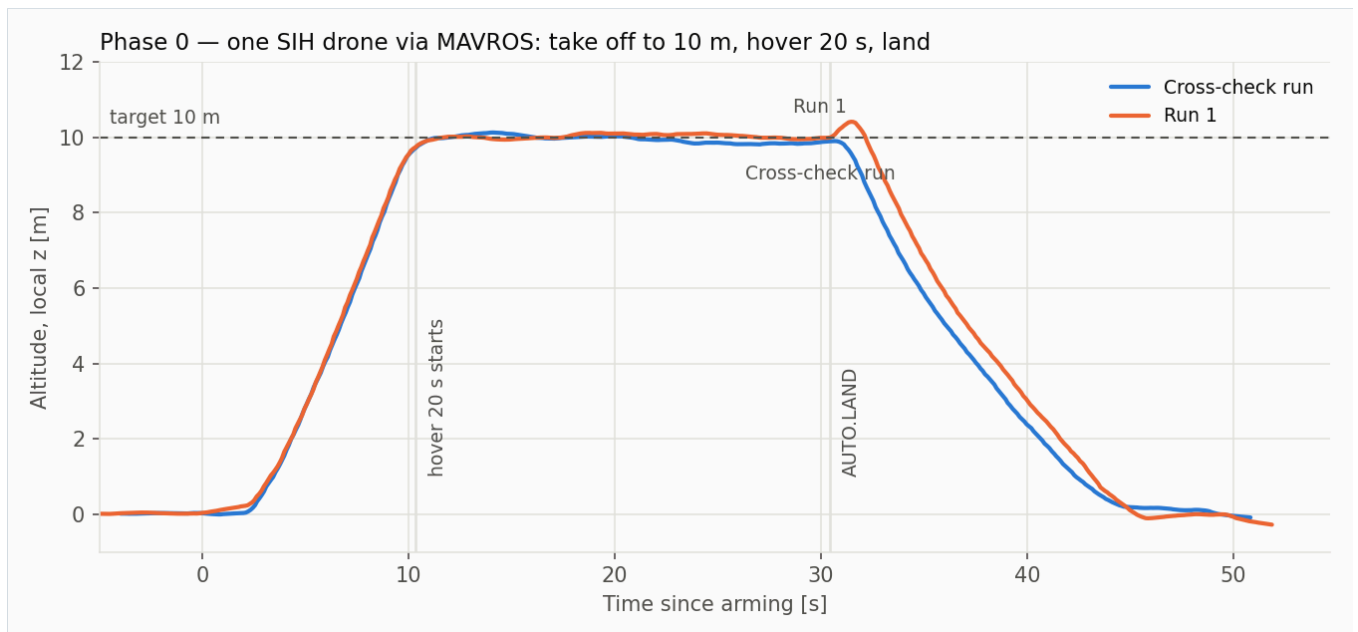
Formation shapes: V, line abreast, column and echelon seen from above, and how they compare after faults; only the V stayed 5 m apart (the others are experimental).



RL training on the laptop: return per episode and held-out scores; still improving at 6 million steps.



PX4 + MAVROS resources for 3, 5 and 10 drones on this laptop (Phase 1).



The first PX4 flight: arm, climb to 10 m, hover 20 s, land (Phase 0).

Installation and operation

DOCS/RUNBOOK.MD

Runbook: installation and operation

All commands run from the repository root. The path of this repository contains a space (drone swarm): quote it in shells, and note that PX4 itself cannot run from such a path, so its working folders go to `/tmp/swarm_sim/` (`config/swarm.yaml -> sim.work_dir`).

1. Install from scratch (Ubuntu 24.04)

Steps that need `sudo` must be run by the owner of the machine.

- ROS 2 Jazzy (desktop or base) from packages.ros.org, then `sudo apt install ros-jazzy-mavros` (installed here: `ros-jazzy-mavros` and `ros-jazzy-mavros-msgs` 2.15.1).
- GeographicLib datasets for MAVROS (egm96-5 geoid and the magnetic model): `sudo /opt/ros/jazzy/lib/mavros/install_geographiclib_datasets.sh`. When its SourceForge download fails (it did here), download the files by hand and copy them to `/usr/share/GeographicLib/` (record: `reports/logs/phase_0/sudo_installs.log`, `geographiclib_datasets.txt`).
- PX4: `git clone https://github.com/PX4/PX4-Autopilot.git ~/PX4-Autopilot --recursive`, `cd ~/PX4-Autopilot && git checkout v1.18.0-rc1 && git submodule update --init --recursive`, `bash ./Tools/setup/ubuntu.sh --no-nuttx --no-sim-tools` (`sudo`), then from this repository `scripts/build_px4.sh` (builds `px4_sitl_sih` with 2 jobs; v1.17 has no `px4_sitl_sih`).
- Python packages from Ubuntu (present here already): `numpy`, `scipy`, `matplotlib`, `pyyaml`, `psutil`, `pytest` (`sudo apt install python3-numpy python3-scipy python3-matplotlib python3-yaml python3-psutil python3-pytest python3-pytest-cov`).
- Only for RL training on the laptop: `python3 -m venv --system-site-packages .venv`, `.venv/bin/pip install torch --index-url https://download.pytorch.org/whl/cpu`, `.venv/bin/pip install gymnasium stable-baselines3` (about 0.9 GB).
- Optional map keys: copy `config/map_keys.example.yaml` to `config/map_keys.local.yaml` and paste your Mapbox and Cesium ion tokens (never commit that file).
- Desktop icon: `bash scripts/install_launcher.sh`.

Check the environment: `scripts/env_audit.sh`. Before any PX4 run: `free -m` should show more than 800 MB available; kill leftovers with `pkill -x px4`; `pkill -x mavros_node`.

2. Every day

Task	Command
Open the ground-control app	double-click Swarm Control in the project folder or on the desktop (or <code>start_swarm_control.sh</code> : right-click → Run as a Program), or <code>python3 scripts/gcs.py</code> and open <code>http://localhost:8080</code>
Stop it (when started by a launcher)	<code>scripts/stop_swarm.sh</code>
Install the launchers (once per machine, and again after moving the folder)	<code>bash scripts/install_launcher.sh</code> : desktop and menu icon, and the Swarm Control program in the folder (needs <code>gcc</code> ; the program is not in git, so a fresh copy of the repository needs this once)
Run all tests	<code>python3 -m pytest</code> (131 pass, 4 skip without ROS/PyTorch); with PyTorch: <code>PYTHONPATH=src .venv/bin/python -m pytest</code> (134 pass, 2 skip)
Save changes to GitHub (private repository <code>saad-rafeque/drone-swarm-failover</code>)	<code>git status</code> , then <code>git add <files></code> , <code>git commit -m "<message>"</code> and <code>git push</code> (the laptop's deploy key is used automatically; see <code>docs/KNOWN_ISSUES.md</code> , Housekeeping)

In the app: choose home and target (type or pick on the map), number of drones (1-100), obstacles (none or real buildings), avoidance, flight height, formation (V; line, column and echelon are marked experimental); Start; change the speed; use the fault buttons (kill leader, kill 2/3/4, per-drone crash / motor / battery / GPS / radio faults, radio split). Routes up to 400 km; longer than a battery leg they get charging stops automatically.

The **3D view** page follows the same simulation: the drones are 3-D models (leader blue with a ring, followers white, leaving amber, no radio purple, down red), with V-formation lines, trails, and a line down to the ground under each drone. Cameras: **Chase** (behind the formation), **Orbit** (circles it), **Top** (straight down) — in these three, drag to turn and use the wheel to zoom — and **Free** (move the camera yourself). Switches for trails, V lines, labels, obstacles, 3-D buildings, sun shadows and Google photorealistic 3-D (heavy). Fault buttons: kill the leader, kill 2 at random, leader battery low, cut the leader's radio, split the radio net, restore radios. Big events (a drone down, a new leader and how many seconds after the fault) appear as a banner, and the last events are listed at the top right.

3. PX4 simulation (ROS 2 environment through `scripts/ros_env.sh`)

Phase	Command	Output
0: one drone, 10 m hover	<code>scripts/ros_env.sh python3 scripts/phase0_flight_test.py</code>	<code>reports/logs/phase_0/</code>
1: N drones hover	<code>scripts/ros_env.sh python3 scripts/phase1_scale_test.py --n 10</code>	<code>reports/logs/phase_1/n10/</code>
3: formation mission	<code>scripts/ros_env.sh python3 scripts/run_mission.py --n 10 --run-dir reports/logs/phase_3/run1</code>	run folder: <code>states.jsonl</code> , <code>metrics.json</code> , ...
3: acceptance batch (3 runs + 3 clean-shell cross-checks)	<code>bash scripts/phase3_runs.sh</code>	<code>reports/logs/phase_3/</code>
Re-run the PX4 tests of Phases 4, 5 and 6 (all 95 finished on 29 September 2026; the queue skips finished trials, so move or delete a trial folder to run it again)	<code>python3 scripts/px4_queue.py start, stop [--now], battery on off, status</code>	the trial folders in <code>reports/logs/phase_4/</code> , <code>phase_5/</code> , <code>phase_6/</code> (and <code>*_crosscheck/</code>); the queue's log <code>reports/logs/px4_queue/runner.log</code>

Phase	Command	Output
4: fault trials without the queue, one round at a time (F1-F5 once, ~30 min; 10 drones; waits for the charger)	<code>bash scripts/phase4_runs.sh <r> <r> for round r = 1..10, then the clean-shell cross-check round (scripts/phase4_all.sh does all of it in one go, ~7 h); then python3 scripts/phase4_metrics.py --out ... --md ... reports/logs/phase_4/F?_t* and python3 scripts/plot_phase4.py</code>	reports/logs/phase_4/; how-to: reports/PHASE_4.md
5: radio sweep on PX4 (9 conditions, one mission without a fault and one F1 mission each, ~16 min per condition)	<code>bash scripts/phase5_runs.sh <first> <last> (conditions 1-9)</code>	reports/logs/phase_5/d<delay>_l<loss>_<none\\ F1>
6: radio stand-in test on PX4 (F1 and F2 with drone 1 behind the stand-in, ~16 min per round)	<code>bash scripts/phase6_runs.sh <r> <r> for round r = 1..10</code>	reports/logs/phase_6/
Check a drone profile (never opens a serial port)	<code>PYTHONPATH=src python3 scripts/check_profile.py config/profiles/mixed.yaml</code>	console
One mission with a profile, for example drone 1 behind the radio stand-in	<code>scripts/ros_env.sh python3 scripts/run_mission.py --n 10 --run-dir <dir> --profile config/profiles/standin.yaml</code>	run folder, proc_logs/radio_standin_1.json (link statistics); drone 1's PX4 log shows mode: Minimal, data rate: 1200 B/s (its radio link set-up)
Metrics / plots of a run	<code>python3 scripts/metrics.py <run_dir>; python3 scripts/plot_mission.py <run_dir> out.png</code>	
Replay page from a run	<code>python3 scripts/make_replay.py <run_dir> scripts/replay_template.html reports/replay/swarm_replay.html</code>	open in the app: PX4 flights
Logs as CSV	<code>PYTHONPATH=src python3 -c "from swarm_tools.logfmt import jsonl_to_csv; jsonl_to_csv('<run>/states.jsonl', '<run>/states.csv')"</code>	
Phase 0 / Phase 1 figures	<code>python3 scripts/plot_phase0.py; python3 scripts/plot_phase1.py</code>	reports/phase0_altitude.png, reports/phase1_resources.png
Diagnostic: CPU and memory of idle PX4 + MAVROS for several N (Phase 1)	<code>scripts/ros_env.sh python3 scripts/mavros_idle_scaling.py --ns 1 3 5</code>	console
Diagnostic: where 2 SIH drones spawn without home settings (Phase 1)	<code>scripts/ros_env.sh python3 scripts/spawn_default_check.py</code>	console

Every PX4 drone listens on UDP 14580+n and sends to 14540+n (PX4's own port plan, which covers 10 instances); MAVROS runs in namespace /uav<id>. Serial connection URLs are refused by the tools.

4. Fast-simulator experiments (no ROS)

Experiment	Command
1,000 random fault runs (Phase 2)	<code>PYTHONPATH=src python3 scripts/random_trials.py --runs 1000 --workers 3</code>
Fault types F1-F5	<code>PYTHONPATH=src python3 scripts/puresim_faults.py --n 10 --seeds 20</code>
Swarm size 1-100	<code>PYTHONPATH=src python3 scripts/scale_test.py --ns 1 2 3 5 10 20 50 100 --seeds 1 2 3 --jsonl reports/logs/scaling/fastsim_scaling.jsonl</code>
One app mission without the browser, saved as JSON (events, progress, formation error, closest pair)	<code>PYTHONPATH=src python3 scripts/run_route.py --target LAT LON [--altitude auto\\ low\\ normal] [--avoider rl+shield] --out reports/logs/long_route/NAME.json</code>
The 12 km route (F-9 Park -> Rawalpindi Saddar), ~2 min each	<code>... scripts/run_route.py --target 33.5973 73.0479 --altitude auto --out reports/logs/long_route/rawalpindi_12km_auto.json, and --altitude low</code>
Islamabad -> Lahore to the end (272.55 km, 65 stops), ~20-25 min	<code>PYTHONPATH=src python3 scripts/run_route.py --target 31.5204 74.3587 --out reports/logs/long_route/lahore_full.json</code>
Replay part of a route and record every follower (for example the stop-5 episode)	<code>PYTHONPATH=src python3 scripts/route_window.py --target 31.5204 74.3587 --from 5000 --to 5300 --out reports/logs/long_route/lahore_full_stop5_detail.json</code>
Phase 5 radio sweep in the fast simulator (540 runs, ~14 min with 2 jobs)	<code>PYTHONPATH=src python3 scripts/radio_sweep.py --seeds 20 --jobs 2</code>
Formation shapes compared (160 runs, ~3 min)	<code>PYTHONPATH=src python3 scripts/formation_compare.py --seeds 10 --jobs 3</code>

5. Obstacle avoidance and RL

Step	Command	Time on this laptop
Tune the classical avoider (training scenarios)	<code>PYTHONPATH=src python3 scripts/rl_tune_apf.py</code>	~15 min
Train the policy (CPU, PPO)	<code>PYTHONPATH=src .venv/bin/python scripts/rl_train.py --steps 6000000 --run reports/logs/rl/run1</code>	~40 min
Learning curve	<code>python3 scripts/plot_rl_training.py reports/logs/rl/run1 --out reports/rl_training.png</code>	seconds
Fair comparison, 90 unseen courses	<code>PYTHONPATH=src python3 scripts/rl_eval.py --policy models/avoid_policy.npz --episodes 30 --jobs 3</code>	~9 min
Real map, full agent code	<code>PYTHONPATH=src python3 scripts/rl_eval_route.py --policy models/avoid_policy.npz --seeds 5 --jobs 3</code>	~8 min
Use a policy in the app	copy its best_policy.npz to models/avoid_policy.npz	
Long training on a GPU	step by step in docs/KAGGLE_GUIDE.md	~11 h per seed on Kaggle (two seeds can run at once)

Step	Command	Time on this laptop
Learning curve of a Kaggle run	<code>python3 scripts/plot_rl_training.py reports/logs/rl/kaggle_seed1 --out reports/rl_training_kaggle_seed1.png</code>	seconds

6. Documents

Document	Command
Project brief page	<code>PYTHONPATH=src python3 scripts/make_brief.py -> reports/brief/swarm_failover.html</code>
Handover PDF	<code>PYTHONPATH=src python3 scripts/make_handover_pdf.py -> docs/HANDOVER.pdf</code> (needs Google Chrome)
Online copy of the project brief	a copy of <code>reports/brief/swarm_failover.html</code> was published once (26 September 2026) as a private online page in the owner's account; it is not updated automatically - republish it after regenerating the brief
Kaggle code bundle	<code>python3 scripts/make_kaggle_bundle.py -> kaggle/swarm-rl-code.zip</code> (never contains <code>config/map_keys.local.yaml</code>)
Kaggle guide alone as a PDF	<code>PYTHONPATH=src python3 scripts/make_handover_pdf.py --only kaggle --out docs/KAGGLE_GUIDE.pdf</code>
3-D drone model of the 3D view	<code>python3 scripts/make_drone_model.py -> src/swarm_tools/gcs/static/drone.glb</code>

7. When something goes wrong

Symptom	Cause and fix
PX4 exits at start with a path error	the repository path has a space; PX4 must run from <code>/tmp/swarm_sim/...</code> (done by <code>sim_launch.py</code>)
A PX4 build uses all cores and the laptop freezes	always build with <code>scripts/build_px4.sh</code> (2 jobs)
Drones do not arm / MAVROS not connected	leftovers from an earlier run: <code>kill -x px4; kill -x mavros_node</code> , check <code>free -m</code>
"Downloading buildings ... map server busy"	the public OpenStreetMap (Overpass) servers are overloaded; wait or use the normal flight height (light query); downloads are cached in <code>data/osm/</code>
3D view says "Cesium key needed"	paste the Cesium ion token into <code>config/map_keys.local.yaml</code> and reload
3D view dark or blurred for a few seconds after opening	the terrain tiles are still loading; wait, the camera glides in on its own
3D view slow, laptop fan loud	switch off Photorealistic and Sun shadows; close the 3D tab during long simulations
Double-clicking <code>start_swarm_control.sh</code> opens a text editor	right-click → Run as a Program, or use the Swarm Control program next to it
The desktop or menu icon does nothing after the folder was moved	the icon stores the folder's path: run <code>bash scripts/install_launcher.sh</code> again (the Swarm Control program inside the folder finds its own place and keeps working)
Satellite map is Esri, not Mapbox	no Mapbox token in <code>config/map_keys.local.yaml</code> , or the server was still starting (reload)
RL options greyed out in the app	<code>models/avoid_policy.npz</code> is missing
The app is slow with obstacles	expected: about 15x real time with 10 drones and the RL avoider; open sky is ~150x

Design decisions

DOCS/DECISIONS.MD

Design decisions

The decisions that shape the system, what was chosen, and the reason. Where a decision came from a measured problem, the evidence is named.

#	Decision	Why
1	No central controller. Every drone runs the same agent and decides its role from heartbeats.	The goal is surviving the loss of any drone, including the leader; the same code must later run on each real drone (docs/SPECIFICATION.md section 6).
2	MAVROS (MAVLink) per drone, not uXRCE-DDS.	Real drones will talk over low-bandwidth MAVLink telemetry radios; switching a drone from simulated to real should only change its connection URL.
3	PX4 SIH, headless, v1.18.0-rc1.	Runs 10 drones on an 8 GB laptop without Gazebo; px4_sitl_sih exists from v1.18 (not in v1.17).
4	Lean MAVROS plugin list + per-namespace remaps of /tf, /tf_static, /parameter_events.	The default plugin set shared /parameter_events across all drones: 5 drones took 99.7 % CPU; lean plugins cut MAVROS CPU per instance from 65.7 % to 4.7 % (reports/PHASE_1.md).
5	One shared ENU frame from each drone's GPS, never MAVROS local frames.	Each MAVROS local frame starts where that drone powered on; comparing them would silently corrupt formation and separation.
6	Lowest alive eligible ID leads; term counter; MASTER_OK blocks claims; no pre-emption; first election waits for the fleet.	Deterministic and testable: exactly one leader after any split heals (1,000/1,000 runs). Waiting for the fleet at startup fixed drone 3 sometimes leading. Learned methods are not used here on purpose (decision 17).
7	Heartbeat as a compact binary message (43-byte header + member mask).	Fits telemetry radios: 18 kbit/s for 10 drones at 5 Hz. The mask was 64-bit (63 drones max) and became variable-length to allow up to 250 drones (PX4's system-ID limit).
8	Parity arms (even left, odd right) instead of alternating slots.	With alternating slots a single loss swapped every later drone across the formation (moves up to 64 m); parity arms only slide the drones behind the loss (reports/PHASE_2.md).
9	Transit layer (6 m below) for long moves, orphan layer (8 m above) for drones the leader cannot hear.	Crossing paths after a radio split healed caused close passes; vertical separation removes them.
10	Leader flies a fixed-heading leg with cross-track correction and a speed ramp.	Re-aiming at the goal made the leader wander and the V rotate; the ramp removed a formation-error spike at the start of cruise (reports/PHASE_3.md).
11	Emergency landing drops below the formation while keeping its speed.	Landing straight down let the drones behind come within 4.66 m; keeping speed while descending lets them pass over.
12	Pure-Python fast simulator running the real agent code.	Thousands of runs in minutes (1,000-run test, scaling to 100 drones, the app), while PX4 validates the same code with the real autopilot.
13	Obstacles are 2-D at flight height; flight height decides what counts.	Simple and honest: at 16 m every building and wood is in the way; at 30 m only tall structures (OSM height or storeys) are. Flying over is not modelled.
14	Classical global planning for the leader (A*), local avoidance for followers.	The leader's route can be computed from the map; followers must react locally while keeping formation, which is where learning can help.
15	Every avoider gets the same inputs and the same safety layer; the classical one is tuned first.	A fair comparison: the question is whether learning beats a good classical controller, not a weak one.
16	Held-out evaluation seeds, paired statistics, confidence intervals.	Results must hold on courses the policy never saw, and differences must be distinguishable from luck.
17	RL only where it can plausibly help: local obstacle and collision avoidance. Not for leader election, not for motor control.	Election must be provably correct; motor control is already solved by PX4.
18	Residual policy (a correction on top of the formation law) with a hard brake shield.	Starts from sensible behaviour, trains faster, and the brake keeps a learned mistake from becoming a crash; RL + brake was the best method.
19	Policy weights exported to numpy; no ML library on the drone.	The onboard agent stays light and dependency-free; the exported policy matches the trained one to 3e-8.
20	Long routes: strip download, chunked planning, charging stops at open spots, landing in place on low battery.	A single map query or planning grid over hundreds of kilometres is impossible; a quadcopter needs battery swaps about every 4 km; flying home from 100 km away is not realistic.
21	Positions put back on the ground far from home (tangent-plane correction).	Without it a drone 270 km away is drawn about 240 m off.
22	Map keys in a git-ignored local file, never typed in by the assistant.	Keys are the owner's credentials.
23	Everything tunable in config/swarm.yaml; strict config loading.	One source of truth; a missing or unknown key is an error, not a silent default.
24	Simulation only.	No serial ports, no real flight controller, no firmware flashing until the owner decides (docs/SPECIFICATION.md rule 7).
25	The GPU trainer picks its best policy on separate validation courses, never on the test courses.	Choosing among ~20 checkpoints by their test score would inflate the reported result. The laptop trainer already used separate courses; the GPU kit did not until the final check (27 September 2026).
26	Secrets never leave the laptop: the Kaggle zip skips *.local.* files and checks every packed file for key values.	The first zip had included the map keys; uploading it would have handed them to a third-party service.
27	The 3-D drone model is generated by a script (scripts/make_drone_model.py), not downloaded.	No licence questions, a 54 KB file, easy to change; built chunkier than a real frame so it stays readable when drawn about 60 pixels wide.
28	The avoider runs at 10 Hz in the agent, the rate used in training and tuning.	About 2.7 times faster simulation with obstacles (5.8x -> 15.6x real time on the Lahore route, together with a cheaper policy input), and every avoider runs at the rate it was trained or tuned for. The classical avoider did better at 20 Hz on the real map; both results are reported (docs/RESULTS.md).
29	The Islamabad -> Lahore run was stopped at 76 km on purpose.	It only demonstrated scale (the charging-stop mechanism had already completed end to end on the 12 km route); the owner wanted the laptop free for the handover work. How to finish it: docs/RUNBOOK.md , section 4.

#	Decision	Why
30	Phase 4 stopped on this laptop (27 September 2026).	With 10 PX4 drones the i3 laptop runs at 60-100 % CPU on the charger and saturates on battery; the owner stopped the 7-hour batch. Run it on a machine with 8+ cores, or with 5 drones here (docs/SPECIFICATION.md rule 6); everything is in reports/PHASE_4.md .
31	F5 formation-recovery limit is 20 s (the owner, 28 September 2026); 15 s for the other faults.	After a radio split heals, the term rule makes the whole V re-form around the newer leader; the transit layer's down-across-up move and PX4's vertical speeds make that about 17 s on PX4. The owner chose a 20 s limit over a faster move with less height separation or a change to the election rule (reports/PHASE_4.md).
32	The telemetry-radio stand-in models SiK defaults: one shared 32 kbit/s channel, transmit turns up to 131 ms, 1 % loss, a 1 s buffer.	ArduPilot's SiK page gives AIR_SPEED 64, ECC on ("the data rate you can support is halved"), time-division turns and MAX_WINDOW 131; loss and buffer size are design choices and say so in config/swarm.yaml . It tests the drone link a real radio would carry, not the radio's framing.
33	Profiles carry each drone's connection URL; the simulation tools refuse a real drone.	The specification requires that moving a drone to hardware only changes its URL, and rule 7 forbids opening serial ports: mixed.yaml is checked as text, and SimLauncher raises before anything starts.
34	The V stays the default formation; line abreast, column and echelon are experimental.	In the comparison (28 September 2026) only the V kept every pair at 5 m or more after the leader was lost or a radio split healed; the slot-change rules were designed for the V.
35	A drone on a telemetry radio gets its own link set-up: PX4 Minimal mode capped at 1,200 B/s, position and velocity at 5 Hz, 1 s allowed without autopilot data, MAVROS time sync at 1 Hz; the config refuses a set-up whose planned traffic exceeds 80 % of the radio.	The first Phase 6 attempt overloaded the stand-in radio 1.7–3.9 times, because PX4's simulator link runs in onboard mode at 4 MB/s. 1,200 B/s is PX4's own TELEM1 default; Minimal mode leaves room for the streams the agent needs; 5 Hz matches the heartbeat rate; 1 s tolerates 4 lost positions in a row. The other drones keep their settings, so Phases 2–5 stay valid. Election rule unchanged (known issue).

Known issues, open work and roadmap

DOCS/KNOWN_ISSUES.MD

Known issues, open work and roadmap

Recommendations for what to do next, with effort estimates, are in docs/FUTURE_WORK.md.

Not done (from the original plan in docs/SPECIFICATION.md)

Item	State	What it takes
Other formations (line, column, echelon, diamond, squads) and their comparison	line abreast, column and echelon added and compared on 28 September 2026: in normal flight as good as the V, but after the leader is lost or a radio split heals they come closer than 5 m (line down to 0.57 m), so they are marked experimental and the V stays the default. Diamond and squads: not done	shape-specific rules for moving to new slots (for example every slot change on the transit layer for single-line shapes), then the same comparison (scripts/formation_compare.py)
Longer RL training, several seeds	done on 28-29 September 2026: two 10.5-hour Kaggle GPU runs (seeds 1 and 2); seed 2's policy is now models/avoid_policy.npz (docs/RESULTS.md). Both runs stopped improving after about 2.5 hours, so more hours with the same settings will not help	a changed set-up (learning-rate decay, more dense courses, a third seed) for dense clutter, which no method solves yet; about 11 GPU hours per run

Known limitations

- **No real drone has flown this code.** The Pixhawk 6C cannot run it alone; each drone needs a companion computer (for example a Raspberry Pi 4/5) connected to the Pixhawk by serial cable, and a radio link between drones for the heartbeats (a bridge node replacing the link emulator).
- **Separation when drones cannot hear each other.** In 143 of 1,000 random fast-simulator runs, two drones came closer than 5 m; every such run had a random radio split or random link drops. The rules cannot push apart drones that do not hear each other. Needs onboard proximity sensing or sticky formation references before real flights.
- **A drone that keeps dropping out takes the lead back each time.** The election gives the lead to the lowest alive ID, so a leader whose own link drops in and out (seen in the first Phase 6 attempt, with an overloaded radio) keeps losing and retaking the lead. The overloaded link is fixed (reports/PHASE_6.md). A rule that makes a returning drone wait before it can lead again would change docs/SPECIFICATION.md section 6, and Phases 2–5 would have to be repeated; this is for the owner to decide.
- **A drone on a telemetry radio needs the radio settings.** PX4 on TELEM1 in Minimal mode at 1,200 B/s (MAV_0_MODE 7, MAV_0_RATE 1200), its agent started with --radio-link, and MAVROS time sync at 1 Hz (config/swarm.yaml, radio_standin; docs/FLIGHT_TEST_PLAN.md). With PX4's default Normal mode at 1,200 B/s, position arrives at only about 1 Hz.
- **Dense clutter is unsolved.** In the densest obstacle courses the best method (RL + brake) completes 5 of 30; followers still hit buildings in dense city blocks at 16 m.
- **Simplified physics.** PX4 SIH uses a simple aircraft model; the fast simulators use point masses with a first-order velocity response and a random drift instead of real wind.
- **Perfect sensing assumed.** Positions, velocities and range readings are exact in simulation. Real GPS drifts by metres (use RTK GPS or wider spacing); range readings would come from a real sensor (lidar or depth camera) or from a map that may be out of date.
- **2-D obstacles.** Obstacles are footprints at the flight height; flying over is not modelled, OSM heights are often missing (defaults: houses 9 m, woods 15 m).
- **Map data availability.** The public Overpass servers are often busy (HTTP 429/504); downloads retry and are cached, but a first long-route download can take tens of minutes.
- **Radio load.** Heartbeats go from every drone to every drone: 224 kbit/s for 100 drones, far more than one telemetry radio channel (SiK default 64 kbit/s). Large swarms need a mesh network, lower rates, or squads.
- **One V for large swarms.** With 100 drones each arm is about 490 m long; big swarms should fly as squads of about ten.
- **PX4 on this laptop is limited to 10 drones** (CPU, and PX4's default port plan).
- **Phase 3 harness:** two runs ended with the harness's watcher thread stalled (flights fine); the fix is in the code but has not been re-run on PX4.
- **Followers can get stuck against buildings.** On the 12 km route at 16 m, three followers got stuck about 1.5 m from a wall, crawled, fell 100–1,250 m behind the formation and finally hit the building (7 of 10 landed). At the normal 30 m the same route is clean (formation error max 1.42 m, no hits). On the full Islamabad -> Lahore run at 30 m it happened once: after charging stop 5 a tall building pushed drone 9 onto the 24 m crossing layer, below the rooftop, where it was held at the wall for about 2 minutes and fell 600 m behind before it got free and caught up, without a hit. A fix needs a way out of dead ends (for example re-planning a short path for a stuck follower, or crossing above a tall building instead of below) - the learned avoider only sees 25 m around it. Evidence: reports/logs/long_route/ (lahore_full_stop5_detail.json).
- **Formation shapes other than the V are experimental.** Line abreast, column and echelon fly as well as the V in normal flight, but the rules that move drones to new slots after the leader is lost or a radio split heals were designed for the V: the line came down to 0.57 m between two drones (8 of 10 split runs under 5 m), the column and echelon to about 4.6 m (reports/logs/formations/).
- **The classical avoider depends on its update rate.** On the real map it hit 4 and 7 buildings when run every 0.05 s but 10 and 8 at 10 Hz, its tuned rate; RL + brake had 0 in both (docs/RESULTS.md).
- **F5 on PX4: the formation re-forms slowly after a radio split heals.** The group with the newer leader wins (the term rule), so the whole V re-forms around it; the transit layer and PX4's vertical speeds make that take about 17 s. On 28 September 2026 the owner set F5's limit to 20 s instead of changing the rules (reports/PHASE_4.md, "Why F5 is slow").
- **This laptop's power.** On battery the power-saver profile throttles the CPU and 10 PX4 drones saturate it; the battery also ran out twice on 27 September 2026. Run long PX4 jobs only on the charger (scripts/phase4_runs.sh waits for it).
- **3-D view heights.** The simulators have flat ground; the 3-D view draws every drone at its simulated height above the real terrain under it (Cesium World Terrain), so on hills it shows height above ground, not a real climb. For the first seconds after the page opens the terrain is still coarse and the picture can be dark or blurred until the tiles arrive.
- **3-D view load.** Google photorealistic tiles and sun shadows are heavy for this laptop's integrated GPU; keep them off while a long simulation runs. The page draws at most 40 frames per second; above 20 drones only the leader gets a trail and a label.

Road to real drones (in order)

1. Phase 4 and Phase 5 on PX4 (fault trials, bad radio).

2. Fix the separation weak spot for drones that cannot hear each other.
3. Measure the real drone: weight, battery capacity, motor and propeller data, PX4 flight logs; put the numbers into the simulators (a digital twin), re-run the tests.
4. Companion computer per drone (Ubuntu 24.04, ROS 2 Jazzy, MAVROS, this agent), wired to the Pixhawk 6C; a heartbeat radio bridge (WiFi mesh or telemetry radios).
5. Bench test with propellers off; then one real drone with nine simulated ones (Phase 6), RC override and a kill switch on every real drone, PX4 geofence and failsafes configured.
6. Three real drones in an open field with safety pilots; only then more.
7. Legal permission for flights (local civil aviation rules) before any outdoor test.

Also before real flights: PX4 is pinned to a release candidate (v1.18.0-rc1, the first version with the `px4_sitl_sih` target); move to a stable PX4 release for the real drones and run Phases 0-4 again.

Ideas for later

- RL where mistakes are cheap: area re-division when drones fail (search and rescue), charging and patrol schedules, battery-aware routing - planning on the ground rather than flight control.
- Train on real OpenStreetMap neighbourhoods instead of random courses; train with the brake in the loop; curriculum from sparse to dense clutter.
- Terrain heights (for example Mapbox Terrain-DEM or Copernicus) so the swarm keeps its height above hills such as the Margalla range.

Housekeeping

- **Backup: done on 27 September 2026.** The repository, with its full history and tags, is on GitHub as a private repository (saad-rafeque/drone-swarm-failover). The laptop pushes with a deploy key that works for this one repository only (`~/ssh/drone_swarm_failover_deploy`, selected by the local Git setting `core.sshCommand`); if the laptop is lost, delete that key under the repository's Settings -> Deploy keys. Git-ignored files are not on GitHub and need their own copy if wanted: `config/map_keys.local.yaml` (keys), `.venv/`, `kaggle/swarm-rl-code.zip` (rebuilt by a script) and the `Swarm Control` launcher (rebuilt by `scripts/install_launcher.sh`).
- **No licence file.** Choose a licence before sharing the code outside the team. Third-party data keep their own terms: OpenStreetMap data (ODbL, attribution), Mapbox and Cesium ion / Google tiles (their terms of service, shown as credits in the app).
- **The online project brief is out of date** (published 26 September 2026; see `docs/RUNBOOK.md`, section 6).

Found and fixed during the final check (27 September 2026)

- **Kaggle bundle packed the private map keys.** `scripts/make_kaggle_bundle.py` zipped the whole `config/` folder, including `config/map_keys.local.yaml`. The zip had not been uploaded. The script now skips `*.local.*` files and refuses to build if any packed file contains a key value; `tests/test_tools_scripts.py` checks both.
- **GPU training would have chosen its best policy on the test courses.** `build_pools.py` gave the trainer the same 90 courses the final comparison reports on. Now the trainer scores separate validation courses (`val.npz`, seeds 1,000,000-1,000,029); the test courses (1,000,100-1,000,129) are used only for the final report (checked by `tests/test_tools_scripts.py`).
- **3-D view:** drones were drawn before the terrain height was known, so their trails started hundreds of metres below the ground and the camera could end up under the terrain. Drones now appear once the ground height is known, trails are stored as height above ground, and the camera lifts itself above hills.
- **Learning-curve plot** could not read the GPU trainer's logs; `scripts/plot_rl_training.py` now reads both formats.
- **Stopping the app did not stop it.** `scripts/start_swarm.sh` saved the process ID of a helper shell instead of the app, so `scripts/stop_swarm.sh` said "stopped" while the app kept running. The start script now saves the app's own ID, and the stop script checks that the process really is the app (and falls back to looking for it) before and after stopping it.
- **In-app Docs page showed no documents.** `static/md.js` had a JavaScript syntax error ("use strict" inside a function with a default parameter). Fixed; the viewer also shows pictures and quote boxes now.

Future work and recommendations

DOCS/FUTURE_WORK.MD

Future work and recommendations

Status (29 September 2026): the software phase is complete. Phases 0 to 6 of `docs/SPECIFICATION.md` passed (tags `phase-0` to `phase-6`), the Kaggle-trained obstacle-avoidance policy is in use, and everything is on `main`. This note lists what can come next, what I recommend, and roughly how much work each item is. Effort figures are estimates, not measurements.

In short:

- **One-click setup is possible.** The app and the fast simulator can be one command within half a day of work. The full PX4 + ROS 2 system can be one command with a container (Docker), or one click in the browser with GitHub Codespaces, in about 2–3 days.
- **Before going public:** choose a licence, scan the whole history for secrets, add a responsible-use note.
- **Swarm logic:** stop a drone with a patchy link from grabbing the lead back, and keep drones apart when they cannot hear each other.
- **RL:** the next run should change the training set-up, not just run longer.
- **Real drones:** hardware, a stable PX4 release, bench tests, then the flight test plan, only with legal permission.

1. One-click setup for anyone who copies the repository

Can it be done? Yes, in layers. Today a new person has to follow 7 manual steps in `docs/RUNBOOK.md`, section 1. They install ROS 2 Jazzy and MAVROS, fetch the GeographicLib data, clone and build PX4, install the Python packages, set up the RL environment, add map keys and install the desktop icon. Some of that needs `sudo`, the PX4 build takes about 15 GB of disk, and one download (GeographicLib from SourceForge) failed on this laptop and had to be done by hand.

Not everyone needs all of it. Most visitors only want to see the swarm fly in the app, which needs none of the heavy parts. So the setup should come in three levels:

#	What the person gets	How they start it	What they need	Their waiting time	Work to build it
1	Quick start: the ground-control app (2-D map, 3-D view, faults, results), the fast simulator with the real agent code, the RL policy, all tests	<code>./setup.sh</code> , then the app opens in the browser	Linux or macOS with Python 3.12 (Windows through WSL); no <code>sudo</code>	about 2–5 minutes	about half a day
2	Full install script: everything, including 10 PX4 drones with MAVROS	<code>bash scripts/install_all.sh</code>	Ubuntu 24.04, 15 GB free disk, 8 GB RAM, the <code>sudo</code> password once	about 1–1.5 hours (downloads and the PX4 build)	about 1–2 days, tested on a clean Ubuntu 24.04 virtual machine
3	Container: the same as level 2, identical on every machine	<code>docker compose up</code> , or the "Open in Codespaces" button on GitHub (nothing installed at all)	Docker, or a GitHub account (Codespaces has a monthly free allowance; 10 PX4 drones need a 4-core machine)	about 10–20 minutes to download a ready image	about 2–3 days

What each level would do: - **Level 1**, `setup.sh`: 1. Check Python 3.12. 2. Create `.venv` and install a pinned `requirements.txt`: `numpy 1.26.4`, `scipy 1.11.4`, `matplotlib 3.6.3`, `PyYAML 6.0.1`, `psutil 5.9.8`, `pytest`. 3. Run the fast tests (about a minute). 4. Ask for map keys; skipping is fine. 5. Start the app on port 8080 and open the browser. PyTorch is not needed here: the policy runs on plain numpy. - **Level 2**, `install_all.sh`: 1. Check Ubuntu 24.04, free disk (at least 15 GB) and memory. 2. Install ROS 2 Jazzy, MAVROS and the GeographicLib data. Keep a second download source, because SourceForge failed once. 3. Clone PX4 at `v1.18.0-rc1` and build `px4_sitl_sih` with 2 jobs (`scripts/build_px4.sh`). 4. Do everything level 1 does, plus the optional RL training environment. 5. Install the desktop icon. 6. Finish with `scripts/env_audit.sh` and a one-drone take-off and landing, the Phase 0 test. The script must be safe to run twice and must say clearly which step failed. - **Level 3, container:** - A `Dockerfile` starting from the official ROS 2 Jazzy image, with MAVROS, the GeographicLib data and PX4 SIH built inside. - A `docker-compose.yml` that starts the app on port 8080. - A `.devcontainer/devcontainer.json` for Codespaces and VS Code. - Build the image once and publish it on GitHub's container registry, so users download it instead of building it for an hour.

Also add an automatic check (GitHub Actions) that, on every push, clones the repository fresh, runs level 1 and the test suite, and builds the container. Without this, setup scripts break quietly as packages change. Phase 6 did this check once by hand (`reports/logs/phase_6/fresh_clone_check.txt`).

What cannot be made automatic: - **Map keys** (Mapbox, Cesium ion) belong to a person's own free account and must never be shipped. The 2-D map works without them (OpenStreetMap streets). Satellite imagery needs a Mapbox key, and the 3-D view needs a Cesium ion key. The setup can ask for them and write `config/map_keys.local.yaml`. - **The `sudo` password** for a native install (level 2). Containers avoid it. - **Kaggle training** runs on the user's own Kaggle account (`docs/KAGGLE_GUIDE.md`). - **Computer limits:** 10 PX4 drones used about 1.1 GB of RAM and 77 % of this laptop's CPU. Weaker machines should start with 3 drones.

Recommendation: build level 1 first, because most visitors only want to see it work. Then build level 3, because a container is the only way to make the full PX4 system truly one step on any computer. Keep level 2 for people who want a native install, for example on a drone's companion computer.

2. Before making the repository public

- **Licence.** Without one, nobody may legally reuse the code, even if it is public.
- **Apache-2.0** is permissive and includes a patent grant. **MIT** is the shortest permissive licence. With **GPL-3.0**, copies that are shared must stay open.
- For a research project that others should build on, Apache-2.0 or MIT is the usual choice.
- PX4, MAVROS and ROS 2 are not part of this repository, so their licences do not change this choice.
- The OpenStreetMap files in `data/osm/` fall under the ODbL; the README already gives the required credit.
- **Secrets.** `config/map_keys.local.yaml` has never been committed. Still, scan the whole history before publishing, for example with `gitLeaks`, because a key committed once stays in the history after it is removed.
- **Personal details.** 394 tracked files, mostly raw logs, contain the laptop's home folder path with the user name. Commits already use the GitHub no-reply e-mail address. Keeping the paths is harmless; removing them means rewriting the logs.

- **Size.** The history is about 206 MB, mostly raw trial logs. That is fine for GitHub, but cloning is slower. Option: move the raw logs to a GitHub Release download and keep the summaries in the repository.
- **Responsible-use note.** Add a short section to the README:
- The project is for civil research (search and rescue, inspection, education).
- It is simulation-tested only.
- Real flights need the flight test plan and legal permission.
- It must not be used for weapons or harm.
- **Nice to have:** a `CONTRIBUTING.md`, issue templates, and a badge showing that the automatic check passes.

3. Swarm logic: recommended improvements

1. **Stop leader flapping.** Today, a drone whose own link keeps dropping in and out takes the lead back every time it returns, because the lowest alive ID wins. This was seen in the first Phase 6 attempt with an overloaded radio (`docs/KNOWN_ISSUES.md`). - **Recommendation:** a hold-down rule. A drone that was counted as dead must be heard steadily, for example for 3 s (15 heartbeats), before it may claim the lead again. Until then it flies as a follower. - The lowest-ID rule and the term counter stay as they are. - **Cost:** this changes `docs/SPECIFICATION.md`, section 6, so the tests must be repeated. That means the 1,000 random runs of Phase 2 (minutes) and the PX4 trials of Phases 4 and 5 (about 8 hours with the queue). About 1 day of work plus the re-runs.
2. **Keep drones apart when they cannot hear each other.** In 143 of 1,000 random fast-simulator runs, two drones came closer than 5 m. Every one of those runs had a radio split or random link drops. - **Cheap first fix:** height layers during link loss. Each drone moves to its own height, for example 2 m apart by ID, while it has not heard its neighbours, so drones that cannot talk still cannot meet. - **Also:** "sticky" slots. A follower that loses the leader keeps its last slot and heading instead of drifting towards others. - **For real drones:** an onboard proximity sensor as the last layer. - About 1–2 days, then repeat the random runs and Phase 4 F2 and F5.
3. **Separation with the new RL policy.** On the Islamabad route, two drones once came to 4.77 m (limit 5 m). - Extend the brake so it also stops a drone that is closing in on a neighbour, not only on an obstacle. Or add a separation penalty to training (section 4). - Then re-run `scripts/rl_eval_route.py`. About half a day.
4. **Safer slot changes for the other shapes.** The line, column and echelon come closer than 5 m after faults, so they are experimental. Moving to a new slot on the transit layer, as the V does, should fix it. Re-run `scripts/formation_compare.py`. About 1 day.

4. Reinforcement learning: the next run

The two Kaggle runs (10.5 hours each) stopped improving after about 2.5 hours (`docs/RESULTS.md`). More hours with the same settings will not help. Change the set-up instead: - **Learning-rate decay:** lower the learning rate step by step to zero over the run, so the policy settles instead of going up and down. - **More dense courses:** dense clutter is still the weak case, with 18 of 30 missions passed. Use a curriculum from sparse to dense, or simply a larger share of dense courses. - **The brake inside training,** so the policy learns to work with it, and a **separation penalty** for coming closer than 5 m to a neighbour. - **Real map areas:** train on patches of real OpenStreetMap neighbourhoods as well as random courses. - **Three seeds** for a result others can trust. Because of the plateau, 5 hours per seed is enough: three seeds cost about 15 GPU hours, which fits in Kaggle's 30 free hours per week. - **One lesson from this run:** the uploaded zip must contain `reports/logs/rl/apf_tuning.jsonl`, or Kaggle's classical comparison runs untuned. Always re-test on the laptop (`docs/KAGGLE_GUIDE.md`, section 9). - **Choose the new policy by the same rules** (`docs/KAGGLE_GUIDE.md`, section 8), plus one more: closest pair at least 5 m on the real route.

Where RL should **not** be used: choosing the leader (it must be predictable and provable) and motor or attitude control (PX4 does this well).

5. Road to real drones

1. **Hardware per drone:** - a Pixhawk 6C with GPS; - a companion computer (for example a Raspberry Pi 5) running Ubuntu 24.04, ROS 2 Jazzy, MAVROS and this agent, wired to the Pixhawk by serial cable; - a telemetry radio; - a radio or Wi-Fi mesh for the heartbeats between drones; - an RC receiver with a kill switch.
2. **A stable PX4 release.** PX4 is pinned to a release candidate, `v1.18.0-rc1`. Move to the stable release and repeat Phases 0–4 in simulation.
3. **A digital twin.** Measure the real drone (weight, battery, motors, a PX4 flight log) and put the numbers into the simulators, then repeat the tests.
4. **Bench test with the propellers off,** then one real drone with nine simulated ones. The set-up is `config/profiles/mixed.yaml`: only the connection address changes. Every step follows `docs/FLIGHT_TEST_PLAN.md`: geofence, RC override, kill switch, go/no-go checklist.
5. **Three real drones** in an open field with safety pilots; only then more.
6. **Legal permission first.** Check the current drone rules of the civil aviation authority (in Pakistan, the PCAA) and any local permission needed before buying or flying.

6. Keeping the project healthy

- **Versions:**
- ROS 2 Jazzy and Ubuntu 24.04 are long-term releases, supported until about 2029.
- Pin the Python packages in `requirements.txt` (section 1) so results can be repeated.
- Stay on PX4 `v1.18.0-rc1` until the stable release has been tested.
- **Evidence habit:** keep the rule that every claim comes with a log, and re-run the fresh-clone check before every release.
- **Backups:** GitHub holds the code, history and tags. The Kaggle notebooks (`rafique/swarm-rl-train-seed1`, `-seed2`) hold their training output. The chosen policy and both result sets are already in the repository.

7. What to do first

#	Item	Why	Effort (estimate)	Who
1	Choose a licence; scan the history for secrets	nothing can be shared safely without these	1 hour	owner decides, then a short task
2	Level 1 one-click setup + automatic check	anyone can try the project in minutes	about half a day	development
3	Hold-down rule against leader flapping	the one known weak point of the election	about 1 day + re-runs (about 8 h of PX4 trials)	owner approves the spec change
4	Height layers when drones cannot hear each other	the main separation risk before real flights	1–2 days + re-runs	development

#	Item	Why	Effort (estimate)	Who
5	Container and Codespaces (level 3)	the full PX4 system in one step on any computer	2-3 days	development
6	Next RL run with a changed set-up, 3 seeds	better in dense clutter; results others can trust	1 day of set-up + about 15 GPU hours	owner approves the quota
7	Real drones: hardware, stable PX4, bench test, flight plan	the goal of the project	weeks; needs hardware and permission	owner

Flight test plan (not flown)

DOCS/FLIGHT_TEST_PLAN.MD

Flight test plan: one real drone with simulated swarm members

Status: not flown. Nothing in this repository has flown on a real drone. This plan describes how the first outdoor test should be prepared and run: one real Pixhawk 6C drone and simulated drones (mixed reality, profile `config/profiles/mixed.yaml`). The safety pilot and the owner must review and sign it before any flight. Every number marked *proposal* is a starting value for them to confirm, not a tested limit.

1. Purpose and scope

- **Goal:** check that the swarm software controls a real drone the way it controls simulated ones: take-off, V formation, a short leg to a goal, leader failover, separation, landing.
- **Set-up:** the real drone is drone 1 or 2; the other drones are PX4 SIH instances on the ground computer. All agents, MAVROS and the link emulator run on the ground computer; the real drone's MAVROS talks to it over a SIK telemetry radio pair (the link the Phase 6 radio stand-in imitates).
- **Out of scope:** payloads, anything that engages objects, flights beyond visual line of sight, more than one real drone, flights near people or buildings.

2. Before a field day is planned

All of these must be true; the evidence is in `reports/` and `docs/`.

Precondition	Where it is recorded
Phase 4 (fault trials on PX4) passed	<code>reports/PHASE_4.md</code>
Phase 5 (radio realism) passed, including the radio settings that will be used	<code>reports/PHASE_5.md</code>
Phase 6 radio stand-in test passed (F1 and F2 with drone 1 behind the stand-in)	<code>reports/PHASE_6.md</code>
PX4 on the real drone is a stable release (not the v1.18.0-rc1 used in simulation), and the simulation tests were re-run with that same release	<code>docs/KNOWN_ISSUES.md</code> , road to real drones
A reviewed way to start the real drone exists. The simulation tools in this repository refuse any profile with a real drone, on purpose	<code>src/swarm_tools/sim_launch.py</code> , <code>src/swarm_tools/profiles.py</code>
The same mission, with the same configuration and profile, passed in simulation on the day before	a simulation run folder under <code>reports/logs/</code>
Written permission: the national civil aviation authority (in Pakistan, the Pakistan Civil Aviation Authority), any local authority, and the landowner	copies kept with the test records

3. Team and roles

At least three people. Each role has one person; nobody holds two roles during a flight.

Role	Duties
Test director	Runs the go/no-go poll, reads the test card, calls each step, decides to continue or stop.
Safety pilot	Holds the RC transmitter of the real drone for the whole flight, watches the drone (not a screen), takes control or uses the kill switch. Has the final word on safety.
Ground station operator	Starts and watches the swarm software and QGroundControl, announces leader changes, battery and link quality, triggers only the planned faults.
Observer	Watches the sky and the ground around the area; calls "abort" when a person, vehicle or aircraft comes near.

Standard callouts, repeated back by the person addressed: **"Taking control"** (safety pilot), **"Abort"** (anyone), **"Kill"** (safety pilot only).

4. Site, airspace and weather

- An open, flat field: no buildings, trees, power lines or roads inside the flight area, and nobody but the team within 50 m beyond the geofence (*proposal*).
- Outside controlled or restricted airspace; below the maximum height the permission allows.
- The whole flight in visual line of sight of the safety pilot.
- Weather: wind below 6 m/s (*proposal*, and within the drone's own limit), no rain, good visibility.

5. Configuration

5.1 Swarm software (ground computer)

Setting	Value for the test	Where
Shared-frame origin	the take-off point in the field	<code>config/swarm.yaml</code> , <code>origin</code>
Geofence	radius 150 m, ceiling 30 m (<i>proposal</i>), smaller than the drone's own PX4 geofence	<code>config/swarm.yaml</code> , <code>safety</code>
Cruise height and speed	20 m, 3 m/s (<i>proposal</i>)	<code>config/swarm.yaml</code> , <code>mission</code>
Goal	about 100 m from home, inside the geofence	<code>config/swarm.yaml</code> , <code>mission</code>
Real drone	its swarm ID, the ground radio's serial device and baud rate (57600), <code>mav_sys_id</code> equal to its ID; check with <code>scripts/check_profile.py</code>	<code>config/profiles/mixed.yaml</code>

Setting	Value for the test	Where
Telemetry radio	the same settings as in the Phase 6 stand-in test (air rate, error correction, MAX_WINDOW)	the radio's own settings; <code>config/swarm.yaml</code> , <code>radio_standin</code>
The real drone's agent	started with <code>--radio-link</code> , so it asks PX4 for position at 5 Hz and allows 1 s without autopilot data, as in the Phase 6 stand-in test	<code>launch/swarm.launch.py</code> <code>radio_ids=<id>;</code> <code>config/swarm.yaml</code> , <code>radio_standin</code>
MAVROS of the real drone	time sync at 1 Hz instead of 10 Hz (<code>/**/time timesync_rate</code>)	<code>src/swarm_tools/sim_launch.py</code> , <code>mavros_radio_params</code>

5.2 The real drone (PX4 parameters)

Parameter names were checked in the PX4 v1.18.0-rc1 source; check them again in the stable release that is flown. Export the full parameter file after setting them and keep it with the test records.

Parameter	Setting	Why
<code>MAV_SYS_ID</code>	the drone's swarm ID	the swarm software addresses the drone by it
<code>SER_TEL1_BAUD</code>	57600	the radio's serial speed (SiK default <code>SERIAL_SPEED 57</code>)
<code>MAV_0_MODE</code>	7 (Minimal)	the set of messages PX4 sends over the radio; the default 0 (Normal) sends many the swarm does not use, and at 1200 B/s leaves position at about 1 Hz
<code>MAV_0_RATE</code>	1200 B/s (default)	PX4's cap on the radio link; it lowers every message rate to stay under it. With 20 Hz setpoints, the swarm's radio traffic plans for 65 % of the radio (<code>config/swarm.yaml</code> , <code>radio_standin</code>)
<code>GF_ACTION</code>	3 (Return)	the autopilot's own geofence, independent of the swarm software (default 2, Hold)
<code>GF_MAX_HOR_DIST</code> / <code>GF_MAX_VER_DIST</code>	200 m / 40 m (<i>proposal</i>)	larger than the software geofence; the default 0 means off
<code>COM_OBL_RC_ACT</code>	0 (Position mode, default)	what the drone does when the offboard setpoint stream stops
<code>COM_OF_LOSS_T</code>	1.0 s (default)	how long the stream may stop before that
<code>NAV_RCL_ACT</code> / <code>COM_RC_LOSS_T</code>	2 (Return, default) / 0.5 s (default)	loss of the RC transmitter
<code>NAV_DLL_ACT</code> / <code>COM_DL_LOSS_T</code>	3 (Land) / 5 s (<i>proposal</i>)	loss of the ground link; the default 0 does nothing
<code>COM_LOW_BAT_ACT</code>	3 (Return at critical, land at emergency)	the default 0 only warns
<code>BAT_LOW_THR</code> / <code>BAT_CRIT_THR</code> / <code>BAT_EMERGEN_THR</code>	0.30 / 0.20 / 0.10 (<i>proposal</i> ; defaults 0.15 / 0.07 / 0.05)	a larger margin for test flights
<code>RC_MAP_KILL_SW</code>	a dedicated two-position switch	the kill switch
<code>MAN_OVERRIDE_SPD</code>	1 (default; never negative)	moving the sticks gives control back to the pilot in Position mode
<code>RC_MAP_FLTMODE</code>	Position, Land and Return on the mode switch	quick manual modes for the safety pilot
<code>MPC_XY_VEL_MAX</code> / <code>MPC_Z_VEL_MAX_UP</code> / <code>MPC_Z_VEL_MAX_DN</code>	5 / 2 / 1.5 m/s (<i>proposal</i> ; defaults 12 / 3 / 1.5)	slower flight leaves more time to react
<code>RTL_RETURN_ALT</code>	25 m (<i>proposal</i> ; default 60 m is above the test ceiling)	Return stays inside the permitted height

6. Go / no-go checklist (every flight)

The test director reads each line; the named person answers "check". Any "no" means no flight.

1. Permissions and this plan signed and on site. (*test director*)
2. Area clear, observer in position, everyone knows the callouts. (*observer*)
3. Wind and visibility within limits. (*safety pilot*)
4. Flight battery, RC transmitter and ground computer charged; spares ready. (*safety pilot*)
5. Propellers, frame, motors and battery mount inspected. (*safety pilot*)
6. GPS 3-D fix, no pre-arm errors in QGroundControl. (*ground station operator*)
7. Parameters match section 5.2 (compare the exported file). (*ground station operator*)
8. Kill switch tested **with propellers off**: armed, switch on, motors stop and stay stopped. (*safety pilot*)
9. Stick override tested (propellers off, offboard mode): moving the sticks switches to Position mode. (*safety pilot*)
10. Radio link: signal strength and loss shown as good in QGroundControl. (*ground station operator*)
11. Software: the git commit or tag is written on the test card, the tests pass, `scripts/check_profile.py` says the profile is valid, logging is on (PX4 ULog and the swarm logs). (*ground station operator*)
12. Everyone says "go". (*test director*)

7. Test sequence

One step per flight. A step is repeated until it passes; the next step starts only after that.

Step	What flies	Pass when
1. Bench, propellers off	connect, arm and disarm from the software, enter and leave offboard mode, kill switch, stick override	every action works on the first try

Step	What flies	Pass when
2. Manual flight	the safety pilot hovers, flies Position mode, triggers Return and Land	normal handling, no warnings
3. Real drone alone	the swarm software takes off to 10 m, hovers 30 s, lands (like Phase 0)	height error under 1 m, clean landing
4. Real drone as leader	drone 1 real with simulated followers; the short V leg to the goal and back	the V forms around it, no warnings, landing at home
5. Real drone as follower	a profile with the real drone as drone 2; simulated leader	it holds its slot within 2 m during cruise
6. Planned faults	only faults that keep the real drone's motors running: the simulated leader is killed (the real drone may take over); the real leader's battery handover (it hands over and returns home); the real leader's heartbeats are cut in the link emulator (the others elect a new leader; the real drone hears it, steps down and follows)	the behaviour matches the Phase 4 results

The real drone's motors are never stopped as a "fault": killing its processes or cutting its RC link in flight is not part of this plan.

8. Abort criteria

Any one of these ends the flight at once:

- anyone calls "Abort";
- a person, vehicle or aircraft comes near the area;
- the real drone leaves the planned area, flies higher than planned, or moves in a way nobody expected (oscillation, drifting away, a wrong direction);
- the software shows two leaders, or no leader, for more than 3 s;
- the real drone comes within 5 m of any other drone (real or simulated) or of any object;
- the radio link drops for more than 1 s, GPS degrades, or PX4 reports an estimator error;
- the battery reaches the planned landing level, or the wind rises above the limit.

How to abort, in this order: 1. The safety pilot calls "Taking control", moves the sticks (the drone switches to Position mode) and lands. 2. If the drone does not respond: switch to Land, or to Return if landing in place is not safe. 3. The kill switch only as a last resort (section 9).

9. Kill-switch procedure

- **When:** only when stopping the motors in the air is safer than any other action, for example a flyaway toward people, or a fire.
- **How:** the safety pilot calls "Kill", sets the kill switch and keeps it set. The motors stop and the drone falls.
- **After:** wait until the propellers have stopped; approach only when told by the safety pilot; watch the battery for smoke or swelling before touching it; disconnect it; save the logs; record what happened.

10. After each flight

- Download the PX4 ULog and the swarm logs; note battery voltage and flight time.
- Compare the flight with the same mission in simulation: formation error; leader changes, separation.
- Debrief: what worked, what did not, anything unexpected. Decide go or no-go for the next step.

11. Test card (one per flight)

Date and time; site; team and roles; weather; git commit or tag; profile; exported parameter file; step; result (pass or fail); aborts and why; log file names; signatures of the test director and the safety pilot.

Kaggle training guide

DOCS/KAGGLE_GUIDE.MD

Kaggle training guide: long RL training on a GPU

Status (29 September 2026): done once, with two seeds. Two 10.5-hour runs on a T4 GPU (28-29 September, about 143,000 steps per second, 5.5 and 5.8 billion steps). Seed 2's policy passed the checks of section 8 and is now `models/avoid_policy.npz`: RL + brake completes 30, 23 and 18 of 30 unseen courses (few, medium, dense), against 26, 18 and 5 for the laptop policy. Both runs stopped improving after about 2.5 hours, so a next run should change the set-up (section 11) rather than only run longer. One lesson: the uploaded zip must contain `reports/logs/rl/apf_tuning.jsonl`, or Kaggle's classical row runs untuned; re-test on the laptop (section 9). Results: `docs/RESULTS.md`, "Obstacle avoidance". This file explains, step by step: which files to take, how to start the training on Kaggle, what gets trained, what problem it solves, how to change things, where to paste every file when training is finished, and what you get at the end. Section 12 has the whole procedure on one page.

In short. One command on the laptop builds a zip file. Upload it to Kaggle as a dataset, import our notebook, switch the GPU on and press "Save & Run All". About 11 hours later Kaggle gives you `results.zip`, which holds the newly trained policy (`best_policy.npz`) and its test results. If the new results are better than the old ones, put `best_policy.npz` in place of `models/avoid_policy.npz`: the app and the drones then use the new policy on their own. Details in section 12 and below.

1. What gets trained (in simple words)

Only one thing: the **obstacle-avoidance brain of the followers** — a small neural network.

- **Inputs (47 numbers, 10 times a second):** where the formation wants the drone to go (desired velocity), the drone's own velocity, how far it is from its place in the V, 24 distance readings around the drone (like a 2-D lidar, up to 25 m), the closest obstacle point, and the three nearest drones. Everything is turned into the formation's own frame (forward/left), so the same network works whichever way the route points (`src/swarm_agent/avoidance.py`).
- **Output (2 numbers):** a sideways/forward velocity correction (up to 8 m/s per axis) added to the formation command. The hard safety layer (drone-to-drone repulsion, geofence) and — in the "RL + brake" option — a stopping-distance brake stay on top of it.
- **Network:** 47 inputs → 128 → 128 (tanh) → 2 outputs. After training it is saved as plain numpy weights (`.npz`, about 180 KB), so the drone needs no machine-learning library.
- **How it learns:** PPO (a standard reinforcement-learning method). One shared network drives all nine followers. On the GPU, 1024 missions run at the same time (`src/swarm_tools/torch_sim.py`, checked step by step against the laptop simulator by `tests/test_torch_sim.py`).
- **What it is rewarded for (per follower, every 0.1 s):** staying close to its slot in the V, getting closer to it, small corrections; it is penalised for coming within 4 m of an obstacle, for coming closer than 5 m to another drone, and heavily (−10) for a crash. The exact formula is in `src/swarm_tools/obstacle_sim.py` (search for `# rewards for the followers`).
- **Training courses:** random routes of 300–600 m through random buildings and tree clusters (0–2 buildings and 0–1 tree clusters per hectare), 8,000 different courses.

What is **not** trained: the leader election, the formation law, the leader's route planner (A*), the autopilot. Those are rules and stay exactly as they are (see `docs/DECISIONS.md`, 14 and 17).

2. What problem it solves, and what it will not

The laptop training (6 million steps, 38 minutes on the CPU) produced the current policy. On 90 test courses it never saw (`docs/RESULTS.md`):

Method	Few obstacles	Medium	Dense
Classical (tuned)	15/30	7/30	3/30
RL + brake (laptop policy)	26/30	18/30	5/30

Two open problems:

1. **The training was still improving when it stopped** (`reports/rl_training.png`). Dense clutter is unsolved (5 of 30). Longer training — about 10 hours on a GPU per session instead of 38 minutes on the CPU — should reduce crashes, most of all at medium and high density. How much is unknown until it is measured.
2. **One training run proves little.** Training again with seeds 2 and 3 shows whether the result repeats; that is needed before anyone presents the result as reliable.

It will **not** fix: the simplified physics, the 2-D obstacles (no flying over), the perfect sensing assumed in simulation, or the radio-split separation weak spot (`docs/KNOWN_ISSUES.md`).

3. What you need

- A Kaggle account (free). Kaggle may ask you to verify a phone number before GPUs can be switched on.
- GPU time: every run uses one session of up to 12 hours (Kaggle's limit for GPU notebooks, from kaggle.com/docs/notebooks). Your weekly GPU quota is shown in your Kaggle account settings; plan one session per seed, so three sessions for seeds 1–3.
- On the laptop: this repository. Nothing has to be installed on Kaggle: PyTorch is already in Kaggle's image and the notebook installs nothing, so it runs with Internet off.

4. Which files to take

Only **two files** go to Kaggle:

File on the laptop	What it is	How it gets to Kaggle
kaggle/swarm-rl-code.zip	all the code (src/, scripts/, config/, cached map data data/osm/, pyproject.toml), about 0.5 MB	uploaded as a private Dataset named <code>swarm-rl-code</code>
kaggle/train_swarm_rl.ipynb	the notebook that runs everything	imported as a notebook

Make the zip fresh every time (it is not in git), from the repository root:

```
python3 scripts/make_kaggle_bundle.py
```

It prints `wrote ../kaggle/swarm-rl-code.zip (N files, 0.5 MB; no *.local.* files, no map keys)`. Your map keys (`config/map_keys.local.yaml`) are never packed: the script skips `*.local.*` files and refuses to build if any packed file contains one of your key values. (Fixed on 27 September 2026 — an earlier zip had included the keys file; that zip was never uploaded.)

5. Starting the training on kaggle.com, click by click

1. **Upload the code.** kaggle.com → **Create** → **New Dataset** → drag `kaggle/swarm-rl-code.zip` in → title `swarm-rl-code` → keep it **Private** → **Create**. (Kaggle may unpack the zip; the notebook handles both cases.)
2. **Import the notebook.** **Create** → **New Notebook** → menu **File** → **Import Notebook** → choose `kaggle/train_swarm_rl.ipynb`.
3. **Attach the code.** In the notebook's right-hand panel: **Input** → **Add Input** → search for your `swarm-rl-code` dataset → **Add**.
4. **Switch the GPU on.** Right-hand panel → **Session options** → **Accelerator** → **GPU T4 x2** (the trainer uses one GPU; on 28 September 2026 Kaggle no longer offered the P100). Internet can stay off.
5. **Choose the seed.** In the first code cell: `SEED = 1` (later runs: 2, 3). Leave `HOURS = 10.5` and `STEPS = 6e9`.
6. **Run it as a background job:** **Save Version** → **Save & Run All (Commit)** → **Save**. This runs on Kaggle's machines from top to bottom even if you close the browser or switch the laptop off. (Do not just press "Run all" in the editor: an interactive session stops after 20 minutes without activity.)
7. **Watch it (optional).** Open the notebook's page → the running version → **Logs**. Every few minutes a line like `step 74,317,824 fps 142,684 ret 56.012 success 0.31 crash_free 0.31 ...` appears (the numbers are from seed 1 on 28 September 2026), and every 30 minutes an `[eval] {...}` line with the scores on the validation courses.

What the notebook does, and how long it takes:

Cell	What happens	Time
1	prints the GPU name (must say <code>CUDA True</code>), unpacks the code	seconds
2	builds the courses: 8,000 training, 90 validation (to pick the best policy), 90 test (for the final report only)	~5 min
3	trains on the GPU for <code>HOURS = 10.5</code> h (or until <code>STEPS = 6e9</code> steps, whichever comes first); checkpoint every 20 min; scores the 90 validation courses every 30 min and keeps the best policy	10.5 h
4	final fair test on the CPU with exactly the laptop's method: 90 test courses (<code>scripts/rl_eval.py</code>) and the real Islamabad map route (<code>scripts/rl_eval_route.py</code>)	~20–30 min
5	packs everything into <code>/kaggle/working/results.zip</code>	seconds

The code cells are numbered from the top (the text cell above them does not count); each one starts with a comment such as `# Cell 3: training on the GPU`.

Total about 11 hours, inside Kaggle's 12-hour limit. The trainer stops itself when `HOURS` are used up and saves everything first, so nothing is lost at the limit.

Speed measured on a T4 (28 September 2026): about 140,000 steps per second, some 54 times the laptop. At that speed the trainer's own default target of $3e9$ steps is reached after about 6 hours, so the notebook sets `STEPS = 6e9`: the 10.5-hour limit then ends the session at about $5.3e9$ steps. Kaggle accepted two GPU runs at the same time (seeds 1 and 2); each uses about 11 of the 30 weekly GPU hours.

Fairness rule (important). The best policy is chosen on the 90 *validation* courses (`val.npz`, seeds 1,000,000–1,000,029). The reported results use the 90 *test* courses (`heldout.npz`, seeds 1,000,100–1,000,129) that neither training nor selection ever saw — the same courses as the laptop comparison, so the numbers are directly comparable. Never pass `heldout.npz` to the trainer. (This was also fixed on 27 September 2026; before that the kit would have chosen the policy on the test courses.)

6. When the run is finished: what to download

On the notebook page open the finished version → **Output** tab → download `results.zip` (a few MB). Unzip it, for example to `~/Downloads/results/`. Inside (for seed 1):

In results.zip	What it is
<code>run_seed1/best_policy.npz</code>	the new brain — the policy with the best validation score
<code>run_seed1/policy.npz</code>	the policy at the very end of training (usually not the one to use)
<code>run_seed1/progress.csv</code>	training log: steps, speed, return, success, crashes, losses (one row per update)
<code>run_seed1/eval.jsonl</code>	validation scores every 30 minutes, per density level
<code>run_seed1/ckpt.pt</code>	full checkpoint (network, optimiser, step count) to continue training later
<code>run_seed1/status.json</code> , <code>session_*.json</code>	how far it got, and the exact settings and GPU of the session
<code>eval_seed1/summary.md</code> , <code>summary.json</code> , <code>episodes.jsonl</code> , <code>comparison.png</code>	the fair test: all five methods on the 90 test courses, same table as the laptop's
<code>route_eval_seed1/summary.md</code> , <code>episodes.jsonl</code>	the real-map test: F-9 Park → Faisal Mosque, 932 buildings, 5 runs, with and without the leader killed

7. Where to paste each file (on the laptop)

From results.zip	Paste it here in the repository	Why
the whole <code>run_seed1/</code> folder	<code>reports/logs/rl/kaggle_seed1/</code>	the training record (evidence)
the whole <code>eval_seed1/</code> folder	<code>reports/logs/rl/eval_kaggle_seed1/</code>	the fair comparison
the whole <code>route_eval_seed1/</code> folder	<code>reports/logs/rl/route_eval_kaggle_seed1/</code>	the real-map result
<code>run_seed1/best_policy.npz</code>	<code>models/avoid_policy.npz</code> — only if it is better (section 8); first rename the old one to <code>models/avoid_policy_run1.npz</code>	the app, the simulators and the agent all read this file

The same as commands, from the repository root:

```
mkdir -p reports/logs/rl/kaggle_seed1
cp -r ~/Downloads/results/run_seed1/. reports/logs/rl/kaggle_seed1/
cp -r ~/Downloads/results/eval_seed1 reports/logs/rl/eval_kaggle_seed1
cp -r ~/Downloads/results/route_eval_seed1 reports/logs/rl/route_eval_kaggle_seed1
```

Only after the check in section 8 says it is better:

```
git mv models/avoid_policy.npz models/avoid_policy_run1.npz
cp reports/logs/rl/kaggle_seed1/best_policy.npz models/avoid_policy.npz
```

For seeds 2 and 3 use `kaggle_seed2`, `eval_kaggle_seed2`, ... in the same way.

8. Is the new policy better? (decide before replacing)

Open `reports/logs/rl/eval_kaggle_seed1/summary.md` next to the laptop's `reports/logs/rl/eval/summary.md` and compare the **RL + brake** row (laptop: 26/30, 18/30, 5/30).

Use the new policy if all of these hold:

1. RL + brake completes at least as many test courses at every density, and more in total;
2. its crashes per mission are not higher than the laptop policy's at any density;
3. in `route_eval_kaggle_seed1/summary.md`, RL + brake still has 0 drones that hit something (laptop: 0 in 5 runs, with and without the leader killed).

If only some hold, keep the laptop policy and write the result down anyway (a negative result is still a result). With several seeds, pick the seed whose policy is best on these rules and report all seeds, not only the best one.

9. After replacing: check on the laptop and update the documents

```
# 1. the same test on the laptop (should give the same numbers as eval_seed1; takes ~9 min)
PYTHONPATH=src python3 scripts/rl_eval.py --policy models/avoid_policy.npz --out reports/logs/rl/eval_kaggle_check
PYTHONPATH=src python3 scripts/rl_eval_route.py --policy models/avoid_policy.npz --out reports/logs/rl/route_eval_kaggle_check
# 2. learning curve of the Kaggle run
python3 scripts/plot_rl_training.py reports/logs/rl/kaggle_seed1 --out reports/rl_training_kaggle_seed1.png
# 3. tests still pass
python3 -m pytest
```

Then write the new numbers into `docs/RESULTS.md` (the table under "Obstacle avoidance"), rebuild the documents and commit:

```
PYTHONPATH=src python3 scripts/make_brief.py
PYTHONPATH=src python3 scripts/make_handover_pdf.py
git add models reports docs && git commit -m "RL: Kaggle seed 1 policy, results"
```

10. What you get at the end

- A new `models/avoid_policy.npz`. The ground-control app uses it the next time it starts (avoidance options "RL policy" and "RL policy + brake"), and so do the fast simulator, the evaluation scripts and the drone agent — no code change.
- A fair, reproducible comparison against the classical avoider on the same 90 test courses, plus the real-map result, with all raw logs in `reports/logs/rl/`.
- Learning curves showing whether more training still helps.
- With seeds 2 and 3: evidence that the result repeats (or does not).
- A checkpoint (`ckpt.pt`) to continue training later without starting again.

11. How to change things

To change	Where	Notes
seed	notebook cell 1, <code>SEED</code>	1, 2, 3 ...; each seed is a separate run
training time per session	notebook cell 1, <code>HOURS</code>	keep ≤ 10.5 so pools + evaluation fit in 12 h
number of parallel missions	cell 3, <code>'--envs', '1024'</code>	lower to 512 on "CUDA out of memory"
network size	cell 3, add <code>'--hidden', '256', '256'</code>	the app reads any number of layers; bigger is slower
learning rate	cell 3, add <code>'--lr', '1e-4'</code>	default 3e-4

To change	Where	Notes
total step target (all sessions)	notebook cell 1, <code>STEPS</code>	6e9; on a T4 the 10.5 h limit comes first (about 5.3e9 steps). Raise it (e.g. 12e9) before continuing a seed, or the next session stops almost at once
how often it checkpoints / scores	'--checkpoint-min' (20), '--eval-min' (30)	minutes
exploration noise at the start	'--log-std-init' (-1.0)	lower = calmer start
reward	<code>src/swarm_tools/obstacle_sim.py</code> and <code>src/swarm_tools/torch_sim.py</code>	the two must stay identical: change both, then run <code>PYTHONPATH=src .venv/bin/python -m pytest tests/test_torch_sim.py</code> on the laptop
obstacle density of the training courses	<code>SimCfg.building_density</code> , <code>SimCfg.tree_density</code> in <code>obstacle_sim.py</code>	the test levels (<code>LEVELS</code> in <code>rl_eval.py</code> / <code>build_pools.py</code>) stay fixed so results remain comparable
inputs of the network	<code>avoidance.py</code> <code>observation()</code> and the batched version in <code>torch_sim.py</code>	changes <code>OBS_DIM</code> : old policies stop loading (the loader says so); retrain from scratch
number of drones	'--drones' (10)	also pass <code>--drones</code> to the evaluation scripts

Every code change needs a new zip on Kaggle: run `python3 scripts/make_kaggle_bundle.py`, open your `swarm-rl-code` dataset on Kaggle → **New Version** → upload the new zip; in the notebook's **Input** panel make sure the latest dataset version is attached; then **Save & Run All** again.

Continue a seed that stopped at the time limit (the log ends with `[budget] ... saved` and `status.json` says `"done": false`): in a new version of the notebook, **Add Input** → the previous version's output (search your notebook's name), raise `STEPS` in cell 1 (for example to 12e9), and insert this cell after cell 2:

```
import glob, shutil
prev = glob.glob('/kaggle/input/**/run_seed1', recursive=True)[0]
shutil.copytree(prev, '/kaggle/working/run_seed1', dirs_exist_ok=True)
```

The trainer finds `ckpt.pt` and continues from the saved step, keeping the best score so far.

12. The whole procedure on one page

What gets trained? Only the followers' obstacle-avoidance policy, a small neural network. Every 0.1 s it reads 47 numbers (where the formation wants the drone to go, its own speed, its distance from its place in the V, the distance to walls and trees in 24 directions, the three nearest drones) and returns 2 numbers: how much to change its velocity. The leader election, the formation rules and the autopilot are not trained; they are rules and stay as they are.

Which problem does it solve? The laptop training ran for 38 minutes and was still improving when it stopped. In dense clutter only 5 of 30 missions succeed today. About 10 hours on Kaggle's GPU should reduce crashes; by how much can only be measured. Seeds 2 and 3 show whether the result repeats.

Which files to take? Only two: 1. `kaggle/swarm-rl-code.zip`: first run `python3 scripts/make_kaggle_bundle.py` on the laptop, which builds a fresh zip (your map keys are never included). 2. `kaggle/train_swarm_rl.ipynb`: the notebook.

How to run it on Kaggle: 1. `kaggle.com` → Create → New Dataset → upload the zip → name `swarm-rl-code` → Private → Create. 2. Create → New Notebook → File → Import Notebook → choose `train_swarm_rl.ipynb`. 3. Right-hand panel: Input → Add Input → add your `swarm-rl-code` dataset. 4. Session options → Accelerator → GPU T4 x2. Internet can stay off. 5. Keep `SEED = 1` in the first cell (next time 2, then 3), `HOURS = 10.5` and `STEPS = 6e9`. 6. Save Version → **Save & Run All (Commit)** → Save. Kaggle keeps running even if you switch the laptop off. It takes about 11 hours.

When training has finished: 1. On the notebook's page open that version's **Output** tab → download `results.zip` → unzip it into `~/Downloads/results/`. 2. Paste these folders into the project (or copy the commands from section 7): `- run_seed1/ → reports/logs/rl/kaggle_seed1/ - eval_seed1/ → reports/logs/rl/eval_kaggle_seed1/ - route_eval_seed1/ → reports/logs/rl/route_eval_kaggle_seed1/` 3. Compare the "RL + brake" line in `eval_kaggle_seed1/summary.md` with the old one (26/30, 18/30, 5/30). Only if it is equal or better at every density, crashes are not higher, and the Islamabad route still has 0 hits, switch to the new policy: rename `models/avoid_policy.npz` to `avoid_policy_run1.npz` and copy `run_seed1/best_policy.npz` to `models/avoid_policy.npz`. 4. Re-check on the laptop with the commands in section 9, write the new numbers into `docs/RESULTS.md`, rebuild the PDF, commit.

What you get at the end: a new `models/avoid_policy.npz`. The app's "RL policy" and "RL policy + brake" options, the simulators and the drone agent use it without any code change. Plus a fair comparison (the same 90 test courses as on the laptop), the real-map result, and the training curves.

To change something: seed and hours in the notebook's first code cell; everything else in the third cell (table in section 11). If you change code, build a new zip and upload it as a "New Version" of the Kaggle dataset. To change the reward, change `obstacle_sim.py` and `torch_sim.py` in the same way and run `tests/test_torch_sim.py` to check they still match.

13. When something goes wrong

What you see	Cause and fix
cell 1 prints <code>CUDA False</code>	the GPU is not on: Session options → Accelerator → GPU (phone verification may be needed)
cell 1: <code>IndexError: list index out of range</code>	the <code>swarm-rl-code</code> dataset is not attached: Input → Add Input
<code>CUDA out of memory</code>	use '--envs', '512' in cell 3
the version stops at 12 h without <code>results.zip</code>	<code>HOURS</code> too high or the evaluation was slow: set <code>HOURS = 10</code> , and continue the seed (section 11)
the version shows "Error"	open Logs , read the last lines; fix, make a new zip if the code changed, Save & Run All again
<code>policy expects N inputs, this code builds 47</code> when loading a policy	the policy was trained with a different input layout; retrain, or use the matching code version
the laptop check gives different numbers than <code>eval_seed1</code>	should not happen (same scripts, same courses); check that the laptop code is the same version as the zip
the app does not offer the RL options	<code>models/avoid_policy.npz</code> is missing
training <code>success</code> in the log stays at 0 for hours	normal in the first hour; if it never rises, compare the <code>[eval]</code> lines with <code>reports/logs/rl/run1/eval.jsonl</code> and check the reward change you made

Appendix A - Phase 0 report

REPORTS/PHASE_0.MD

Phase 0 — Environment audit and setup

Status: PASSED

Acceptance criteria

- [PASS] One SIH drone + one MAVROS instance: script arms, takes off to 10 m, hovers 20 s, lands. Evidence: `scripts/phase0_flight_test.py`, run twice, both "result": "PASS":
- run 1: `reports/logs/phase_0/run1/flight_summary.json`, `flight_altitude.csv` (518 rows, 10 Hz)
- cross-check run (after `pkill`, from a clean `env -i` shell): `reports/logs/phase_0/run2_crosscheck/flight_summary.json`, `flight_altitude.csv`
- plot of altitude over time: `reports/phase0_altitude.png`
- PX4 console confirms `Landing detected / Disarmed by landing (run*/px4_1.log)`
- [PASS] Peak RAM for 1 drone (PX4 + MAVROS) measured and recorded: **135.0 MB** (PX4 10.1 MB + MAVROS 124.9 MB), kernel peak RSS (VmHWM from `/proc/<pid>/status`), matching the 10 Hz sampled peak exactly. Evidence: `run2_crosscheck/flight_summary.json` (`peak_rss_vmhwm_mb`, `peak_rss_sampled_mb`). Run 1 (sampled only): 135.2 MB.

Phase 0 tasks: - [DONE] Environment recorded: `reports/logs/phase_0/env_audit.txt`, `env_audit_crosscheck.txt`. - [SKIPPED — user's request] ntfy test. The user said not to bother with phone notifications. `scripts/notify.sh` exits 0 silently because `~/config/swarm-ntfy/topic` does not exist. - [DONE] Installed PX4 toolchain (`ubuntu.sh --no-nuttx --no-sim-tools`), `ros-jazzy-mavros` 2.15.1, GeographicLib datasets: `sudo_installs.log`, `geographiclib_datasets.txt`. - [DONE] Built `px4_sitl_sih` with 2 jobs: `px4_build.log` (`BUILD_EXIT=0`, [784/784]). - [DONE] Repo skeleton: `config/`, `src/swarm_agent/`, `src/swarm_tools/`, `tests/`, `scripts/`, `reports/`.

Key numbers

Item	Value	Source
OS	Ubuntu 24.04.5 LTS, kernel 7.0.0-34-generic, x86_64	<code>env_audit.txt</code>
ROS 2	Jazzy (<code>ROS_DISTRO=jazzy</code>)	<code>env_audit.txt</code>
Python	3.12.3	<code>env_audit.txt</code>
RAM	7721 MiB (8,097 MB) total; available 2357–3150 MiB (<code>free -m</code>) / 3,267–3,287 MB (<code>psutil</code>) during this phase, with Chrome open (~3.1 GB)	<code>env_audit*.txt</code> , <code>flight_summary.json</code>
CPU	Intel i3-1115G4, 2 cores / 4 threads	<code>env_audit.txt</code>
Free disk	131 GB before, 128 GB after the PX4 build (need ≥ 15 GB)	<code>env_audit.txt</code> , <code>env_audit_crosscheck.txt</code>
PX4	v1.18.0-rc1, target <code>px4_sitl_sih</code> , model <code>sihsim_quadx</code>	<code>env_audit_crosscheck.txt</code>
MAVROS	2.15.1 (apt)	<code>env_audit_crosscheck.txt</code>
PX4 build (resumed run)	2 min 12 s wall; largest single process 383,512 kB (≈ 393 MB); <code>ninja -j2</code>	<code>px4_build.log</code>

Flight test	Run 1	Cross-check
MAVROS connected after launch	1.3 s	1.3 s
OFFBOARD + armed	2.0 s	1.1 s
Climb 0 → 10 m (±0.3 m)	10.3 s	10.3 s
Hover duration	20.0 s	20.0 s
Hover altitude mean / min / max	10.018 / 9.723 / 10.116 m	9.943 / 9.706 / 10.125 m
AUTO.LAND → disarmed	20.7 s	19.6 s
Final landed_state	1 (ON_GROUND)	1 (ON_GROUND)
Peak RAM PX4 + MAVROS	135.2 MB (sampled)	135.0 MB (VmHWM)

Sources verified (URLs / commands)

- Build target `px4_sitl_sih`, run `make px4_sitl_sih sihsim_quadx`, multi-instance `sitl_multiple_run.sh`, `PX4_HOME_LAT/LON/ALT`: https://docs.px4.io/main/en/sim_sih/
- `boards/px4/sitl/sih.px4board` exists at tag v1.18.0-rc1 and `main`, but **not** at v1.17.0 (latest stable) or v1.16.2 (GitHub raw checks returned 404 at those two tags).
- Ubuntu setup `ubuntu.sh [--no-nuttx] [--no-sim-tools]`, 24.04 supported: https://docs.px4.io/main/en/dev_setup/dev_env_linux_ubuntu. The script was read before running: the `dialout` group change sits inside the NuttX block (lines 126–197), so `--no-nuttx` skips it. A pip dry run showed 16 new packages and **no upgrades** (numpy stays 1.26.4).
- MAVROS install + `install_geographiclib_datasets.sh` + `px4.launch`: <https://github.com/mavlink/mavros/blob/ros2/mavros/README.md>; `/opt/ros/jazzy/share/mavros/launch/{px4.launch,node.launch,px4_config.yaml,px4_pluginlists.yaml}`.
- Offboard: setpoints must stream ≥ 2 Hz before switching into OFFBOARD and while in it (`COM_OF_LOSS_T`, `COM_OBL_RC_ACT`): https://docs.px4.io/main/en/flight_modes/offboard
- Installed PX4 scripts (`build/px4_sitl_sih/etc/init.d-posix/`):
- `px4-rc.mavlink`: offboard link of instance *n* listens on UDP 14580+*n* and sends to 14540+*n* (instances > 9 share 14549)
- `rcS`: `MAV_SYS_ID = instance + 1`; `PX4_SIM_MODEL` selects the airframe by name

- `px4-rc.sihsim: PX4_HOME_* → SIH_LOC_LAT0/LON0/H0`
- `airframes/10040_sihsim_quadx: SIH quad`
- `rcS: battery_simulator` starts when `SIM_BAT_DRAIN > 0` (for Phase 4 F3)
- PX4 Makefile lines 77–107: `-jN` is read from `ps T` (needs a terminal); `j=2` sets it explicitly.
- MAVROS interfaces seen on the running system: `ros2 topic list`, `ros2 service list (/uav1/mavros/state, local_position/pose, global_position/rel_alt, extended_state, setpoint_velocity/cmd_vel, cmd/arming, set_mode)`, plus the message/service definitions (`mavros_interfaces.txt`, `/opt/ros/jazzy/share/mavros_msgs/msg/State.msg`).

Problems and fixes

1. **The build target in docs/SPECIFICATION.md is missing from stable PX4.** `px4_sitl_sih` is absent from v1.17.0, so PX4 is pinned to **v1.18.0-rc1** (`config/swarm.yaml: sim.px4_version`).
2. **GeographicLib geoid and magnetic downloads failed.** The SourceForge mirror `ver.dl.sourceforge.net` failed its SSL handshake, and the MAVROS script hides errors and still exits 0. Fix: re-downloaded with the same tools (`geographiclib-get-geoids/-magnetic`, retry on a working mirror) into scratch space, then `sudo cp` into `/usr/share/GeographicLib`.
3. **The first build ran 6 parallel jobs**, breaking rule 6. PX4's Makefile only detects `-j2` from a terminal. It was stopped at 344/1160 and resumed with `make px4_sitl_sih j=2 (scripts/build_px4.sh)`; `ninja -j2` confirmed in `ps`.
4. **PX4's startup script breaks on paths with spaces.** The repo path contains one ("drone swarm") and the error was `no autostart file found`. PX4 working dirs now go to `sim.work_dir (/tmp/swarm_sim/<timestamp>/px4_<id>)`: a fresh dir each run, never deleted by our tools. Console logs stay in the repo.
5. **MAVROS aborts on an empty parameter override** (`-p gcs_url:=`). The empty value is the default anyway, so the argument was removed.
6. `ros2 interface show mavros_msgs/msg/State` **printed ExtendedState's fields.** The authoritative `.msg` file and a live `ros2 topic echo` both show the correct State fields.
7. `kill -f px4 (rule 3a)` **also kills the shell that runs it**, because its own command line contains "px4". Replaced with exact-name matching (`kill -x px4; kill -x mavros_node`, and `kill_orphans()` in `src/swarm_tools/sim_launch.py`).

Known limitations / honest caveats

- PX4 v1.18.0-rc1 is a release candidate. Real Pixhawk 6C drones should run the same version when Phase 6 mixed-reality tests happen.
- Two flight runs only; the evidence is for a single drone.
- After auto-disarm, `mavros/state.mode` reads `OFFBOARD` again, because the test still streams setpoints. The vehicle is disarmed on the ground; harmless, noted for Phase 3.
- The takeoff used `OFFBOARD` velocity setpoints (the pipeline Phases 3–6 need), not `AUTO.TAKEOFF`.
- PX4 writes `.ulg` flight logs into `/tmp/swarm_sim/...`; the OS cleans `/tmp`, our tools don't.
- CPU load was not measured in Phase 0 (not required); Phase 1 measures it.

Next phase: what is needed from the user

Nothing. All sudo installs are done. For Phases 1 and 3–5, closing Chrome during multi-drone runs frees about 3 GB of RAM.

Appendix B - Phase 1 report

REPORTS/PHASE_1.MD

Phase 1 — Multi-drone simulation scaling

Status: PASSED — max stable N on this laptop = **10** (the target), with a lean MAVROS plugin list

Acceptance criteria

- [PASS] All N drones arm, take off to 10 m, hover 30 s, and land, with no crashes, for N = 3, 5 and 10. Each N ran twice: once, then again from a clean `env -i` shell after `pskill -x px4; pkill -x mavros_node`. Evidence: `reports/logs/phase_1/n{3,5,10}/summary.json` and `n{3,5,10}_crosscheck/summary.json`, all "result": "PASS", with every criterion true: `all_armed_took_off_to_10m`, `hover_30s`, `all_landed_disarmed` (landed_state 1 for every drone), `no_process_crash` (no PX4/MAVROS process exited before shutdown), `distinct_spawn_positions`. Per-drone altitude traces: `n*/altitude.csv`.
- [PASS] Report of max stable N with RAM/CPU numbers: **N = 10**, 1,074 MB peak RAM for PX4 + MAVROS (107.4 MB per drone), 76.5 % mean system CPU during hover (cross-check run). N = 10 is also the most the PX4 SITL port plan supports unchanged (`px4-rc.mavlink: instances > 9` share UDP port 14549).

Phase 1 tasks: - [DONE] Launch script for N SIH + N MAVROS instances, each with unique ports and sysid: `src/swarm_tools/sim_launch.py`. PX4 instance `n` gets `-i n`; its offboard link is UDP 14580+`n` ↔ 14540+`n`; `MAV_SYS_ID = n+1`; MAVROS runs in namespace `/uav<id>` with `fcu_url udp://:14540+n@127.0.0.1:14580+n` and `tgt_system n+1`. Serial URLs are refused. - [DONE] Verified spawn positions. Without `PX4_HOME_*`, two instances spawn at the same point (0.02 m apart, PX4 default home 47.3977427, 8.5455942): `spawn_default_check.txt`. Fix: each drone gets its own home via `PX4_HOME_LAT/LON/ALT`, the documented method (`docs.px4.io/main/en/sim_sih/`; mapped to `SIH_LOC_LAT0/LON0/H0` in `px4-rc.sihsim`). The layout is the V formation itself (`formation.initial_layout`, 10 m spacing, apex = lowest ID, facing the goal), so drones take off already in their slots. Measured against plan, from the GPS fix converted to the shared ENU frame: max error 0.19 m, min pair distance 9.75 m. - [DONE] Scaled 3 → 5 → 10, measuring RAM (kernel VmHWM per process) and CPU (psutil, 1 Hz) at each step: `n*/resources.csv`. Plot: `reports/phase1_resources.png`.

Key numbers

Idle laptop, no sim (Opera ≈ 31 % of a core, gnome-shell ≈ 12 %): **14.6 %** system CPU, 3,253 MB available (`idle_baseline.txt`). System CPU is % of all 4 logical CPUs; per-process CPU is % of one core. RAM is decimal MB.

Run	MAVROS plugins	Result	RAM total (MB)	RAM / drone	System CPU hover mean / max	PX4 CPU (all)	MAVROS CPU (all)	Harness CPU	Min available RAM
n3_default_mavros	default	PASS	513.7	171.2	44.1 / 46.7 %	25.0 %	84.7 %	37.4 %	2,867 MB
n5_default_mavros	default	PASS	987.2	197.4	99.7 / 99.9 %	37.7 %	281.4 %	42.8 %	2,650 MB
n3	lean	PASS	288.1	96.0	25.0 / 42.0 %	23.7 %	23.0 %	27.9 %	3,609 MB
n5	lean	PASS	496.4	99.3	41.2 / 45.7 %	38.9 %	44.6 %	52.1 %	3,516 MB
n10	lean	PASS	1,070.9	107.1	76.1 / 77.2 %	72.4 %	116.0 %	82.1 %	3,203 MB
n3_crosscheck	lean	PASS	287.6	95.9	24.9 / 26.3 %	24.2 %	22.8 %	28.0 %	3,766 MB
n5_crosscheck	lean	PASS	496.3	99.3	41.0 / 46.0 %	39.3 %	45.0 %	51.4 %	3,522 MB
n10_crosscheck	lean	PASS	1,074.2	107.4	76.5 / 77.4 %	71.4 %	121.8 %	78.7 %	3,477 MB

Run	Spawn error max	Spawn min pair	Hover min pair	Arm → all at 10 m	Land → all disarmed
n3 / n3_crosscheck	0.10 / 0.11 m	10.09 / 10.08 m	9.18 / 9.13 m	12.3 / 12.2 s	22.4 / 20.3 s
n5 / n5_crosscheck	0.19 / 0.19 m	10.06 / 10.10 m	9.00 / 8.94 m	13.3 / 12.5 s	23.5 / 21.2 s
n10 / n10_crosscheck	0.17 / 0.16 m	9.75 / 9.76 m	8.32 / 9.05 m	13.1 / 13.2 s	23.6 / 25.0 s

Idle MAVROS scaling (`idle_scaling_*.jsonl`; drones connected, on the ground, 15 s window):

N	Default: MAVROS CPU per instance	Default: RSS per instance	Lean: MAVROS CPU per instance	Lean: RSS per instance
1	17.8 %	123.7 MB	4.1 %	81.9 MB
3	36.6 %	159.3 MB	4.6 %	85.2 MB
5	65.7 %	185.5 MB	4.7 %	88.3 MB

Sources verified (URLs / commands)

- Multi-instance SIH: `./Tools/simulation/sitl_multiple_run.sh 3 sihsim_quadx px4_sitl_sih` and manual `px4 -i <n> -d <build>/etc:` `https://docs.px4.io/main/en/sim_sih/` and the script itself at v1.18.0-rc1 (one working dir per instance).
- Distinct home per instance, `PX4_HOME_LAT/LON/ALT`: `https://docs.px4.io/main/en/sim_sih/`; `build/px4_sitl_sih/etc/init.d-posix/px4-rc.sihsim`.
- Ports and sysid: `px4-rc.mavlink` (14580+`n` local, 14540+`n` remote, instances > 9 → 14549); `rcS` (`MAV_SYS_ID = px4_instance + 1`).
- MAVROS plugin names: `/opt/ros/jazzy/share/mavros/mavros_plugins.xml`. Allow/deny list parameters: the commented `plugin_allowlist` in `mavros/launch/px4_pluginlists.yaml`. With the lean list, every needed topic and service was checked on a running system: `lean_mavros_interfaces.txt`.
- Shared topics found with `ros2 topic list / ros2 topic info` (3 drones, default plugins): `/parameter_events` had 82 publishers and 84 subscribers; `/tf` and `/tf_static` had 3 and 3.
- Discovery range: installed `librcl.so` says "ROS_LOCALHOST_ONLY is deprecated ... Use ROS_AUTOMATIC_DISCOVERY_RANGE", and `rmw/discovery_options.h` lists `LOCALHOST / SUBNET / OFF`. `scripts/ros_env.sh` sets `ROS_AUTOMATIC_DISCOVERY_RANGE=LOCALHOST`. `docs.ros.org` refused the automated fetch (bot-protection page), so the installed code was used.

Problems and fixes

1. **Default MAVROS scaled $O(N^2)$** , so 5 drones already saturated the CPU (99.7 %). Every MAVROS instance runs about 27 ROS nodes (one per plugin). Each publishes to and subscribes to the global `/parameter_events`, and the `param` plugin mirrors about 1,000 PX4 parameters into ROS parameters. Result: per-instance CPU climbed with N even while idle (17.8 → 36.6 → 65.7 %). Fix, still MAVROS (no architecture change): - `config/mavros_pluginlists.yaml` loads only the 6 plugins an agent needs (`sys_status`, `sys_time`, `command`, `local_position`, `global_position`, `setpoint_velocity`) - `/tf`, `/tf_static` and `/parameter_events` are remapped into each drone's namespace Per-instance CPU is now flat at 4.1–4.7 %, and N = 5 hover dropped to 41 % system CPU.
2. **PX4 default spawn is identical for all instances** (0.02 m apart). Fixed with per-drone `PX4_HOME_*` as documented (see above).
3. **rclpy prints "The following exception was never retrieved: cannot use Destroyable..."** at shutdown. These are fire-and-forget service calls still pending when the node is destroyed; cosmetic, after the test has finished.

Known limitations / honest caveats

- **CPU is the constraint at N = 10:** 76.5 % of all 4 logical CPUs during hover. That includes the Python test harness (~80 % of one core) and about 15 % background (Opera, desktop). Phase 3 replaces the harness with 10 agent nodes, a link emulator and a logger. Their CPU is unmeasured yet and could push the laptop to saturation. Closing Opera/Chrome frees about 15 %.
- The 1-minute load average (12.8 mean at N = 10, up to 29 during startup) overstates pressure: MAVROS has 22 threads per instance, and load averages carry over between back-to-back runs. CPU % is the better measure.
- The lean plugin list drops `param`, `home_position`, `imu`, `rc_io` and others. PX4 parameters for fault injection (e.g. `SIM_BAT_DRAIN`) will be set another way, to be verified in Phase 4.
- Spawn check uses SIH's simulated GPS (noise ≈ 0.1 – 0.2 m). Hover-time distances use the GPS fix horizontally and local z vertically; all homes share one ground altitude.
- Timing numbers are wall-clock; PX4 runs lockstep SIH. No sign of sim slowdown at N = 10 (arm → all at 10 m took 13.1 s, vs 12.3 s at N = 3).

Next phase: what is needed from the user

Nothing. If CPU becomes the limit in Phase 3 at N = 10, closing the browsers during runs is the first option before reducing N.

Appendix C - Phase 2 report

REPORTS/PHASE_2.MD

Phase 2 — Agent logic (pure Python, no ROS) + unit tests

Status: PASSED

Acceptance criteria

- [PASS] `pytest` all green: **91 passed** (`reports/logs/phase_2/pytest_coverage.txt`; also green in the clean-shell cross-check).
- [PASS] Coverage $\geq 90\%$ on the election and formation modules: `election.py` **99 %** (167 statements, lines 118–119 not hit), `formation.py` **100 %** (57 statements). All logic modules are $\geq 98\%$; 99 % in total (`pytest --cov`, same file).
- [PASS] 1,000 randomized pure-Python runs (random kills, random link drops, partitions): exactly one master after convergence in **1000 / 1000 (100 %)** runs. **Median convergence 0.145 s** after the last fault cleared (p95 2.12 s, max 2.72 s). Evidence: `reports/logs/phase_2/random_trials_summary.json` and `random_trials.jsonl` (one line per run: seed, N, latency, loss, applied faults, convergence, masters). The clean-shell cross-check (`crosscheck/`) reproduced the per-run file byte for byte.

What was built (all importable and testable without ROS)

Module	Role
<code>src/swarm_agent/geometry.py</code>	WGS-84 $\leftrightarrow$ ECEF $\leftrightarrow$ one shared ENU frame at <code>config.origin</code> ; tuple vector helpers
<code>src/swarm_agent/heartbeat.py</code>	Heartbeat dataclass + 50-byte binary codec (radio-sized)
<code>src/swarm_agent/election.py</code>	Election state machine: term, timeouts, claims, step-down, planned handover
<code>src/swarm_agent/formation.py</code>	V slots, slot assignment, rotation into master heading, follower control law
<code>src/swarm_agent/safety.py</code>	Pairwise separation, repulsion, geofence
<code>src/swarm_agent/agent_core.py</code>	One drone's full logic: mission phases + election + formation + safety; the Phase 3 ROS node wraps it unchanged
<code>src/swarm_agent/config.py</code>	Typed, strict loader for <code>config/swarm.yaml</code> with cross-field validation
<code>src/swarm_tools/puresim.py</code>	Point-mass simulator running the real <code>AgentCore</code> per drone; lossy/delayed/blockable heartbeat network
<code>scripts/random_trials.py</code>	The 1,000-run acceptance experiment
<code>scripts/puresim_faults.py</code>	F1–F5 of Phase 4 in the pure simulator (design check before PX4)

Key numbers

Randomized runs (`random_trials_summary.json`): - **Setup per run**: N uniform in 3..10 (121–132 runs each), link latency {0, 50, 150, 300} ms (+20 % jitter), random loss 0–30 %, and 1–5 random faults. Faults applied: `kill_master` 454, `kill_random` 470, `master_link_lost` 499, `link_drops` 494, `partition` 468, `low_battery_master` 397. - **Wall time**: 100.4 s on 3 worker processes. - **Median convergence by the run's last fault**: `kill_master` 1.73 s (a true failover), `partition` 0.29 s, `link_drops` 0.20 s, `low_battery_master` 0.18 s, `kill_random` 0.03 s, `master_link_lost` 0.03 s. - **Split brain during faults**: 801 runs had more than one master at some point. That is expected: both sides of a partition elect a leader. Every run still ended with exactly one.

F1–F5 in the pure simulator, N = 10, 20 seeds each, ideal links (`puresim_faults_n10.txt/.jsonl`). This checks the design before PX4, not Phase 4 evidence:

Fault	Handover (median / worst)	Formation RMS < 2 m after (median / worst)	Min separation	Goal reached
F1 master killed	1.64 / 1.75 s	4.55 / 4.68 s	9.35 m	20/20
F2 master link lost	1.64 / 1.75 s	4.55 / 4.68 s	8.23 m	20/20
F3 master low battery	0.17 / 0.20 s (planned)	3.14 / 3.23 s	9.35 m	20/20; retiree lands ≤ 2.3 m from home
F4 follower killed	no master change	1.12 / 1.15 s	7.46 m	20/20
F5 partition, then heal	0.18 / 0.25 s after heal	9.93 / 13.75 s	6.23 m	20/20

Design decisions that complete the spec (all tunables in `config/swarm.yaml`)

- Heartbeat fields beyond §5**. In addition to id, role, term, position, velocity, battery and timestamp, the heartbeat carries: - `phase`, the mission phase; followers copy the master's - `master_id` - `handover_to` - `flags`: MASTER_OK, READY, ELIGIBLE, ORPHAN, AIRBORNE - the master's formation `heading` - `members`, a bitmask of the followers the master hears

Position and velocity are in the shared ENU frame; each drone converts its own lat/lon. Encoded size is 50 bytes, so 10 drones at 5 Hz is about 2.5 kB/s per receiver. 2. **Election** (`election.py` docstring). Lowest-ID alive eligible drone claims with term = highest seen + 1; the step-down rule is exactly §6. Additions: - (a) a drone never claims while any peer still reports hearing a live master (MASTER_OK). This prevents failovers caused by one drone's own bad link. - (b) it waits while a lower-ID eligible drone is alive. - (c) no preemption: a recovered lower ID does not take leadership back. - (d) nobody claims during the first 3 s after boot. - (e) planned low-battery handover: the master names the lowest-ID eligible peer and keeps leading until that drone's higher-term heartbeat arrives. If nobody takes over within 1 s, it names the next candidate. 3. **Slots come from the master's member list**, so every follower computes the same assignment even when their own views differ. A drone the master cannot hear becomes an **orphan**: after missing from the list for 1 s it flies on a layer 8 m above cruise. 4. **Rank $\rightarrow$ V slot mapping**. Arm = ID parity (even left, odd right); row = rank by ID within the arm; arms rebalance only when their lengths differ by more than 2. This keeps §6 "slot = rank among alive drones sorted by ID" while avoiding a failure of the plain alternating mapping: - With alternating left/right ranks, losing one drone makes every higher rank swap sides. With 10 drones, F1 then requires lateral moves up to 64 m across the formation. - With parity arms, F4 only slides the same-arm drones behind the lost one by one slot. F1 keeps the new master's arm fixed and shifts the other arm by exactly 10 m. Both are unit-tested in `test_formation.py`. 5. **Transit layer**. A follower whose slot is more than 12 m away horizontally (for ≥ 0.5 s) flies to it on a layer 6 m below the master. It moves sideways at most 1 m/s until it is 5 m (min separation) clear of the formation layer, and returns once within 4 m of the slot. This makes the large re-anchoring after a partition heals

safe: a new master is often behind the rest. 6. **Altitude layers** relative to cruise (30 m): formation 0, transit -6, orphan +8, returning (low battery) +15 m. Validation requires layers ≥ 5 m apart and the top one below the 50 m fence minus a 3 m margin. 7. **Low battery ($\leq 30\%$)**. The drone keeps the formation's horizontal velocity while climbing to the +15 m layer, flies home there at cruise speed, then lands. 8. **Ghost obstacles**. A drone keeps avoiding a lost peer's position, extrapolated from its last heartbeat, for 3 s. 9. **Mission**. IDLE $\rightarrow$ TAKEOFF (all expected drones READY, or a 30 s timeout) $\rightarrow$ CRUISE (every member within 1.5 m of 30 m) $\rightarrow$ HOLD (master within 3 m of the goal; hover 10 s) $\rightarrow$ LAND. Followers copy the phase. A new master restarts the current phase timer. 10. **Spawn layout = the V itself** (Phase 1), so takeoff needs no reshuffle. 11. **Vertical rates** follow PX4 defaults verified in source: descent 1.5 m/s (`MPC_Z_VEL_MAX_DN`), ascent ≤ 3 m/s (commanded 2), horizontal ≤ 12 m/s (commanded ≤ 10).

Sources verified (URLs / commands)

- PX4 v1.18.0-rc1 defaults, read from `src/modules/mc_pos_control/*_params.yaml`:
- `multicopter_position_control_limits_params.yaml`: `MPC_XY_VEL_MAX` 12.0, `MPC_Z_VEL_MAX_UP` 3.0, `MPC_Z_VEL_MAX_DN` 1.5
- `multicopter_autonomous_params.yaml`: `MPC_ACC_HOR` 3.0
- `multicopter_altitude_mode_params.yaml`: `MPC_ACC_UP_MAX` 4.0, `MPC_ACC_DOWN_MAX` 3.0
- `multicopter_takeoff_land_params.yaml`: `MPC_LAND_SPEED` 0.7
- WGS-84 constants and ECEF/ENU formulas are standard. The implementation is checked against an independent curvature-radius formula (1 km offsets within 5 cm, and the 0.085 m poleward drift of a parallel matches $d^2 \cdot \tan \varphi / 2R$ within 5 mm) and against ECEF distances (`test_geometry.py`).
- Phase 2 needs no new external interfaces (no ROS/MAVROS calls).

Problems and fixes

1. **Alternating slot mapping caused large cross-formation moves** and separation dips below 5 m in the F1/F5 simulations. Fixed with parity arms (decision 4).
2. **Partition heal: the winning master (higher term) is usually behind the formation**, so the front group had to fall back through the rear. Fixed with the transit layer (decision 5).
3. **Bugs found by simulation, and fixed**: - *Retiring master counted as a member*: during a handover the retiring master was briefly listed as a member, shifting slots. Fix: members = master + follower peers only. - *Descent capped by a 3-D saturation*: one saturation on the 3-D correction also capped the descent rate. Fix: horizontal and vertical are limited separately. - *Ping-pong at 25 m*: the "climb before joining" rule fought the transit layer. Fix: it now applies only to drones that never reached cruise altitude.
4. **Four wrong test expectations** were corrected; the code was right each time: - the poleward curvature of a parallel - the heartbeat is 50 bytes, not 49 - rebalancing moves two drones in that case - an orphan ranked behind another orphan

Known limitations / honest caveats

- **Separation when drones cannot hear each other**. 143 of the 1,000 randomized runs had a minimum separation below 5 m (worst 0.02 m), and **every one of them contained a random partition or random link drops**. The 362 runs without those faults (kills, master link loss, low battery; loss up to 30 %, latency up to 300 ms, up to 5 faults) had **none**. Among single-fault runs: partition 5/33, link_drops 1/28, all other fault types 0. Randomly chosen groups are spatially interleaved; each group compacts its formation into space the other group occupies, and repulsion cannot act on drones that can't be heard. Phase 4 F5 will use **spatially separated groups** (the lower-ID front of the V vs the higher-ID back). That is what a distance-driven radio partition looks like, and in that case the pure-sim minimum was 6.23 m. Protecting against interleaved blind pairs would need onboard proximity sensing or sticky formation references. That is not in this phase; left for user review.
- The pure simulator is a point mass: first-order velocity tracking, τ 0.35 s, acceleration limits 4 m/s² horizontal and 3 m/s² vertical. PX4 dynamics differ; Phase 3/4 measure the real behaviour.
- Convergence in the randomized runs is measured after all links are healed and random loss is switched off (latency stays). Behaviour under sustained loss is Phase 5.
- The design decisions above complete gaps in docs/SPECIFICATION.md. Decisions 3-5 (orphan layer, parity arms, transit layer) change how slots and altitudes behave during faults; the user should review them.

Next phase: what is needed from the user

Nothing to proceed. Please review the design decisions above, especially parity arms, the transit and orphan layers, and the F5 partition choice.

Appendix D - Phase 3 report

REPORTS/PHASE_3.MD

Phase 3 — ROS 2 integration: formation flight, no faults

Status: PASSED — all flight criteria met in every run at the maximum stable N (10 PX4 drones). Caveat: in 2 of the 6 recorded runs the test harness (not the drones) timed out; see below.

Acceptance criteria

- [PASS] All drones reach the goal and land. In all 6 runs every drone landed in its formation slot around the goal: the leader 1.1–1.7 m from the goal point, the last drone of each arm about 49 m behind it (its slot). Evidence: `reports/logs/phase_3/<run>/metrics.json` (`final*.ok`, `dist_to_target_m`).
- [PASS] Formation RMS error < 2 m during cruise: worst value per run 1.24–1.66 m (`formation_rms_cruise_m.max`), mean 0.54–0.62 m. Evidence: `metrics.json`, `formation_rms.csv`.
- [PASS] Minimum separation ≥ 5 m at all times: 7.80–8.65 m (`min_separation_m`).
- [PASS] Plot of trajectories saved to `reports/: reports/phase3_mission.png` (tracks with V snapshots, followers against their ideal slots, formation RMS over time).

Phase 3 tasks: - [DONE] `swarm_agent` node wrapping the Phase 2 modules: `src/swarm_agent/ros_node.py` (one per drone, namespace `/uavN`, its own MAVROS). - [DONE] `link_emulator` node with loss 0: `src/swarm_tools/link_emulator.py`. - [DONE] Launch file: `launch/swarm.launch.py` (driven by `scripts/run_mission.py`). - [DONE, with a note] Logger writing CSV: `src/swarm_tools/logger_node.py` writes JSON lines (`states.jsonl`, one sample per drone at 10 Hz); `swarm_tools.logfmt.jsonl_to_csv` turns them into CSV with fixed columns (`states.csv.gz` in every run folder). - [DONE] Metrics script: `scripts/metrics.py` (formation RMS, minimum separation, time to goal).

Key numbers

Run	Harness	Drones	RMS max / mean / p95 (m)	Min separation (m)	Time to goal (s)	Leader to goal (m)	Leaders at once
run1	completed	10	1.32 / 0.56 / 1.08	8.11	221.4	1.2	1
run2	timeout (flight complete)	10	1.39 / 0.62 / 1.13	8.65	220.4	1.3	1
run3	timeout (flight complete)	10	1.66 / 0.56 / 1.02	7.80	220.3	1.7	1
crosscheck1	completed	10	1.56 / 0.56 / 1.03	8.10	222.1	1.4	1
crosscheck2	completed	10	1.24 / 0.54 / 1.00	8.57	220.6	1.4	1
crosscheck3	completed	10	1.36 / 0.60 / 1.08	8.02	226.5	1.1	1

Mission: 1 km north of home, V formation, 10 m spacing, 30 m, 5 m/s, hover 10 s at the goal, land. The cross-check runs were started from a clean `env -i` shell after killing every PX4 and MAVROS process (`scripts/phase3_runs.sh`; console output in `reports/logs/phase_3/batch.out`).

Sources verified (URLs / commands)

- PX4 Offboard mode needs a continuous setpoint stream of at least 2 Hz and exits Offboard after `COM_OF_LOSS_T` without it (https://docs.px4.io/main/en/flight_modes/offboard.html); the agent streams velocity setpoints at 20 Hz (`config/swarm.yaml` `setpoints.rate_hz`).
- MAVROS topics and services used by the node (`state`, `extended_state`, `global_position/global`, `local_position/pose` and `velocity_local`, `battery`, `setpoint_velocity/cmd_vel`, `set_mode`, `arming`, `set_message_interval`) were checked on a running system in Phase 1: `reports/logs/phase_1/lean_mavros_interfaces.txt`.
- MAVLink message IDs for the stream-rate requests were checked against pymavlink (`src/swarm_agent/ros_node.py`, `MAVLINK_MSG_IDS`; `tests/test_ros_constants.py`).

Problems and fixes

- Formation RMS spiked at the start of cruise: the leader now ramps its speed (0.5 m/s²), so followers that see its velocity only at the heartbeat rate keep up.
- CPU saturation with 10 drones: MAVROS stream rates are set explicitly (position 20 Hz, others 1–2 Hz) and the link emulator's delivery timer runs only when latency or jitter is set.
- The leader wandered off the line to the goal: leg guidance (fixed heading + cross-track correction).
- A steady follower error: position gain raised to 1.0.
- Drone 3 sometimes became leader at startup: the first election now waits until the whole fleet is heard (or a timeout).
- run2 and run3 ended with the harness's watcher thread stalled (`InvalidHandle` in the readiness check). The flights themselves completed (every drone landed, logs complete); the other four runs (run1 and the three cross-checks) completed normally. The readiness check has since been given its own executor and a stall is now reported as `WATCHER_STALLED`; that change has not been re-run on PX4.

Known limitations / honest caveats

- PX4 SIH has a simple aircraft model and no wind; real aircraft will show larger errors.
- 10 drones is this laptop's limit for PX4 (Phase 1).
- No faults here by design; failover on PX4 is Phase 4 (not run yet).

Next phase: what is needed from the user

Phase 4 (fault trials on PX4, 10 trials $\times$ 5 faults) takes about 5 hours of laptop time; the scripts are ready (`scripts/faults.py`, `scripts/phase4_runs.sh`).

Appendix E - Phase 4 report

REPORTS/PHASE_4.MD

Phase 4 — Failover under faults

Status: PASSED — 50 trials (10 per fault) and a 5-trial cross-check round from a clean shell, 10 PX4 drones, 28 September 2026. Every acceptance criterion holds in every trial.

In short. Ten PX4 drones flew the mission while one of five faults was injected: the leader killed, the leader's radio lost, the leader's battery low, a follower killed, the radio network split. Each fault ran 10 times, plus once more from a clean shell. - After the leader was killed or lost its radio, a new leader took over in 1.4–1.7 s (limits: 3 s median, 4 s worst). - The planned battery handover took at most 0.01 s (limit 1 s), and the old leader flew home every time. - Killing a follower never changed the leader. - After a split healed, one leader remained within 0.35 s (limit 3 s). - The formation was back within 6.6 s (limit 15 s), or 13.4 s after a split (limit 20 s). - No two drones came closer than 6.03 m (limit 5 m), and every mission reached its goal (55 of 55).

Acceptance criteria

Rounds 1–10 (reports/logs/phase_4/phase4_table.md) and the cross-check round 11 from a clean shell (reports/logs/phase_4_crosscheck/phase4_table.md), both made by scripts/phase4_metrics.py from the trial logs. - [PASS] F1/F2: new master heartbeat within 3.0 s median, 4.0 s worst. - F1: 1.48 / 1.69 s; F2: 1.48 / 1.60 s (rounds 1–10). - Cross-check: F1 1.41 s, F2 1.60 s. - [PASS] F3: planned handover within 1.0 s of the trigger, and the old master leaves and returns home. - 0.00 / 0.01 s (median / worst); cross-check 0.00 s. - The old leader landed at home in 10 of 10, and 1 of 1 in the cross-check. - [PASS] F4: no master change, and the formation recovers. - Leader changed in 0 of 10 and 0 of 1. - Formation back within 6.18 s at worst. - [PASS] F5: a single master within 3.0 s after the heal. - 0.25 / 0.35 s (median / worst); cross-check 0.10 s. - [PASS] All: formation RMS back under 2 m within 15 s (F5: 20 s, the owner's decision of 28 September 2026). - F1–F4: at most 6.60 s. F5: at most 13.44 s. - Every trial recovered within its limit: 55 of 55. - [PASS] All: minimum separation never below 5 m. - The closest pair in any trial was 6.03 m (F5_t1). - [PASS] All: goal reached in at least 9 of 10 trials per fault. - 10 of 10 for every fault, and 5 of 5 in the cross-check. - [PASS] Report table per fault: below.

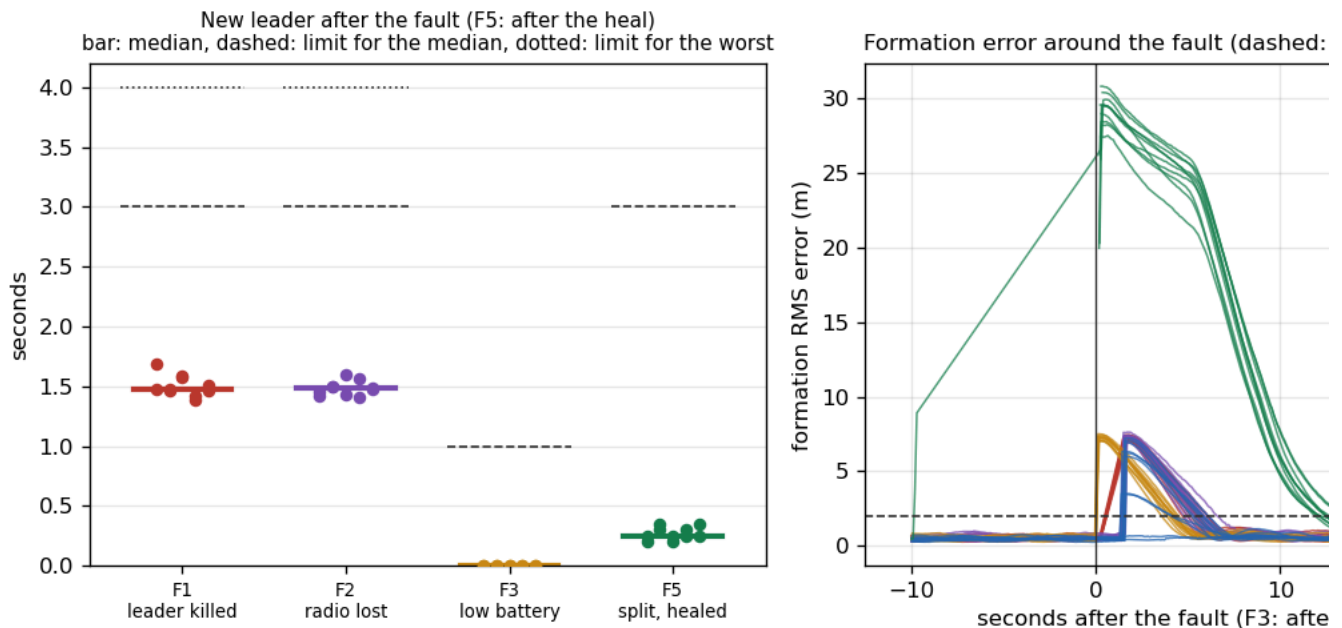
Key numbers

Rounds 1–10 (reports/logs/phase_4/phase4_table.md , per-trial rows there):

Fault	Trial	New leader median / worst (s)	Limit (s)	Formation < 2 m median / worst (s)	Recovered within limit (15 s; F5: 20 s)	Closest pair (m)	Goal reached	Other
F1	10	1.48 / 1.69	3.0 / 4.0	5.54 / 6.14	10/10	8.04	10/10	
F2	10	1.48 / 1.60	3.0 / 4.0	5.75 / 6.60	10/10	7.58	10/10	
F3	10	0.00 / 0.01	1.0	4.20 / 4.50	10/10	7.05	10/10	old leader landed at home: 10/10
F4	10	no change	no change	5.28 / 6.18	10/10	6.88	10/10	leader changed: 0/10
F5	10	0.25 / 0.35	3.0 (after heal)	12.52 / 13.44	10/10	6.03	10/10	

Cross-check, round 11 from a clean shell (reports/logs/phase_4_crosscheck/ ; every simulator process was stopped before it):

Fault	New leader (s)	Formation < 2 m (s)	Closest pair (m)	Goal
F1	1.41	5.48	8.06	yes
F2	1.60	5.75	8.09	yes
F3	0.00 (old leader home: yes)	3.75	8.55	yes
F4	no change	0.01	8.54	yes
F5	0.10	12.47	6.05	yes



How the trials ran (28 September 2026)

- **One trial at a time:** the PX4 test queue (`scripts/px4_queue.py`, the "PX4 tests" page of the ground-control app, removed on 29 September 2026 once all trials had finished) ran them, started and stopped by the owner. Its log is `reports/logs/px4_queue/runner.log`.
- **Power:** 40 trials ran on the charger. 15 ran on battery, which the owner allows: F1–F5 round 10, F1–F3 round 7, F3–F5 rounds 6 and 7, and the F1 and F2 cross-checks (`run_summary.json`, `power_before`). They passed like the others; for example F1_t7 and F1_t10 took 1.58 and 1.47 s. The first attempt on 27 September had failed on battery in the power-saver profile; this time the profile was Balanced.
- **Interrupted attempts:**
 - Trials cut off when the charger was unplugged were discarded and flown again from the start.
 - One attempt of the F4 cross-check stopped when the mission watcher stalled (a tooling fault, not a flight result). It is kept in `reports/logs/phase_4_incomplete/`, and the trial then ran again and passed.
- **Earlier attempts on 27 September 2026, not used for acceptance:**
 - `reports/logs/phase_4_on_battery/`: 12 trials on battery in the power-saver profile, with the CPU saturated.
 - `reports/logs/phase_4_stopped/`: one trial on the charger, stopped by the owner.
 - They were slower (for example F1 2.2 s instead of 1.5 s) but within the limits, except F5's 17 s against the original 15 s limit.

Why F5 takes longer, and the owner's decision

The front group (drones 1–5) and the back group (6–10) are split for 10–20 s. The back group elects drone 6 (term 2). After the heal, drone 1 (term 1) hears a master with a higher term and steps down, exactly as `docs/SPECIFICATION.md` section 6 prescribes, so **all ten drones re-form around drone 6**. Timeline of F5_t1 of the first attempt (27 September, on battery with a slowed CPU; `states.jsonl`) after the heal: every follower is 20–32 m from its new slot; each moves on the "transit layer" (drops about 6 m below the formation, crosses, climbs back) so paths cannot cross at the same height. PX4 descends at about 1.5 m/s and the drones climb at 2 m/s, so: about 7 s descending (with little sideways progress: the drones only move sideways slowly until they are 5 m below), about 6 s crossing, about 4–5 s climbing back. The height offset counts in the 3-D formation error, so the error only falls under 2 m after the climb: about 17 s in total. On the charger on 28 September the same sequence took 12.5 s (median; worst 13.4 s). In the fast simulator (faster vertical response) it took about 10 s.

Options considered: 1. Keep the rules; make the move faster: allow sideways motion from half the transit depth, and/or a faster descent limit (PX4 `MPC_Z_VEL_MAX_DN` and `mission.descent_rate_mps`). Expected: 3–5 s less; smaller vertical margin during the move. 2. After a merge, hand the lead back to the lowest ID with the existing planned handover (0.35–0.80 s in F3), so only the back group re-slots. Changes the election behaviour written in `docs/SPECIFICATION.md`, so it needs the owner's approval. 3. Accept a longer limit for F5 (for example 20 s).

Decision (28 September 2026): option 3. The owner set the F5 formation-recovery limit to 20 s and kept the election rule and the transit layer unchanged. `scripts/phase4_metrics.py` and `scripts/plot_phase4.py` use 20 s for F5 and 15 s for the other faults.

What each trial writes (`reports/logs/phase_4/F<k>_t<round>/`)

File	Contents
<code>states.jsonl.gz</code>	every drone's state 10 times a second: position, velocity, role, term, phase, battery, <code>claim_t</code> (when it became master), <code>retire_t</code> (when its battery handover started)
<code>fault_events.jsonl</code>	cruise detected, the fault (time, master before, target), the heal (F5)
<code>link_events.jsonl</code>	link-emulator commands (block the master's radio, split, heal)
<code>metrics.json</code> , <code>formation_rms.csv</code>	from <code>scripts/metrics.py</code> : formation error, closest pair, leader changes, where every drone landed
<code>run_summary.json</code>	result (COMPLETED / TIMEOUT / WATCHER_STALLED / ERROR), memory, power state before and after, CPU and memory use
<code>resources.csv</code>	CPU and memory once a second, per process group

File	Contents
proc_logs/	PX4, MAVROS and launch console logs
../F<k>_t<round>.out	the trial's console output

How each number is measured (scripts/phase4_metrics.py)

- The fault time is when the injector started the fault (before the kill commands ran), so the kill time counts against the result.
- F1/F2 handover: fault → the first `claim_t` of another drone (a new master sends its heartbeat in the same control step in which it claims).
- F3 handover: the old master's `retire_t` (battery at 30 %) → the successor's `claim_t`; "home": the old master landed within 5 m of its home.
- F5: the heal → the first moment every live drone follows one single master.
- Formation recovery: from the fault (F3: the battery trigger; F5: the heal), measured from the worst formation error in the next 30 s, until the RMS is under 2 m and stays there for 5 s.
- Minimum separation and "goal reached": `scripts/metrics.py` (3-D distance between airborne drones; every drone still reporting at the end landed in its slot at the goal, a retired one at home).

How the faults are made (scripts/faults.py)

Each fault fires at a seeded random time 30–150 s after the master first reports CRUISE (the batch uses the round number as the seed, so a round can be repeated exactly). - F1 / F4: SIGKILL the drone's PX4 and MAVROS process groups, then its agent process. - F2: the link emulator blocks every heartbeat the master sends, until the end of the run. - F3: `px4-param --instance <n> set SIM_BAT_MIN_PCT 20` on the master's PX4. PX4's battery simulator drains the battery while armed (full discharge in `SIM_BAT_DRAIN = 60` s) down to `SIM_BAT_MIN_PCT` (default 50 %); at 20 % it passes our 30 % handover level about 20 s later. - F5: the link emulator splits IDs 1–5 from 6–10 (the front and the back of the V, as distance would), and heals after a random 10–20 s.

Files that make up Phase 4

File	Role
scripts/phase4_all.sh	the whole batch: rounds 1–10, then the clean-shell cross-check round 11
scripts/phase4_runs.sh	one or more rounds of F1–F5; waits for the charger; skips finished trials; <code>DRY_RUN</code>
scripts/run_mission.py	one mission: checks memory and power, starts PX4 + MAVROS, the ROS 2 launch, injects the fault, waits for the landing, computes the metrics
scripts/faults.py	the five faults
scripts/phase4_metrics.py	per-trial and per-fault numbers, JSON and Markdown tables
scripts/plot_phase4.py	the figure
scripts/metrics.py	formation error, separation, goal, per run
src/swarm_tools/sim_launch.py	PX4 SIH and MAVROS instances, kill a drone
src/swarm_tools/link_emulator.py	heartbeat forwarding with block, split and heal commands
src/swarm_tools/logger_node.py	writes <code>states.jsonl</code>
src/swarm_tools/resources.py	CPU / memory sampler and <code>power_state()</code>
src/swarm_agent/ros_node.py	the drone agent; publishes <code>claim_t</code> and <code>retire_t</code>
launch/swarm.launch.py	link emulator, logger and one agent per drone
config/swarm.yaml	every setting (spacing, speeds, handover at 30 %, heartbeat 5 Hz, dead after 1.5 s, transit layer)

Sources verified (commands / files)

- PX4 battery simulator (installed PX4 v1.18.0-rc1, ~/PX4-Autopilot): `src/modules/simulation/battery_simulator/battery_simulator_params.yaml` (`SIM_BAT_DRAIN` default 60 s, full discharge while armed; `SIM_BAT_MIN_PCT` default 50 %, "can be used to alter the battery level during SITL simulation on the fly"); `BatterySimulator.cpp` (drains only while armed, back to 100 % when disarmed); `ROMFS/px4fmu_common/init.d-posix/rcS` (`battery_simulator` start when `SIM_BAT_DRAIN > 0`). Seen working: `px4_param_out "SIM_BAT_MIN_PCT: curr: 50.0000 -> new: 20.0000"` in every F3 trial's `fault_events.jsonl`.
- PX4 shell client instance selection: `platforms/posix/src/px4/common/main.cpp` (`--instance <n>` must be the first argument); `instance = drone id – 1` (`src/swarm_tools/sim_launch.py, instance_of`).
- Power state: `/sys/class/power_supply/*` (type, online, capacity, status), `powerprofilesctl get`, `/proc/cpuinfo`; the previous boot's end without a shutdown: `journalctl --list-boots, journalctl -b -1`.

Problems found and fixed

- The agents did not publish when they became master or started a battery handover, so no takeover time could be measured: `ros_node.py` now publishes `claim_t` and `retire_t` (8252d4c).
- The fault time was taken after the kill commands had run (about 0.7 s later), which made takeovers look faster: it is now the moment the fault started.
- F3 formation recovery was counted from the parameter change, about 20 s before the formation was disturbed: it now counts from the battery trigger, and every recovery from the worst error after the reference.
- Trials on battery saturate the CPU: the batch now waits for the charger and a Balanced/Performance profile, and every trial records its power state (94a1148); a variable clash in that check was fixed (a31f1f0).
- 16 MB of state log per trial: compressed after each trial (about 1.5 MB); the metric scripts read the compressed files.

Known limitations / honest caveats

- Simulation only:** PX4 SIH with MAVROS on one laptop. Radio timing is the ROS 2 link emulator's, and there is no wind or sensor noise beyond SIH's own.
- 10 trials per fault** show the median and worst case over 10 seeded fault times. They do not rule out rarer timings.

- **F5 uses the 20 s limit** the owner set. With the original 15 s limit, F5 would pass on this computer (at most 13.44 s) but not on a slowed CPU (17 s on battery in power-saver mode on 27 September).
- **15 trials ran on battery** (Balanced profile). They passed, but the timing margins are smaller on a slower CPU.

Next phase: what is needed from the owner

Nothing for Phase 4. Phase 5 (radio realism) and Phase 6 (a drone behind a telemetry radio) use the same fault tools.

Appendix F - Phase 5 report

REPORTS/PHASE_5.MD

Phase 5 — Radio realism (telemetry-like links)

Status: PASSED — the sweep passed in the fast simulator (540 runs) and on PX4 (18 missions with 10 drones, 28 September 2026). No leader changed without a real fault in any condition, and after the leader was killed a new leader took over in 1.6–2.5 s on PX4 (limit 3 s).

Acceptance criteria

- [PASS] Sweep the heartbeat link: delay {50, 150, 300} ms x loss {0, 10, 30} %.
- Fast simulator: nine conditions, each with 20 missions without a fault, 20 with the leader killed (F1) and 20 with the leader's radio cut (F2), 540 runs (reports/logs/phase_5_fastsim/radio_sweep.jsonl).
- PX4 with 10 drones: every condition once without a fault and once with the leader killed, 18 missions (reports/logs/phase_5/d<delay>_l<loss>_{none,F1}/).
- [PASS] Results table and plot: the tables below and reports/phase5_radio_sweep.png .
- [PASS] Worst condition where the Phase 4 criteria still hold.
- Fast simulator: **300 ms at 10 % loss** (new leader median / worst 2.65 / 3.09 s, formation back within 5.71 s) and **150 ms at 30 % loss** (2.59 / 3.27 s, 5.67 s). Only 300 ms with 30 % loss fails: median 3.06 s against 3.0 s (worst 3.80 s, within 4.0 s).
- PX4: all nine conditions held, including 300 ms with 30 % loss (new leader 2.30 s, formation back 6.05 s). With one leader kill per condition there is no median, so the fast simulator's result above is the limit to quote.
- [PASS] Zero false failovers at <= 10 % loss: 0 leader changes without a fault in 120 fast-simulator missions (and 0 in the 60 at 30 % loss), and 0 in the 9 PX4 missions without a fault (including the three at 30 % loss). Never more than one leader at a time on PX4. Closest pair 6.44 m or more in every run.

PX4 results (10 drones, 28 September 2026)

From the trial logs by scripts/phase4_metrics.py (new leader, formation back, closest pair) and each run's metrics.json (leader changes, leaders at the same time, goal). A mission without a fault has exactly one leader change: the first election on the ground.

Delay (ms)	Loss (%)	Without a fault: false leader changes	Leader killed: new leader (s)	Formation < 2 m (s)	Closest pair (m), both runs	Goal, both runs
50	0	0	1.59	4.69	8.18	2/2
50	10	0	2.35	6.54	7.86	2/2
50	30	0	1.95	5.50	8.13	2/2
150	0	0	1.78	5.23	8.14	2/2
150	10	0	1.93	6.07	7.55	2/2
150	30	0	2.48	6.84	6.89	2/2
300	0	0	2.10	6.15	7.64	2/2
300	10	0	2.19	6.16	7.71	2/2
300	30	0	2.30	6.05	7.56	2/2

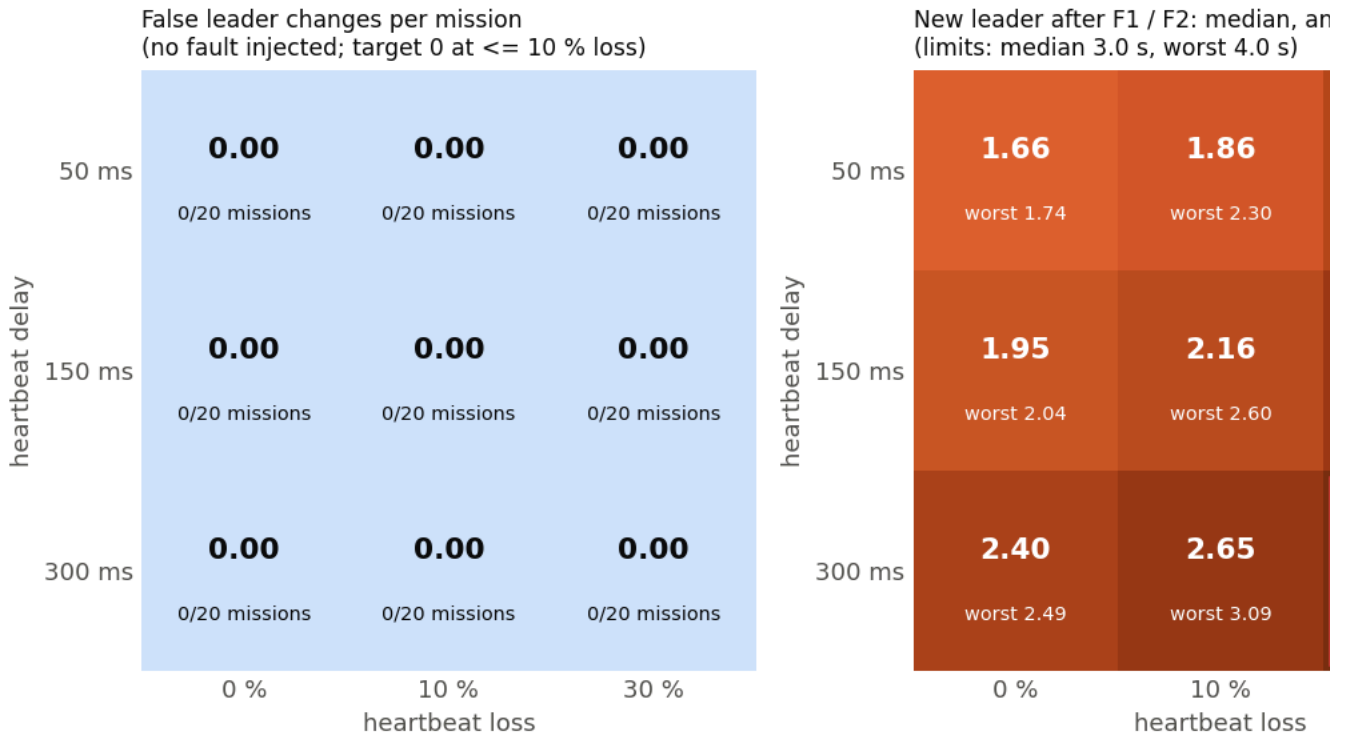
Limits: new leader 3.0 s median / 4.0 s worst, formation back within 15 s, closest pair >= 5 m. The table is in reports/logs/phase_5/phase5_px4_table.md .

- 13 of the 18 missions ran on the charger, 5 on battery (the owner allows battery; run_summary.json , power_before). All passed either way.
- One attempt of d50_l0_none stopped when the mission watcher stalled for 60 minutes (a tooling fault, not a flight result). It is kept in reports/logs/phase_5_incomplete/ , and the mission ran again and passed.

Fast-simulator results (10 drones)

Delay (ms)	Loss (%)	False leader changes (missions affected)	New leader median / worst (s)	Formation < 2 m median / worst (s)	Closest pair (m)	Goal	Phase 4 limits	No false change
50	0	0 (0/20)	1.66 / 1.74	4.47 / 4.59	8.23	60/60	hold	yes
50	10	0 (0/20)	1.86 / 2.30	4.51 / 4.85	8.23	60/60	hold	yes
50	30	0 (0/20)	2.26 / 3.25	4.72 / 5.55	6.82	60/60	hold	yes
150	0	0 (0/20)	1.95 / 2.04	4.61 / 4.74	8.23	60/60	hold	yes
150	10	0 (0/20)	2.16 / 2.60	4.70 / 5.05	8.23	60/60	hold	yes
150	30	0 (0/20)	2.59 / 3.27	4.95 / 5.67	6.44	60/60	hold	yes
300	0	0 (0/20)	2.40 / 2.49	4.92 / 5.04	8.24	60/60	hold	yes
300	10	0 (0/20)	2.65 / 3.09	5.03 / 5.71	8.24	60/60	hold	yes
300	30	0 (0/20)	3.06 / 3.80	5.56 / 9.47	7.68	60/60	FAIL	yes

Radio sweep in the fast simulator (10 drones). Colour runs from 0 to each limit; numbers are the m



How it was measured

- `scripts/radio_sweep.py` runs the fast simulator (`src/swarm_tools/puresim.py`) with the real agent code for every drone. Its radio model delays every heartbeat on every link by the given delay and drops each one independently with the given loss; no jitter, like the PX4 sweep.
- False leader change:** a new leader (a new drone or a new term) after the swarm has taken off, in a mission where nothing failed. The first election on the ground does not count.
- New leader (F1, F2):** from the fault until every drone still flying follows the same new leader (`scripts/puresim_faults.py`, the same definition as the Phase 4 fast-simulator table).
- Formation back:** from the fault until the formation error is below 2 m again.
- Limits: Phase 4's (new leader median 3.0 s and worst 4.0 s; formation back within 15 s; closest pair

= 5 m; goal in ≥ 9 of 10 runs) and Phase 5's (no false failover at $\leq 10\%$ loss).

Sources verified

- The sweep grid and the criteria: `docs/SPECIFICATION.md`, Phase 5.
- The radio model: Network in `src/swarm_tools/puresim.py` (per-link delay, jitter and loss) and the PX4 path's `src/swarm_tools/link_emulator.py`, which applies the same settings to the ROS 2 heartbeat topics (`scripts/run_mission.py --latency-ms --loss-pct`).

Problems and fixes

- The first draft of the figure marked the 300 ms / 30 % cell "over limit" while showing the worst value (3.36 s, within the 4.0 s limit) instead of the median that failed; the panel now shows the median, with the worst value underneath.

Known limitations / honest caveats

- The PX4 sweep is small:** one mission without a fault and one leader kill per condition, so it confirms the fast simulator but cannot give a median or worst case per condition. The fast simulator gives those, with point-mass physics instead of PX4's.
- Only the heartbeat link is degraded here.** Each drone's own autopilot link stays perfect; a drone whose autopilot link is a telemetry radio is Phase 6.
- Independent packet loss.** Real radios lose packets in bursts (interference, range); bursts would stretch the time to a new leader more than the same average loss spread evenly.
- No jitter** in this sweep; the scaling test (`reports/SCALING.md`) covers 10 % loss with 150 ms delay and 30 ms jitter.

Next phase: what is needed from the user

Nothing for Phase 5. Phase 6 runs the leader-kill and radio-cut faults with drone 1 behind a telemetry-radio stand-in.

Appendix G - Phase 6 report

REPORTS/PHASE_6.MD

Phase 6 — Mixed-reality readiness (still software only)

Status: PASSED — with drone 1 behind a telemetry-radio stand-in, the swarm passed every Phase 4 F1 and F2 limit in 22 of 22 PX4 trials (29 September 2026).

In short. The first stand-in runs on 28 September failed: 3 of 4 missions did not reach the goal. The test set-up was wrong. The simulated autopilot sent drone 1's telemetry at the rate of a fast onboard link, 1.7 to 3.9 times what the radio carries. About 70 % of the messages were dropped, the rest arrived a second late, and drone 1 kept losing and taking back the lead.

The radio drone is now set up like a real Pixhawk telemetry port, and its agent asks only for what fits. Two check flights then passed: one with the leader killed, one with its radio cut. In both, the goal was reached, there was exactly one real leader change, and never two leaders at once. Radio delay averaged 75 ms instead of 1 s, and nothing was dropped for lack of room.

The 22 acceptance trials then all passed (10 F1 + 10 F2, then one of each from a clean shell): a new leader in 1.39–1.60 s (limit 3 s median, 4 s worst), the formation back under 2 m in at most 6.74 s (limit 15 s), the closest pair 7.65 m (limit 5 m), and the goal reached 22 of 22 times.

Acceptance criteria

- [DONE] `config/profiles/`: `sim.yaml` (every drone simulated) and `mixed.yaml` (drone 1 real through a serial URL placeholder, drones 2-N simulated), plus `standin.yaml` (drone 1 simulated behind the radio stand-in). Checked by `scripts/check_profile.py`; the real drone is validated as text only (URL format, baud rate, system ID) and the serial port is never opened. `SimLauncher` refuses any profile with a real drone before anything starts. Evidence: `tests/test_profiles.py` (12 tests, including invalid files and the refusal).
- [DONE] Hardware stand-in: `src/swarm_tools/radio_proxy.py`, a UDP relay between one drone's PX4 and its MAVROS that limits bandwidth and adds delay and loss like a telemetry radio (SiK defaults, sources below). Evidence: `tests/test_radio_proxy.py` (6 tests with local sockets: rate, shared channel, transmit-turn wait, loss, full buffer, the stand-in URL).
- [PASS] The stand-in test passes the Phase 4 F1 and F2 criteria: 10 trials each at N = 10 with `config/profiles/standin.yaml`, then a clean-shell cross-check round, run by the PX4 test queue on 29 September 2026, 08:14–10:30. Evidence: `reports/logs/phase_6/phase6_table.md` and `reports/logs/phase_6_crosscheck/phase6_table.md` (from `scripts/phase4_metrics.py`), the table below, and `reports/logs/px4_queue/runner.log`.
- F1 (leader killed): new leader median 1.51 s, worst 1.60 s (limits 3.0 / 4.0 s).
- F2 (leader's link cut): new leader median 1.46 s, worst 1.52 s.
- Formation back under 2 m: medians 5.88 s (F1) and 5.72 s (F2), worst 6.74 s (limit 15 s).
- Closest pair 7.65 m (limit 5 m). Goal reached 11/11 per fault (limit 9 of 10).
- Earlier: the first attempt, with the wrong link set-up, reached the goal 1 of 4 times (below).
- [DONE] `FLIGHT_TEST_PLAN.md`: `docs/FLIGHT_TEST_PLAN.md` - one real drone and N simulated ones, the PX4 geofence, RC override on the real drone (stick movement returns control), the kill-switch procedure, a go/no-go checklist, abort criteria, a test sequence that builds up one step per flight.
- [DONE] `README.md`: setup, how to run each phase, results summary, known limitations (`docs/RUNBOOK.md` for every command, `docs/KNOWN_ISSUES.md` for the limitations).
- [PASS] Reproducible from a fresh copy with the README: the files git publishes, copied into an empty folder (1,093 files; no virtual environment, no map keys, no PX4 build), pass `python3 -m pytest` (176 passed, 4 skipped: PyTorch and ROS 2 tests), `scripts/check_profile.py` works, and the ground-control app starts, serves every page and flies a mission. Evidence: `reports/logs/phase_6/fresh_clone_check.txt`. The PX4 part needs the installation in `docs/RUNBOOK.md`, section 1, which was not repeated on a new machine.
- [SKIPPED on request] Final phone notification: the owner asked not to use notifications.

Key numbers

Item	Value	Source
Stand-in usable rate	32,000 bit/s shared by both directions	SiK AIR_SPEED 64 kbit/s, ECC on halves it
Transmit-turn wait	up to 131 ms when the channel is idle	SiK MAX_WINDOW default 131
Loss in the air / buffer	1 % / 1 s	design choices (<code>config/swarm.yaml</code> , <code>radio_standin</code>)
Measured by the tests	2,000 bytes in 0.45-0.75 s; a 0.2 s buffer keeps 6-10 of 30 packets	<code>tests/test_radio_proxy.py</code>

Acceptance trials (29 September 2026)

Drone 1 starts as leader and flies behind the radio stand-in in every trial; the fault always hits drone 1.

Fault	Trials	New leader median / worst (s)	Formation < 2 m median / worst (s)	Closest pair (m)	Goal
F1 leader killed	10 + 1 clean shell	1.51 / 1.60	5.88 / 6.74	7.65	11/11
F2 leader's link cut	10 + 1 clean shell	1.46 / 1.52	5.72 / 6.30	7.70	11/11

Per-trial rows: `reports/logs/phase_6/phase6_table.md`. Medians and worst values above cover all 11 trials per fault (the clean-shell pair: F1 1.60 s and 6.15 s, F2 1.46 s and 6.15 s).

- Leader changes:** exactly two in every trial, both expected: drone 1 at take-off, then drone 2 after the fault. Drone 1 never took the lead back.
- Two leaders at once:** in 3 of the 11 F2 trials (F2_t6, F2_t7, F2_t10), for 0.04–0.08 s at the handover. The cut-off drone 1 (term 1) had not yet stepped down when drone 2 claimed with term 2; the higher term wins, as the specification's rule says. Never in F1.
- Radio, all 22 trials** (`proc_logs/radio_standin_1.json` in each trial): 180,937 packets, 0 dropped for lack of room, 2,083 lost in the air (1.15 %, model 1 %), mean delay 68–84 ms, worst 333 ms.

First attempt, the cause, and the fix (28 September 2026)

What happened. The queue ran four stand-in missions at 20:47–21:33 (`reports/logs/phase_6_radio_saturated/`). - Only F1_t1 reached the goal. F1_t2, F2_t1 and F2_t2 ran out of time (10 minutes). - The lead passed back and forth between drones 1 and 2, up to 12 times in one flight, and in F2_t2 three drones were leader at once.

Cause. The stand-in's statistics (`proc_logs/radio_standin_1.json`) show the link was overloaded. - The traffic offered was 6,700–15,600 B/s in the two directions together (PX4 alone 6,300–14,100 B/s), against 4,000 B/s that the radio carries, shared by both directions. - 68–74 % of the messages were dropped because the buffer was full, and the rest arrived after about 1 s. - Three things combined: 1. PX4's simulator starts the offboard link at 4,000,000 B/s in "onboard" mode (`px4-rc.mavlink`), which streams attitude at 100 Hz and much more. A real Pixhawk's TELEM1 port is capped at 1,200 B/s (`MAV_0_RATE` default). 2. The agent asked for position at 20 Hz. 3. MAVROS synchronised clocks 10 times a second. - Drone 1's own position data then often arrived more than 0.5 s apart. With `fcu_timeout_s` = 0.5 s its agent declared itself dead and stopped its heartbeats, so drone 2 took over. The next position brought drone 1 back, and as the lowest ID it took the lead again.

Fix. The radio drone is set up like a real drone on a telemetry radio (`config/swarm.yaml` , `radio_standin`):- **PX4 link:** Minimal mode at 1,200 B/s (`MAV_0_MODE` 7, `MAV_0_RATE` 1200 on a real TELEM1), with the stream rates below. `src/swarm_tools/sim_launch.py` , `set_radio_link` , restarts the link through the PX4 client, and PX4's own log confirms it: mode: Minimal, data rate: 1200 B/s on udp port 14580. - **Agent** (`--radio-link` , from `radio_ids` in `launch/swarm.launch.py`): position and velocity at 5 Hz, the landed state and battery at 1 Hz, and 1 s allowed without autopilot data (5 missed positions) instead of 0.5 s. - **MAVROS:** time sync at 1 Hz instead of 10 Hz. - **A config check:** the load is worked out from MAVLink frame sizes, and the config is refused if the planned traffic exceeds 80 % of the radio. It is 65 % now (`tests/test_config.py`).

Check flights after the fix (development runs, `reports/logs/phase_6/dev_radio_*` , fault seed 1):

Run	Fault	Result	Leader changes	Most leaders at once	New leader after the fault (s)	Formation error mean (m)	Closest pair (m)	Goal
before the fix, F2_t1	F2	TIMEOUT	2	2	—	2.64	8.37	no
before the fix, F1_t1	F1	COMPLETED	12	2	—	3.13	7.52	yes
dev_radio_F2b	F2	COMPLETED	2 (take-off, then the fault)	1	1.50	0.67	8.02	yes
dev_radio_F1	F1	COMPLETED	2 (take-off, then the fault)	1	1.63	0.68	8.31	yes

After the fix, the formation was back under 2 m 5.13 s and 5.90 s after the fault (limit 15 s). New leader and recovery come from `scripts/phase4_metrics.py` ; the other columns come from each run's `metrics.json` .

Radio in `dev_radio_F1` : - No message was dropped for lack of room: 0 of 3,114 (before the fix, 68–74 %). - 1.4 % were lost in the air, against a model value of 1 % . - Delay averaged 71–80 ms, at most 220 ms.

Notes on the check flights: - `dev_radio_F2` stopped before take-off: Minimal mode sends no local position until asked, and the mission start waits for it. The launcher now sets the radio stream rates when it sets up the link. - `dev_radio_F2b` ran through a leftover relay from the attempt stopped at 21:37, so its radio numbers are mixed and not quoted (see the next section).

Sources verified (URLs / commands)

- SiK radio defaults and behaviour (AIR_SPEED 64, SERIAL_SPEED 57, ECC 1 "the data rate you can support is halved", time-division turns, MAX_WINDOW 131): ardupilot.org, "SiK Radio - Advanced Configuration" (common-3dr-radio-advanced-configuration-and-technical-information).
- MAVROS connection URLs (`serial:///path/to/serial/device[:baudrate][?ids=sysid,compid]` , `serial-hwfc://` , `udp://[bind_host][:port]@[remote_host][:port]`): github.com/mavlink/mavros, docs/connection_urls.md; the schemes also in the installed `/opt/ros/jazzy/include/mavconn/interface.hpp` .
- PX4 parameters in the flight test plan (`GF_ACTION` , `GF_MAX_HOR_DIST` , `GF_MAX_VER_DIST` , `COM_OBL_RC_ACT` , `COM_OF_LOSS_T` , `NAV_RCL_ACT` , `COM_RC_LOSS_T` , `NAV_DLL_ACT` , `COM_DL_LOSS_T` , `BAT_LOW_THR` , `BAT_CRIT_THR` , `BAT_EMERGEN_THR` , `COM_LOW_BAT_ACT` , `RC_MAP_KILL_SW` , `MAN_OVERRIDE_SPD` , `RC_MAP_FLTMODE` , `MPC_XY_VEL_MAX` , `MPC_Z_VEL_MAX_UP` , `MPC_Z_VEL_MAX_DN` , `RTL_RETURN_ALT` , `MAV_SYS_ID` ; the TELEM1 baud parameter comes from the MAVLink serial configuration): their definitions in the PX4 v1.18.0-rc1 source, `src/modules/*/params.yaml` and `src/lib/battery/module.yaml` .
- The PX4 offboard port plan the relay sits in (PX4 listens on 14580+i and sends to 14540+i): `px4-rc.mavlink` , as recorded in `src/swarm_tools/sim_launch.py` .
- The radio drone's link, from the installed PX4 v1.18.0-rc1 source:
- `src/modules/mavlink/module.yaml` : `MAV_0_RATE` default 1200 B/s, "if the configured streams exceed the maximum rate, the sending rate of each stream is automatically decreased"; `MAV_0_MODE` values, 7 = Minimal.
- `mavlink_main.cpp` : `update_rate_mult` , the stream lists of each mode, and the `-m` strings (there is no "normal": Normal is used without `-m`).
- `mavlink` status streams on a running instance: in Normal mode at 1,200 B/s, position arrives at about 1 Hz.
- The PX4 client's `--instance` : `platforms/posix/src/px4/common/main.cpp` .
- MAVLink message IDs and frame sizes (`SET_POSITION_TARGET_LOCAL_NED` 65 B, `TIMESYNC` 30 B, `SYSTEM_TIME` 24 B): `src/modules/mavlink/mavlink/message_definitions/v1.0/common.xml` in the same PX4 tree.
- MAVROS time sync rate: `/opt/ros/jazzy/share/mavros/launch/px4_config.yaml` (`/**/time` , `timesync_rate` : 10.0).

Problems and fixes

- The first stand-in tests counted packets the operating system had dropped (400 sent at once) and timed the second direction when it was read, not when it arrived; the tests now pace their sends and listen on both sockets at once. The relay itself did not change.
- A precaution, not an observed fault: the launcher waits (up to 10 s) until the relay's port is open before it starts that drone's MAVROS, so MAVROS never sends into a port nobody listens on.
- The radio overload of the first attempt: see the section above.
- "Stop now" left the radio relay running.**
- Cause: the queue stops a mission with SIGTERM. `run_mission.py` had no handler for it, so Python exited without its clean-up, and the relay runs in its own session.
- Effect: the next mission's relay could not open its ports, and that mission ran through the old relay.

- Fix, in three parts:
 - `run_mission.py` now runs its normal clean-up on SIGTERM.
 - The queue and the launcher's orphan clean-up also stop relays, matched by their exact module argument (`tests/test_px4_queue.py`).
 - The launcher refuses to start a relay whose ports are already in use.

Known limitations / honest caveats

- The stand-in models the link's rate, transmit turns, loss and buffer, not the radio's framing, retransmissions or signal strength; real loss comes in bursts.
- There is no path in this repository that starts a real drone, on purpose; the flight test plan lists that as a precondition to be reviewed by the owner.
- **A weak point of the election, shown by the first attempt:** a drone that keeps dropping out and coming back takes the lead again each time, as the lowest ID. The spec's rule (lowest alive ID wins) was kept; the fix removes the cause here (the overloaded link). A rule that stops a returning drone from taking the lead at once would change `docs/SPECIFICATION.md` section 6, and Phases 2–5 would have to be repeated. It is noted in `docs/KNOWN_ISSUES.md` for the owner to decide.
- The flight test plan has not been used; its numbers marked *proposal* are starting values.

Next phase: what is needed from the user

The software phase is complete. Real flights need the owner's review of `docs/FLIGHT_TEST_PLAN.md`, the hardware, and legal permission to fly. The election's flapping weak point (above) is the owner's decision.

Appendix H - Scaling test

REPORTS/SCALING.MD

Scaling test — does the swarm logic work for 1 to 100 drones?

Status: PASSED in the fast simulator (not PX4). Date: 2026-09-26. Commit of the code under test: 2291af7.

What was run

`scripts/scale_test.py` flies the default 1 km mission (`config/swarm.yaml`, V formation, 10 m spacing, 30 m, 5 m/s) in the pure-Python simulator (`src/swarm_tools/puresim.py`), which runs the real agent code (`AgentCore`: election, formation, safety) for every drone on point-mass physics. For every $N \geq 2$ the leader (drone 1) is killed at $t = 90$ s, mid-cruise. Three seeds per N.

- Clean: `PYTHONPATH=src python3 scripts/scale_test.py --ns 1 2 3 5 10 20 50 100 --seeds 1 2 3` → `reports/logs/scaling/fastsim_scaling.jsonl` (24 runs)
- Harder radio: same with `--loss-pct 10 --latency-ms 150 --drift 0.15` (10 % of heartbeats lost per link, 150 ms delay + up to 30 ms jitter, 0.15 m/s Gauss-Markov velocity drift) for $N = 10, 50, 100$ → `reports/logs/scaling/fastsim_scaling_radio.jsonl` (9 runs)
- Machine: `reports/logs/scaling/machine.txt` (i3-1115G4, 8 GB, other apps open). Sim speed depends on load.

Definitions: *New leader agreed* = time from the kill until every alive drone follows the same new leader with the same term. *Formation < 2 m after* = time from the kill until formation RMS error is back below 2 m. *Closest pair* = minimum distance between any two airborne drones over the whole flight. *Landed* = mission completed, every flying drone landed, exactly one leader at the end. Values are median (min–max) of 3 runs.

Results — clean radio, no drift

N	New leader agreed (s)	Formation < 2 m after (s)	Closest pair (m)	Cruise RMS max (m)	Landed	Sim speed (× real time)	Heartbeat (B)	Radio load (kbit/s)
1	–	–	–	–	3/3	2459.6 (2321.3–2483.4)	44	1.8
2	1.60 (1.50–1.60)	–	10.00	0.39	3/3	1506.0 (1289.0–1654.6)	44	3.5
3	1.70 (1.60–1.70)	4.75 (4.65–4.75)	9.49	0.73	3/3	818.5 (622.6–848.8)	44	5.3
5	1.70 (1.60–1.70)	4.60 (4.50–4.60)	9.49	0.73	3/3	426.8 (416.8–439.6)	44	8.8
10	1.70 (1.60–1.75)	4.50 (4.40–4.55)	9.49	0.73	3/3	162.1 (160.9–162.2)	45	18.0
20	1.70 (1.70–1.75)	4.60 (4.60–4.65)	9.49	0.73	3/3	57.3 (56.8–57.6)	46	36.8
50	1.75 (1.70–1.75)	4.95 (4.90–4.95)	9.49	0.73	3/3	10.9 (10.8–11.3)	50	100.0
100	1.75 (1.70–1.75)	8.75 (8.70–8.75)	9.49	0.73	3/3	2.9 (2.8–2.9)	56	224.0

Results — 10 % loss, 150 ms delay, drift 0.15 m/s

N	New leader agreed (s)	Formation < 2 m after (s)	Closest pair (m)	Cruise RMS max (m)	Max leaders at once	Leader sequence	Landed	Sim speed (× real time)	Heartbeat (B)	Radio load (kbit/s)
10	2.35 (2.15–2.40)	4.80 (4.65–4.90)	9.15	1.14	1	1→2	3/3	150.4 (147.8–153.5)	45	18.0
50	2.55 (2.55–2.75)	5.70 (5.40–6.30)	8.68	1.11	1	1→2	3/3	10.3 (9.7–10.9)	50	100.0
100	2.75 (2.50–2.95)	9.20 (8.95–9.30)	8.14	1.05	1	1→2	3/3	2.6	56	224.0

All 33 runs completed with every drone landed and exactly one leader at the end; in the harder-radio runs the leader sequence was always 1 → 2 and there were never two leaders at once. Closest approach never went below 8.14 m (limit 5 m). The worst new-leader time was 2.95 s ($N = 100$, harder radio) against the Phase 4 target of 3.0 s median / 4.0 s worst.

What changed to make 100 drones possible

The heartbeat's member list was a 64-bit mask, so the configuration refused more than 63 drones (`ConfigError: drone IDs must be within 1..63`, checked before the change). The mask is now sent with only as many bytes as the highest drone ID needs; IDs run 1..250, the PX4 `MAV_SYS_ID` range (`src/modules/mavlink/mavlink_params.yaml` in PX4 v1.18.0-rc1: min 1, max 250). Heartbeat size: 44 B for up to 7 drones, 45 B for 10, 50 B for 50, 56 B for 100, 75 B for 250 (`tests/test_heartbeat.py`).

Honest limits

- **Simplified physics.** This is the point-mass simulator, not PX4. PX4 SIH on this laptop stays at 10 drones (Phase 1: 77 % CPU at 10; PX4's default port plan in `px4-rc.mavlink` covers 10 instances).
- **Simulator cost grows with N^2 .** Every drone checks every other drone: 162× real time at 10 drones, 2.9× at 100 (clean runs).
- **Radio load grows with N.** Heartbeats go to every drone, 5 per second: 18 kbit/s at 10 drones, 224 kbit/s at 100 (payload only, before framing). ArduPilot's SiK radio documentation gives a default air rate of 64 kbit/s, a maximum of 250, and usable throughput of about 90 % of the air rate (half with error correction): <https://ardupilot.org/copter/docs/common-3dr-radio-advanced-configuration-and-technical-information.html>
- **One V for 100 drones is impractical.** Each arm is about 490 m long and the last drones land 490 m from the target. Big swarms should fly as squads (for example ten groups of ten, each with its own leader).
- The formation takes longer to recover at 100 drones (8.75 s clean, 9.2 s harder radio) because every drone on one arm shifts one slot when the leader's successor moves to the tip; still inside the 15 s Phase 4 target.

Appendix I - Project specification

DOCS/SPECIFICATION.MD

Swarm Failover — Project specification

The specification this project was built against: goals, hard rules, phases and acceptance criteria. Section and rule numbers quoted in the code and the reports (for example §6 or rule 3a) refer to this document.

1. Goal

Build, on this laptop only, a simulated swarm of PX4 quadrotors that flies in V formation from home to a goal waypoint. One drone is MASTER. If the master fails (killed, link lost, or low battery), the lowest-ID alive drone becomes master within seconds and the swarm continues to the goal.

The architecture must later run unchanged against real Pixhawk 6C drones: switching a drone from simulated to real must only require changing its connection URL in config.

In scope: waypoint navigation, formation, leader election / failover, inter-drone separation, geofence, fault injection, metrics. **Out of scope:** payloads, targeting, or any logic that engages objects.

2. Environment (VERIFY in Phase 0 — do not assume)

- Laptop: Lenovo IdeaPad 5, Intel i3 11th gen, 8 GB RAM, no GPU
- OS: Ubuntu 24.04, ROS 2 (expected: Jazzy), Python 3.12
- Simulator: PX4 SIH running as SITL (headless, no Gazebo). Build target: `px4_sitl_sih`
- Drone link: MAVROS, one instance per drone (NOT uXRCE-DDS), because real drones will use MAVLink over low-bandwidth telemetry radios.
- User is on mobile most of the time and is notified via ntfy (see §4).

3. Hard rules (apply to every phase)

- Verify before use.** Every PX4 parameter, make target, MAVROS topic/service, ROS 2 command, and package name must be confirmed from official docs (docs.px4.io, docs.ros.org, github.com/mavlink/mavros) OR from the installed system (`ros2 topic list`, `ros2 interface show`, `param show`, reading source). Record the source (URL or command) in the phase report. If you cannot verify something, say so — never guess.
- Evidence or it didn't happen.** Never report success without command output, a test result, or a metrics file. Put raw logs in `reports/logs/phase_N/`.
- Cross-check at phase end.** Before reporting a phase done: a. Kill all sim processes (`kill -f px4`; `kill -f mavros`), open a fresh shell, re-run the phase's acceptance tests from scratch. b. Re-read this file's acceptance criteria line by line and mark each PASS/FAIL with evidence. c. Confirm every number in the report matches the raw logs.
- Phase gates.** After each phase: write `reports/PHASE_N.md`, commit, tag `phase-N`, send the notification, then STOP and wait for the user to type `continue`. Do not start the next phase on your own.
- Stuck rule.** If the same error survives 3 fix attempts, stop, notify (priority high), and write what you tried and what you suspect in the report.
- Resource guard.** Build with `-j2` max. Check `free -m` before launching sims; if available memory < 800 MB, reduce drone count and report it. Kill orphan `px4/mavros` processes between runs.
- Safety.** Simulation only. Never open serial devices (`/dev/tty*`), never connect to a real flight controller, never flash firmware.
- Ask first** before: any `sudo`, `apt/pip` installs, deleting files outside this repo, or changing an architecture decision in this file (e.g., replacing MAVROS).
- Code standards.** Python 3.12, rclpy, type hints, all tunables in `config/swarm.yaml` (no hardcoded ports/IDs), pure-Python logic modules (election, formation, geometry) importable and testable WITHOUT ROS.

4. Notifications (user's phone via ntfy)

Send with: `scripts/notify.sh "<title>" "<message>" [priority]` - Title must be plain ASCII (it is an HTTP header). Emojis only in the message. - Phase done: `scripts/notify.sh "Phase N PASSED" "<1-line key result>". Waiting for continue."` - Phase failed / stuck: same format, title `Phase N FAILED`, priority `high`. - Long run (> 20 min) started: one message with the ETA. - In Phase 0, send a test message and ask the user to confirm it arrived.

5. Mission defaults (`config/swarm.yaml`)

Setting	Value
Drones (target)	10 (start with 3, scale in Phase 1)
Formation	V, 10 m spacing between neighbors
Cruise altitude / speed	30 m AGL / 5 m/s
Goal	single point ~1 km from home, loaded into every drone before takeoff
Heartbeat	5 Hz, each drone broadcasts: id, role, term, position, velocity, battery, timestamp
Master dead after	1.5 s without its heartbeat
Election rule	lowest alive ID wins; <code>term</code> counter resolves conflicts (see §6)
Low-battery handover	master hands over voluntarily at 30 %, then leaves formation and returns home
Min separation (hard)	5 m between any two drones
Geofence	1.5 km radius from home, 50 m max altitude
Setpoint stream	velocity setpoints at 20 Hz (PX4 drops offboard if the stream falls below 2 Hz — verify in docs)

6. Architecture

- **One `swarm_agent` node per drone** (namespace `/uavN`) talking to its own MAVROS instance. There is NO central controller node — each agent decides its own role, so the same code can later run onboard each drone.
- Central tools allowed only for: launching, fault injection, link emulation, logging.
- **Heartbeat transport goes through a `link_emulator` node**: agents publish to `/uavN/hb_out`, the emulator forwards to every other `/uavM/hb_in` with configurable loss/latency per link. This is how "link lost" faults and radio-like conditions are simulated.
- **Election**: each agent keeps `term`. A drone that becomes master increments `term`. On receiving a master heartbeat with a higher `term` (or equal `term` and lower ID), a master steps down. After a partition heals there must be exactly one master.
- **Formation**: follower slot = rank among alive drones sorted by ID. Slot offset is rotated into the master's heading. Follower command = master velocity (feedforward)
- P-control on position error; saturated; add a repulsion term when any neighbor is closer than $1.5 \times$ min separation.
- **Frames — critical**: every drone's MAVROS local frame has its own origin. NEVER compare drones' local positions directly. Convert each drone's global position (lat/lon/alt) to one shared ENU frame anchored at `config.origin`. Unit-test this.
- **No master heard and no election result yet**: hold position (hover).
- **At goal**: swarm hovers 10 s, then all drones land.

7. Phases

Phase 0 — Environment audit and setup

Tasks: - Record OS, `$ROS_DISTRO`, RAM, CPU cores, free disk (need ≥ 15 GB), Python version. - Test `ntfy` (`scripts/notify.sh "Phase 0" "Test message"`) and ask user to confirm. - Install (ask first): PX4-Autopilot toolchain for Ubuntu 24.04 per docs.px4.io, MAVROS for the installed ROS 2 distro, and the GeographicLib datasets MAVROS requires. - Build `px4_sitl_sih` for quadrotor (-j2). - Create repo skeleton: `config/`, `src/swarm_agent/`, `tests/`, `scripts/`, `reports/`. Acceptance: - One SIH drone + one MAVROS instance: script arms, takes off to 10 m, hovers 20 s, lands. Evidence: log with altitude over time. - Peak RAM for 1 drone (PX4 + MAVROS) measured and recorded.

Phase 1 — Multi-drone simulation scaling

Tasks: - Launch script for N SIH instances + N MAVROS instances with unique ports/sysids (verify the multi-instance method in PX4 docs). - Verify spawn positions. If instances spawn at the same point, give each a distinct home position using the documented method, and cite it. - Scale $3 \rightarrow 5 \rightarrow 10$. At each step measure RAM and CPU. Acceptance: - All N drones arm, take off to 10 m, hover 30 s, and land, with no crashes. - Report: max stable N on this laptop with RAM/CPU numbers. If $N < 10$, state it plainly and propose options (e.g., lighter MAVLink bridge) — do not switch without approval.

Phase 2 — Agent logic (pure Python, no ROS) + unit tests

Tasks: - Modules: `geometry` (global $\rightarrow$ shared ENU), `election` (state machine + `term`), `formation` (V slots, rotation, rank reassignment), `safety` (separation, geofence). - Pure-Python swarm simulator (point-mass, no PX4) to exercise election + formation fast. Acceptance: - `pytest` all green; coverage $\geq 90\%$ on election and formation modules. - 1,000 randomized pure-Python runs (random kills, random link drops, partitions): exactly one master after convergence in 100 % of runs; median convergence time reported.

Phase 3 — ROS 2 integration: formation flight, no faults

Tasks: - `swarm_agent` node wrapping the Phase 2 modules; `link_emulator` node (loss = 0); launch file; logger node writing CSV (positions, roles, terms, timestamps). - Metrics script: formation RMS error, min pairwise separation, time to goal. Acceptance (3 runs at max stable N): - All drones reach goal and land. - Formation RMS error < 2 m during cruise. - Min separation ≥ 5 m at all times. - Plot of trajectories saved to `reports/`.

Phase 4 — Failover under faults

Faults (fault injector node/script): - F1 master killed (kill its PX4 + MAVROS processes) - F2 master link lost (emulator drops 100 % of master heartbeats) - F3 master low battery (use PX4's simulated battery drain if verifiable in docs; otherwise inject battery value at the agent level and say so in the report) - F4 follower killed (no election expected; slots reassign) - F5 partition then heal (two groups, then reconnect) Acceptance (10 trials per fault, random fault time during cruise): - F1/F2: new master heartbeat within 3.0 s median (4.0 s worst case) of failure. - F3: planned handover within 1.0 s of trigger; old master leaves and returns home. - F4: no master change; formation recovers. - F5: single master within 3.0 s after heal. - All: formation RMS back under 2 m within 15 s (F5: 20 s, set by the owner on 28 September 2026); min separation never < 5 m; goal reached in $\geq 9/10$ trials per fault. - Report table: per fault — median/worst handover time, recovery time, min separation, success rate.

Phase 5 — Radio realism (telemetry-like links)

Tasks: - Sweep link emulator: latency {50, 150, 300} ms $\times$ loss {0, 10, 30} %. - Measure: false failovers (master change without a real fault), handover time, formation error. Acceptance: - Results table + plot. Identify the worst condition where Phase 4 criteria still hold. - Zero false failovers at $\leq 10\%$ loss; if not, report and propose timeout/heartbeat changes.

Phase 6 — Mixed-reality readiness (still software only)

Tasks: - `config/profiles/`: `sim.yaml` and `mixed.yaml` (example: drone 1 real via serial URL placeholder, drones 2–N SIH). Do NOT open the serial port — validate config only. - Hardware stand-in test: run one SIH drone through a UDP proxy that limits bandwidth and adds latency/loss like a telemetry radio; the swarm must still pass Phase 4 F1 and F2. - Write `FLIGHT_TEST_PLAN.md`: 1 real + N virtual drones, geofence, RC override on every real drone, kill-switch procedure, go/no-go checklist, abort criteria. - Write `README.md`: setup, how to run each phase, results summary, known limitations. Acceptance: - Stand-in test passes F1 and F2 criteria. - Everything reproducible from a fresh clone with the README. - FINAL STOP. Notify: "Software phase complete. Real-drone work needs user review."

8. Phase report template (`reports/PHASE_N.md`)

```
# Phase N - <name>
Status: PASSED / FAILED
## Acceptance criteria
- [PASS/FAIL] <criterion> - evidence: <file/command/number>
## Key numbers
## Sources verified (URLs / commands)
## Problems and fixes
## Known limitations / honest caveats
## Next phase: what is needed from the user (if anything)
```